MONTHLY CURRENT AFFAIRS MAGAZINE

MARCH 2026

- Detailed release for all exams
- Static GK points included
- Category-wise Compilation
- Live Table of Content

Contents

Important Days **4**
Books **14**
Appointments **15**
Award **20**
National 20
International 26
Obituaries **30**
National **31**
Eminent Personalities in News **56**
State Specific News **57**
Jammu & Kashmir 57
Himachal Pradesh 58
Uttarakhand 58
Punjab 60
Haryana 61
Delhi 61
Uttar Pradesh 63
Bihar 65
Jharkhand 65
Chhattisgarh 66
Chandigarh 66
Odisha 66
West Bengal 67
Sikkim 68
Assam 68
Nagaland 69
Manipur 70
Mizoram 70
Rajasthan 70
Gujarat 72
Maharashtra 73
Goa 76
Telangana 76
Andhra Pradesh 77
Karnataka 78
Kerala 79
Tamil Nadu 80
Defence **82**

Science and Technology **93**
Environment **100**
Index **110**
International **117**
Sports **130**
Khelo India Games 130
National / International Championship 131
Cricket 133
Football 135
Tennis 135
Badminton 135
Table tennis 136
Chess 136
Grand Prix 136
Squash 136
Basketball 136
Athletics 137
Miscellaneous 137
Banking **139**

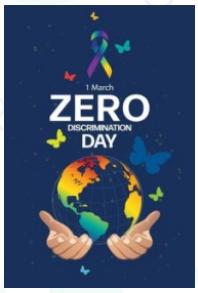
Important Days

Date	Day	Theme
1st March	Zero Discrimination Day	
1st March	World Civil Defence Day	Managing Environmental Risks for a Resilient and Sustainable Future
1st March	World Seagrass Day	
3rd March	World Wildlife Day	Medicinal and Aromatic Plants: Conserving Health, Heritage and Livelihoods
3rd March	World Hearing Day	From communities to classrooms: hearing care for all children
4th March	National Safety Day	Engage, Educate & Empower People to Enhance Safety
4th March	World Engineering Day for Sustainable Development	Smart engineering for sustainable future through innovation and digitalization
4th March	World Obesity Day	8 Billion Reasons to Act on Obesity
5th March	International Day for Disarmament and Non-Proliferation Awareness	
7th March	Jan Aushadhi Diwas	Janaushadhi Sasti Bhi, Bharosemand Bhi, Sehat Ki Baat, Bachat Ke Saath
8th March	International Women's Day	Rights. Justice. Action. For ALL Women and Girls
10th March	CISF Raising Day	
10th March	International Day of Women Judges	Women Judges on the Bench and Beyond: Protecting Access to Justice
12th March	Mauritius Day	
12th March	Dandi March Anniversary	
12th March	World Kidney Day	
13th March	World Sleep Day	
14th March	International Mathematics Day	Mathematics and hope
14th March	Pi Day	
14th March	International Day of Action for Rivers	Protect Rivers, Protect People
15th March	World Consumer Rights Day	Safe Products, Confident Consumers
15th March	International Day to Combat Islamophobia	
16th March	National Vaccination Day	Immunization for All is Humanly Possible
17th March	Narcotics Control Bureau Raising Day	
18th March	Ordnance Factories Day (India)	
20th March	World Sparrow Day	
20th March	International Day of Happiness	
20th March	French Language Day	
20th March	World Oral Health Day	A Happy Mouth is a Happy Life

21st March	International Day of Nowruz	
21st March	World Puppetry Day	
21st March	World Day For Glaciers	
21st March	World Down Syndrome Day	Theme : Together Against Loneliness
21st March	International Day for the Elimination of Racial Discrimination	Mobilizing political will: 60 years of commemorating the International Day for the Elimination of Racial Discrimination
21st March	World Poetry Day	
21st – 27th March	Week of Solidarity with the Peoples Struggling against Racism and Racial Discrimination	
21st March	International Day of Forests	Forests and economies
22nd March	World Water Day	Water and Gender
23rd March	World Meteorological Day [WMO]	Observing Today, Protecting Tomorrow
23rd March	Martyrs' Day/ Shaheed Diwas	
23rd March	World Bear Day	Protecting Habitats, Preserving Sentience
24th March	World Tuberculosis (TB) Day	'Yes! We can end TB!'
25th March	International Day of Remembrance of the Victims of Slavery and the Transatlantic Slave Trade	Justice in Action: Confronting History, Advancing Dignity, Empowering Futures
25th March	International Day of the Unborn Child	
25th March	National Genocide Day (Bangladesh)	
26th March	Anniversary of the Chipko Movement	
26th March	Purple Day of Epilepsy	
27th March	World Theatre Day	
30th March	International Day of Zero Waste	Food Waste
31st March	Eiffel Tower Day	

WITH STATIC

1 March Zero Discrimination Day

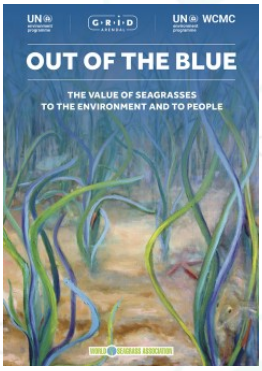


- Celebrate the right of everyone to live a full and productive life—and live it with dignity.
- Zero Discrimination Day highlights how people can become informed about and promote inclusion, compassion, peace and, above all, a movement for change.

1 March World Civil Defence Day

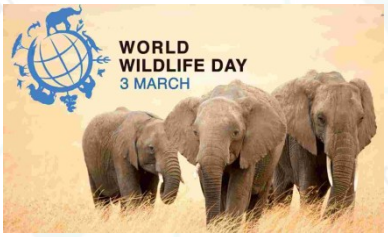
- To bringing issues to light about the significance of civil defence measures in shielding individuals and their property from natural disasters, accidents, and different crises.
- The United Nations established the International Civil Defence Organisation; an association committed to internationally facilitate and promote civil defence attempts.
- In 1990, World Civil Defence Day was declared by the International Civil Defence Organisation
- THEME : “Managing Environmental Risks for a Resilient and Sustainable Future”

March 1 World Seagrass Day



- In May 2022, the General Assembly adopted proclaiming 1 March as World Seagrass Day.
- Seagrasses are marine flowering plants that are found in shallow waters in many parts of the world, from the tropics to the Arctic circle.
- Covering only 0.1% of the ocean floor, these seagrass meadows provide food and shelter to thousands of species of fish, seahorses, turtles, etc. and sustain some of the world’s largest fisheries
- It was recently noted that 21% of seagrass species are categorized as Near Threatened, Vulnerable and Endangered Species under the International Union for Conservation of Nature Red List of Threatened Species .

March 3 - World Wildlife Day



- Declared by United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) on 20th December 2013
- This day holds significance as the day that the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES) was signed in 1973.
- THEME: “Medicinal and Aromatic Plants: Conserving Health, Heritage and Livelihoods”

March 3 - World Hearing Day

- To raise awareness on how to prevent deafness and hearing loss and promote ear and hearing care across the world.
- The theme - "From communities to classrooms: hearing care for all children”

March 4 - National Safety Day

- National Safety Council (NSC) was set up by the Ministry of Labour, Government of India (GOI) on 4th March, 1966 to generate, develop and sustain a voluntary movement on Safety, Health and Environment (SHE) at the national level .
- The National Safety Week is celebrated from March 4 to March 10, 2025.
- National Safety Day/Safety Week Campaign being spearheaded by the Council since 1971.
- Theme: "Engage, Educate & Empower People to Enhance Safety."

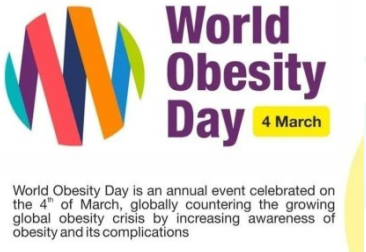
4th March World Engineering Day for Sustainable Development

- In November 2019, UNESCO proclaimed the World Engineering Day for Sustainable Development (WED) at its 40th General Conference.
- It is celebrated worldwide on March 4 each year since 2020.
- the theme is “Smart engineering for sustainable future through innovation and digitalization”

Adani Group Partners UNESCO For World Engineering Day 2026

- The Adani Group has been named an official partner for the World Engineering Day for Sustainable Development (WED) 2026.
- World Engineering Day for Sustainable Development is observed annually on 4 March.
- The international observance is recognised by UNESCO and delivered by the World Federation of Engineering Organizations (WFEO).
- This marks the first time an Indian organisation has been selected

4th March World Obesity Day

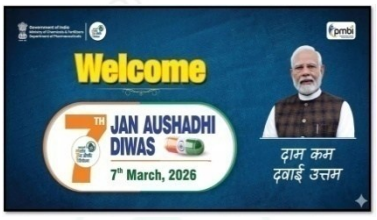


- World Obesity Day has been observed globally on the 4th of March every year from 2020
- theme is "8 Billion Reasons to Act on Obesity"

5 March - International Day for Disarmament and Non-Proliferation Awareness

- The International Day for Disarmament and Non-Proliferation Awareness seeks to promote better awareness and understanding of disarmament issues among the public, especially young people.

7th March Jan Aushadhi Diwas



- To raise awareness about the scheme and promote the use of generic medicines.
- Theme: “Janaushadhi Sasti Bhi, Bharosemand Bhi, Sehat Ki Baat, Bachat Ke Saath,”
- The "Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP)" aim to make available quality medicines, consumables and surgical items at affordable prices for all and reduce out of pocket expenditure of consumers/patients.
- Jan Aushadhi Scheme was launched by the Department of Pharmaceuticals in 2008 across the country by the Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers, in collaboration with Central Pharma Public Sector Undertakings.
- In 2015, the Jan Aushadhi Scheme was revamped as Pradhan Mantri Jan Aushadhi Yojana (PMJAY).
- In 2016, it was again renamed as Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP).

March 8 - International Women's Day

- Theme “Rights. Justice. Action. For ALL Women and Girls.”
- A global campaign theme,’ Give to Gain’.
- Officially recognized by the United Nations in 1977
- The celebrations also coincide with the 30th anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, a historic blueprint adopted in 1995 by 189 governments to promote gender equality and women's rights.
- It was adopted in 1995 at the Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing, China.

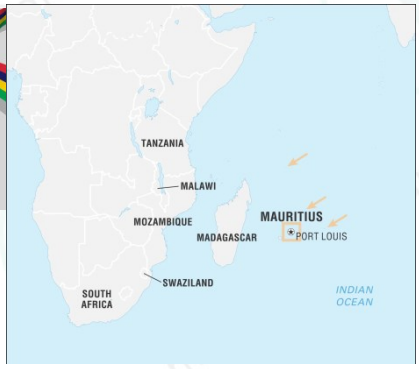
10th March CISF Raising Day

- Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) established in 1969 to protect sensitive public sector undertakings.
- It was set up under an Act of the Parliament of India on 10 March 1969 with a strength of 2,800.
- It is directly under the Union Ministry of Home Affairs
- The CISF was created in response to a fire at the Heavy Engineering Corporation (HEC) in Ranchi in 1964.
- The Justice Mukherjee Commission was appointed to investigate the fire, which found sabotage and recommended the creation of a central industrial security force.
- It was decided in 2019 that instead of celebrating the CISF Raising Day in Delhi, it would be celebrated in different parts of the country.
- CISF Director General Shri Shri Praveer Ranjan

10th March International Day of Women Judges

- THEME :Women Judges on the Bench and Beyond: Protecting Access to Justice

March 12 - Mauritius Day



- Mauritius celebrates its National Day annually on March 12, marking its independence from British rule in 1968.
- The day also signifies the nation's transition to a republic within the Commonwealth in 1992.
- It is an island country in the Indian Ocean, located off the eastern coast of Africa.
- Mauritius Capital: Port Louis.

Dandi March Anniversary - 12th March, 1930

- The Dandi March, also known as the Salt March and the Dandi Satyagraha was an act of nonviolent civil disobedience led by Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi.
- The march lasted from 12th March, 1930 to 6th April, 1930 as a direct action campaign of tax resistance and nonviolent protest against the British salt monopoly.
- On 12th March, Gandhiji set out from Sabarmati with 78 followers on a 241-mile march to the coastal town of Dandi on the Arabian Sea.
- There, Gandhi and his supporters were to defy British policy by making salt from seawater.
- At Dandi, thousands more followed his lead, and in the coastal cities of Bombay and Karachi, Indian nationalists led crowds of citizens in making salt.

13th March World Sleep Day

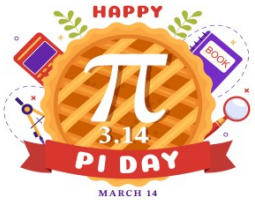
12 March World Kidney Day

- Celebrated on the 2nd Thursday in the month of March every year since 2006.
- This year 2026, World Kidney Day is observed on Thursday, 12th March.
- Theme is "Kidney Health for All: Caring for People, Protecting the Planet.".

March 14 - International Mathematics Day

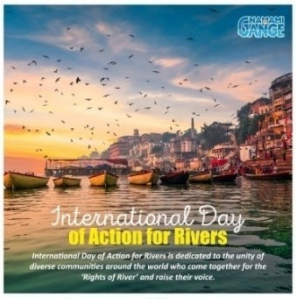
- The day was officially proclaimed by United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) during the organisation's 40th General Conference in November 2019,
- the first official International Day of Mathematics was celebrated on March 14, 2020
- The theme for International Mathematics Day 2026 is "Mathematics and hope." The date corresponds with Pi Day.
- India also celebrates National Mathematics Day on December 22.
- The day commemorates the birth anniversary of Indian mathematician Srinivasa Ramanujan.

14 March Pi Day



- Pi Day is an annual celebration of the mathematical constant π which is approximately 3.14159
- Pi Day is observed on March 14 since 3, 1, and 4 are the first three significant figures of π
- First celebrated in 1988 by physicist Larry Shaw at the San Francisco Exploratorium.
- In 2009, the United States House of Representatives designated March 14 as Pi Day.
- Mathematician and physicist Albert Einstein, known for the "General Theory Of Relativity," was born on Pi Day in 1879.

14 March International Day of Action for Rivers



- A day dedicated to solidarity – with one voice to say that our rivers matter.
- Theme - Protect Rivers, Protect People.
- The International Day of Action for Rivers has its roots in the First International Meeting of People Impacted by Dams, held in Curitiba, Brazil, in March 1997.

15 March World Consumer Rights Day

- Celebrated for the first time in 1983 as a mark of anniversary of the former U.S. President John F. Kennedy's speech to the US Congress on March 15, 1962, where he became the first world leader to formally recognize consumer rights.
- Theme : "Safe Products, Confident Consumers"
- Organizers : Consumers International and its partners worldwide, such as the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution in India.
- India celebrates National Consumer Rights Day on 24th December every year to raise awareness about consumer rights and responsibilities.
- The day commemorates the day when the Consumer Protection Act 1986 received the President's assent on December 24, 1986.

15 March International Day to Combat Islamophobia

- Designated by United Nations in 2022
- Islamophobia is a fear, prejudice and hatred of Muslims that leads to provocation, hostility and intolerance, both in the online and offline world.
- The United Nations General Assembly adopted a resolution sponsored by 60 Member-States of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), which designated 15 March as the International Day to Combat Islamophobia.

March 16 National Vaccination Day

- To acknowledge and appreciate the hard work of frontline health care workers to ensure the vaccination of every child.
- National Vaccination Day was celebrated for the first time on 16 March, 1995.
- The theme - “Immunization for All is Humanly Possible”.
- This day commemorates the initiation of the Pulse Polio Immunisation Programme in 1995.
- India was declared polio-free by WHO in 2014
- World Immunization Day on November 10

March 18 - Ordnance Factories Day (India)

- Ordnance Factory Day is celebrated on 18th March every year in India as a mark of establishing the first Ordnance Factory in India in 1801 in Cossipore, Kolkata.
- The day commemorates the efforts and contributions of the Ordnance Factories in India that strengthens the defense capabilities in India.
- The Ordnance Factory Board established in 1979, manages the defense production in India.

March 17 Narcotics Control Bureau Raising Day

- It is the nodal drug law enforcement and intelligence agency under the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India.
- It came into effect on 14th November, 1985, under the provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985 (NDPS Act).
- Headquarters: New Delhi
- A dedicated agency was formally constituted through a government notification on March 17, 1986.
- Liaison with International agencies such as UNDCP, INCB, INTERPOL, Customs Cooperation Council, RILO etc.

20th March World Sparrow Day

- World Sparrow Day was initiated by "Nature Forever," a bird conservation organization in 2010.
- The aim was to raise awareness about the declining sparrow population.
- In 2012, the house sparrow became Delhi's state bird.
- Known by various names such as "Goraiya" in Hindi, "Kuruvi" in Tamil and "Chirya" in Urdu

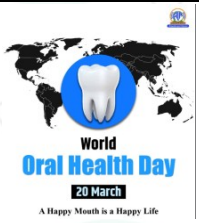
20th March International Day of Happiness

- The General Assembly of the United Nations in its resolution of 12 July 2012 proclaimed 20 March the International Day of Happiness.

20th March French Language Day

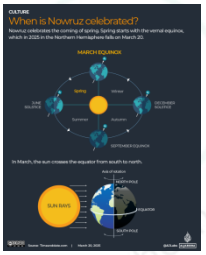
- On March 20th, the United Nations celebrates French Language Day.
- This is one of the six official languages celebrated by the UN each year.
- 6 official languages of the UN, namely Arabic, Chinese, English, French, Russian and Spanish.

20th March - World Oral Health Day



- Theme : A Happy Mouth is a Happy Life

21st March International Nowruz Day

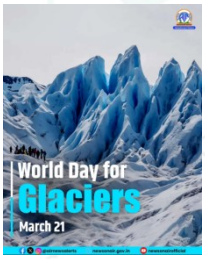


- The Parsi New Year Nowruz, also spelled Novruz, Navruz, Nooruz, Nevruz, or Nauryz.
- Meaning “new day” in Persian, is far more than just the start of a new year—it is an ancient celebration of life, rebirth, and the triumph of light over darkness.
- With roots extending back over 3,000 years to the era of Zoroastrianism, Nowruz heralds the arrival of spring and is celebrated on the day of the vernal equinox, usually March 20 or 21.
- In 2010, the United Nations General Assembly proclaimed March 21 as the International Day of Nowruz, encouraging global celebrations that highlight the festival's themes of peace, unity, and renewal.
- UNESCO inscribed Navroz on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2016, following an initial inscription in 2009.

21st March World Puppetry Day

- The UNESCO has declared March 21st as the World Puppetry Day for the promotion of puppetry art.

21st March - World Day For Glaciers



- The United Nations declared 2025 as the International Year of Glaciers' Preservation.
- Proclaimed 21st March of each year as the World Day for Glaciers starting in 2025.

21st March - World Down Syndrome Day

- Theme : Together Against Loneliness
- Observed by United Nations since 2012

About Down Syndrome:

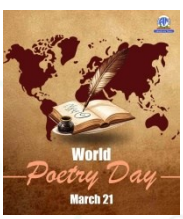
- People with Down syndrome have an extra copy of chromosome 21. In some cases, they may have an extra copy of a part of the chromosome.
- Chromosomes are tiny "packages" in your cells that contain your genes.
- Having an extra copy of a chromosome is called a trisomy. So sometimes Down syndrome is also called trisomy 21.
- This extra copy changes how a baby's body and brain develop.
- Down syndrome is a lifelong condition and it cannot be cured.
  Early therapy programs can help improve skills.

21st – 27th March Week of Solidarity with the Peoples Struggling against Racism and Racial Discrimination

21st March International Day for the Elimination of Racial Discrimination

- Theme - Mobilizing political will: 60 years of commemorating the International Day for the Elimination of Racial Discrimination
- On December 21, 1965, the United Nations General Assembly adopted it

21st March World Poetry Day



- UNESCO first adopted 21 March as World Poetry Day during its 30th General Conference in Paris in 1999.

21st March - International Day of Forests

- Theme - Forests and economies
- Every year on March 21, the world celebrates the International Day of Forests to celebrate all types of forests, recognize the importance of trees and forests, and take action to protect them.
- UNGA proclaimed March 21 as the International Day of Forests in November 2012, with the first official celebration taking place in 2013
- As per 'India State of Forest Report 2023' - The Forest and Tree cover of the country is 8,27,357 sq km which is 25.17 percent of the geographical area of the country, consisting of 7,15,343 sq km (21.76%) as forest cover
- Area wise top three states having largest forest cover are Madhya Pradesh (77,073 sq km) followed by Arunachal Pradesh (65,882 sq km) and Chhattisgarh (55,812 sq km).

Constitutional Provisions:

- Forests are included in the Concurrent List in the (Seventh Schedule) of the Constitution of India.
- Through the 42nd Amendment Act, 1976 Forests and Protection of Wild Animals and Birds were transferred from State to Concurrent List.
- Article 51 A (g) of the Constitution states that it shall be the fundamental duty of every citizen to protect and improve the natural environment including forests and Wildlife.
- Article 48 A in the Directive Principles of State policy, mandates that the State shall endeavor to protect and improve the environment and to safeguard the forests and wildlife of the country.

Green India Mission

- Started in the FY 2015-16.
- Expand forest/tree cover by 5 million hectares (mha) and improve the quality of another 5 mha of forest and non-forest land.
- Boost ecosystem services like carbon storage, water management, and biodiversity.
- Improve livelihoods for 3 million households by increasing income from forest-based activities.

Van Dhan Yojana

- Launched in 2018 by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs and TRIFED, the Pradhan Mantri Van Dhan Yojana (PMVDY) aims to improve the livelihood of tribal communities by enhancing the value of forest produce.

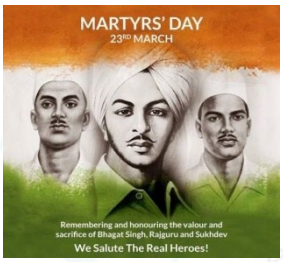
22nd March – World Water Day

- To raise awareness about the importance of freshwater and advocate for the sustainable management of freshwater resources.
- Theme - Water and Gender
- Declared in 1992 at the United Nations Conference on Environment and Development (UNCED) in Rio de Janerio And then, in 1993 the first World Water Day is celebrated.

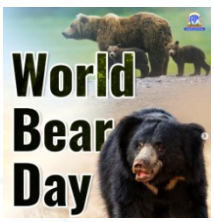
23rd March World Meteorological Day [WMO]

- Commemorates the establishing of World Meteorological Organization on 23 March 1950.
- Theme- Observing Today, Protecting Tomorrow
- WMO is headquartered in Geneva, Switzerland.
- Secretary-General: Professor Celeste Saulo

23rd March Martyrs' Day/ Shaheed Diwas



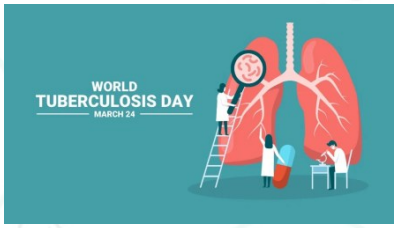
- To commemorate the execution of Bhagat Singh, Shivaram Rajguru and Sukhdev Thapar.
- The three revolutionary freedom fighters were hanged on this day in 1931 for his involvement in the killing of British officer John Saunders.
- Bhagat Singh, Rajguru, and Sukhdev were all members of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA)
- Bhagat Singh popularised the slogan of 'Inquilab Zindabad'
- BOOK: "Why I Am An Atheist"



23rd March World Bear Day

- Theme: "Protecting Habitats, Preserving Sentience"

24th March - World Tuberculosis (TB) Day

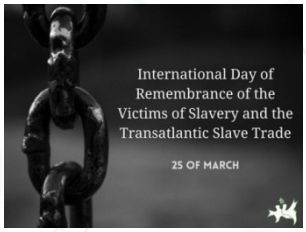


- To commemorate the date when Dr. Robert Koch announced his discovery of Mycobacterium tuberculosis, the bacillus that causes TB in 1882.
- This Day is observed to educate people about TB, its impact around the world.
- Theme – 'Yes! We can end TB!'

About Tuberculosis (TB)

- Tuberculosis (TB) is a contagious bacterial infection.
- It mainly affects the lungs, but it can affect any part of the body, including the tummy (abdomen), glands, bones and nervous system.
- TB is a potentially serious condition, but it can be cured if it's treated with the right antibiotics.

25th March International Day of Remembrance of the Victims of Slavery and the Transatlantic Slave Trade



- Recognized and designated by the United Nations General Assembly In 2006
- Observed first time in March 2007
- The Abolition of the Slave Trade Act was passed in the United Kingdom on 25 March 1807.
- THEME: Justice in Action: Confronting History, Advancing Dignity, Empowering Futures.

25th March International Day of the Unborn Child

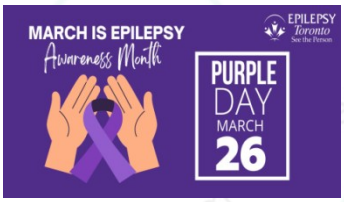
25th March : National Genocide Day (Bangladesh)

- On 11th March 2017, the Jatiya Sangsad unanimously passed a resolution designating 25 March as a Genocide Remembrance Day
- To mark the brutal killing of millions of Bangladeshis of the then East Pakistan on 25th March in 1971.
- The Pakistani army, under the leadership of Yahya Khan, launched 'Operation Searchlight' on 25 March all over East Pakistan who were demanding freedom under East Pakistan' Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Awami League because of the language and cultural differences between the two regions.
- This resulted in millions of Bangladeshis fleeing to India, mainly West Bengal, Assam, Meghalaya and Tripura.
- The Bangladesh War of Independence started on 26 March 1971 and ended on 16 December 1971.
- Bangladesh marks 55th Independence Day on 26 March, 2025. It commemorates the country's declaration of independence from Pakistan in the early hours of 26 March 1971.

26th March - Anniversary of the Chipko Movement

- The Chipko movement, a pivotal environmental protest against deforestation, began on March 26, 1973
- It was a non-violent protest that began in the Chamoli district of Uttarakhand (then Uttar Pradesh), India, in 1973.
- Led by environmental activists such as Sundarlal Bahuguna and Gaura Devi, among others, the movement aimed to prevent the felling of trees in the Himalayan region.
- The name "Chipko" comes from the Hindi word meaning "embrace," as villagers hugged the trees to prevent their cutting.
- The original Chipko movement dates back to 1730 when Amrita Devi Bishnoi and over 300 others from the Bishnoi sect sacrificed their lives protesting the felling of Khejarli trees in Rajasthan.

26th March - Purple Day of Epilepsy



- Purple Day is an international grassroots effort dedicated to increasing awareness about epilepsy worldwide
- Epilepsy is a chronic brain disorder caused by abnormal electrical activity in the brain, leading to seizures—brief episodes of involuntary movement and loss of consciousness.
- It is recognised by the WHO as a neurological disorder.

27th March World Theatre Day

30 March International Day of Zero Waste

- On 14 December 2022, the United Nations General Assembly adopted a resolution at its seventy-seventh session to proclaim 30 March as International Day of Zero Waste
- The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) and the United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat) jointly facilitate the observance of International Day of Zero Waste.
- Theme: Food Waste

31 March Eiffel Tower Day

- To commemorate the opening of the Eiffel Tower in 1889.
- Designed by French engineer Gustave Eiffel

Books

Book	Author	Remark
The Other Half of the Coconut: Women Writing Self-Respect History	Edited by K. Srilata	
That's a Fire Ant Right There	Mohammed Khadeer Babu	Translated into English by D.V. Subhashri
Mahatma: A Great Communicator	Dr Dhiraj Kakadia	
An Accidental Lawyer: My Adventures in Law and Life	K.K. Venugopal co-authored with Advocate Suhasini Sen	The former Attorney General K.K. Venugopal – biography, talks about himself in the book as to how he was an "accidental lawyer".
The Wealth of Nations	Adam Smith	
The Corpse Collector: A True Story (memoir)	Vinu P. and Niyas Kareem	Translated from Malayalam into English - by Ministhy S
Theo of Golden	Allen Levi	
Bharat 2026 – A Reference Annual		The Publications Division, Ministry of Information & Broadcasting, Government of India, released with Four-Colour Design, Updated Data and Enhanced Readability
Karuna: The Power of Compassion	Kailash Satyarthi	
People of Gopallapuram	Ki. Rajanarayanan	Translator Shubashree Desikan

Appointments

Appointments(IN TABLE)

Person	Appointment
José Antonio Kast Rist	President of Chile
Mojtaba Khamenei	Supreme Leader of Iran
Balendra "Balen" Shah	Prime Minister of Nepal
Shri B.P. Singh	Director General of Naval Armament (DGONA)
Saba Shawl	The first Kashmiri woman to head the high-security correctional facility - Superintendent of Central Jail Srinagar
Shiv Pratap Shukla	Governor of Telangana
Jishnu Dev Varma	Governor of Maharashtra
Lieutenant General (Retired) Syed Ata Hasnain	Governor of Bihar
RN Ravi	Governor of West Bengal.
Kavinder Gupta	Governor of Himachal Pradesh
Vinai Kumar Saxena	Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh
Former diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu	Lieutenant Governor of Delhi.
Nand Kishore Yadav	Governor of Nagaland
RM Nachammai	First woman chief superintendent
Menaka Guruswamy	First member from the LGBTQ community to be elected as a Member of Parliament - Rajya Sabha
Dr. Partha Biswas	Member of the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC)
Rahul Bhatia	Interim CEO Role at IndiGo
Vikram Doraiswami	India’s new ambassador to China
Shri Periasamy Kumaran	High Commissioner of India to the United Kingdom
Mr. Anutin Charnvirakul	Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Thailand
Bhumika Shrestha	Nepal’s first transgender woman member of parliament
Sadhvi Niranjan	Chairperson National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC)
Mrs. Kiran Umesh Mahalle	Member of the National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC)
KV Ramana Murty	Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Whole-Time Member
Atanu Chakraborty	Resigned HDFC Bank's part-time chairman
Sarah Mullally	First woman as Archbishop of Canterbury in the Church of England
William Walsh	InterGlobe Aviation Limited Chief Executive Officer

With Static

President Murmu Appoints New Governors for Several States and Union Territories

- President Droupadi Murmu has appointed Governors in different States and Union Territories.
- The Governor of Himachal Pradesh, Shiv Pratap Shukla, has been appointed as Governor of Telangana.
- Telangana Governor Jishnu Dev Varma has been appointed Governor of Maharashtra.
- Former Bihar Assembly Speaker Nand Kishore Yadav has been appointed as Governor of Nagaland.
- Lieutenant General (Retired) Syed Ata Hasnain has been appointed as Governor of Bihar.

- The Governor of Tamil Nadu, RN Ravi, has been appointed as the Governor of West Bengal.
- The Governor of Kerala, Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, will discharge the functions of the Governor of Tamil Nadu.
- The Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, Kavinder Gupta, has been appointed as Governor of Himachal Pradesh.
- The Lieutenant Governor of Delhi Vinai Kumar Saxena, has been appointed as Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh.
- Former diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu has been appointed as Lieutenant Governor of Delhi.

Appointment of Governors

- President of India has executed a major administrative reshuffle by appointing and transferring several Governors and Lieutenant Governors across States and Union Territories.
- The Governor is the Constitutional Head (Titular Head) of a State and acts as a vital link between the Union Government and the State Government.
- While the Governor is the executive head of the state, they generally act on the aid and advice of the Council of Ministers headed by the Chief Minister.

Key Articles Associated:

- Article 153: Mandates that there shall be a Governor for each State. However, the 7th Constitutional Amendment Act of 1956 allows for the appointment of the same person as Governor for two or more States.
- Article 154: Vests the executive power of the State in the Governor.
- Article 155: Specifies that the Governor of a State shall be appointed by the President by warrant under his hand and seal.
- Article 156: States that the Governor holds office during the pleasure of the President, typically for a term of 5 years.

Executive Functions:

- Head of State Administration: All executive actions of the State Government are formally taken in the Governor's name.
- Key Appointments: The Governor appoints the Chief Minister and, on their advice, the other Ministers. They also appoint the Advocate General of the State and the Chairman and members of the State Public Service Commission.
- Constitutional Role: They recommend the imposition of Constitutional Emergency (President's Rule) in a state to the President under Article 356 if the state machinery breaks down.

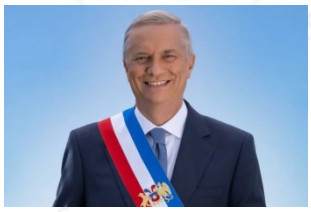
Legislative Functions:

- Summoning the House: The Governor has the power to summon or prorogue (end a session) the State Legislature and dissolve the State Legislative Assembly.
- Addressing the Legislature: They address the State Legislature at the commencement of the first session after each general election and at the first session of each year.
- Veto Power over Bills: When a bill is passed by the state legislature, the Governor can:
- Give assent to the bill.
- Withhold assent.
- Return the bill (if it is not a Money Bill) for reconsideration.
- Reserve the bill for the consideration of the President.
- Ordinance Making Power: Under Article 213, the Governor can promulgate ordinances when the state legislature is not in session, which have the same force as an act.

Judicial Functions:

- Pardoning Power: Under Article 161, the Governor possesses the power to grant pardons, reprieves, respites, or remissions of punishment for offenses against state laws.
- Consultation on Judges: The Governor is consulted by the President when appointing judges to the State High Court.

José Antonio Kast Rist Takes Oath as the President of Chile



- José Antonio Kast has officially taken office as the new President of Chile
- Location: It is located in the southwestern part of South America.
- It occupies a long, narrow coastal land strip wedged between the Andes Mountains to the east and the South Pacific Ocean to the west.
- Bordering Countries: It is bordered by Peru to the north, Bolivia to the northeast and Argentina to the east and by the Drake Passage to the south.
- Capital City: Santiago.

Iran names Khamenei's son, Mojtaba, as new supreme leader

- Mojtaba Khamenei, the second son of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed on the first day of the war that the United States and Israel launched on Iran, has been selected as Iran's new supreme leader.
- The Supreme Leader and his family, were a part of the revolutionary movement that overthrew a monarch in 1979
- Mojtaba Khamenei has long been viewed as a powerful behind-the-scenes figure within Iran's political system and has been closely linked to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC),

Balendra "Balen" Shah (leader of the Rastriya Swatantra Party - RSP) is set to become the next Prime Minister of Nepal

- In Nepal, Prime Ministerial candidate of the Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP), Balendra Shah, has been elected the House of Representatives (HoR) Member from Jhapa constituency

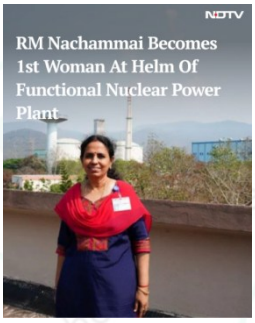
SHRI B.P. SINGH, TAKES OVER AS DIRECTOR GENERAL OF NAVAL ARMAMENT

- Shri B.P. Singh Assumed Charge as Director General of Naval Armament (DGONA) at Naval Headquarters, New Delhi, on 01 Mar 2026 . An officer of the 1994 batch of the Indian Naval Armament Service (INAS).
- He succeeds Shri Divakar Jayant, who superannuated on 28 Feb 2026, after rendering distinguished service to the nation.

Saba Shawl Becomes First Woman to Head Central Jail Srinagar

- Jammu and Kashmir's prison administration, Saba Shawl has been appointed as Superintendent of Central Jail Srinagar, becoming the first Kashmiri woman to head the high-security correctional facility.
- Saba Shawl hails from Peerbagh in Srinagar.

RM Nachammai Becomes First Woman Chief Of Operational Nuclear Plant



- RM Nachammai has created history by becoming the first woman chief superintendent looking after the operations of a functional nuclear power plant under the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL).
- Nachammai takes charge as Chief Superintendent of Karnataka's Kaiga Generating Station Units 3 and 4, effective March 15,
- The Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) operates India's commercial nuclear power plants.
- Kaiga Nuclear Power Station in Karnataka operates Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors (PHWRs).

Senior Advocate Menaka Guruswamy elected to Rajya Sabha, becomes first queer MP

- Senior Advocate Menaka Guruswamy was elected to the Rajya Sabha on a ticket by the All India Trinamool Congress.
- Guruswamy, a renowned lawyer has become the country's first member from the LGBTQ community to be elected as a Member of Parliament.

Dr. Partha Biswas assumed charge as Member of the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC)

- The National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) was established under Article 338 of the Constitution of India.
- According to Article 366(24) of the Indian Constitution, "Scheduled Castes means such castes, races or tribes or parts of or groups within such castes, races or tribes as are deemed under Article 341 to be Scheduled Castes for this Constitution.

Pieter Elbers, the IndiGo CEO who stepped down, Rahul Bhatia Takes Interim CEO Role at IndiGo

- IndiGo CEO Pieter Elbers stepped down from his role, three months after the airline faced network-wide flight disruptions.
- The airline's promoter and Managing Director, Rahul Bhatia, will assume charge of the airline's management in the interim

India appoints Vikram Doraiswami as next Ambassador to China

- Senior diplomat Vikram Doraiswami has been appointed as India's new ambassador to China.
- Mr Doraiswami, who is a 1992 batch Indian Foreign Service officer is currently serving as Indian High Commissioner to the United Kingdom.
- He will succeed Pradeep Kumar Rawat.

Periasamy Kumaran appointed as the next High Commissioner of India to U.K.

- Shri Periasamy Kumaran (IFS:1992), presently Secretary in the Ministry, has been appointed as the next High Commissioner of India to the United Kingdom.
- Mr. Kumaran has previously served as Special Secretary (ER & DPA) in the Ministry of External Affairs.

Mr. Anutin Charnvirakul elected as Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Thailand

- Location: Thailand is located in the center of mainland Southeast Asia.
- Bordering Countries: It shares boundaries with Myanmar (North West), Laos (North Easst), Cambodia (East), and Malaysia (South).
- Maritime boundary: Bordered by Andaman Sea (SW) and Gulf of Thailand (S)
- Capital City: Bangkok.

Bhumika Shrestha Becomes Nepal's First Transgender Woman MP

- Bhumika Shrestha, a 37-year-old LGBTQ rights activist, has made history by becoming Nepal's first transgender woman member of parliament.
- Bhumika Shrestha is a prominent transgender rights advocate from Nepal who has long worked for the dignity and recognition of sexual minorities.

HDFC Bank's part-time chairman and independent director Atanu Chakraborty resigned with immediate effect.

Sadhvi Niranjan Jyoti assumed charge as Chairperson of NCBC

- Sadhvi Niranjan Jyoti has assumed charge as Chairperson and Mrs. Kiran Umesh Mahalle has assumed charge as Member of the National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC) with effect from 18.03.2026 & 20.03.2026, respectively.

KV Ramana Murty Appointed SEBI Whole-Time Member

- The government has appointed Kompella Venkata Ramana Murty as a whole-time member of Sebi for a period of three years.
- With this addition, the regulatory board now has its full team of four full-time members.
- The other three whole-time members are Amarjeet Singh, Kamlesh Chandra Varshney, and Sandip Pradhan.

Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)

- Genesis: Initially constituted in 1988, as a non-statutory body; now a statutory body via SEBI Act, 1992.
- Headquarter: Mumbai; Regional Offices: New Delhi, Kolkata, Chennai, Ahmedabad
- Objectives: To safeguard investors from fraud, insider trading, and unfair practices.
- Functions: Registration and regulation of intermediaries (brokers, mutual funds, merchant bankers, credit rating agencies), and overseeing company takeovers; etc.
- Powers of SEBI: draft rules and regulations (e.g., Insider Trading Regulations); impose penalties in cases of fraud or unethical practices; and enforce regulations against violators.

Sarah Mullally enthroned as first female Archbishop of Canterbury

- Sarah Mullally was enthroned as the Church of England's first female Archbishop of Canterbury on Wednesday, taking the helm as the spiritual leader of 85 million Anglicans worldwide in a historic ceremony blending tradition with global symbolism.
- The former nurse took her seat on the 13th- century Chair of St Augustine at Canterbury Cathedral

The board of InterGlobe Aviation Limited, IndiGo's parent company announced the appointment of William Walsh as Chief Executive Officer.

Award

National

Vairamuthu wins Jnanpith Award, third Tamil writer to receive honour

- Poet and lyricist R. Vairamuthu has been selected for the prestigious 60th Jnanpith Award for the year 2025, becoming the third Tamil writer to receive the country's highest literary honour.
- The 72-year-old author follows in the footsteps of late novelists Akilan (1975) and Jayakanthan (2002).
- He has previously been honoured with the Padma Shri in 2003 and the Padma Bhushan in 2014 by the Government of India.
- Eminent Hindi litterateur, Vinod Kumar Shukla, 88, will be awarded the 59th Jnanpith Award for 2024 for his contributions to Hindi Literature.
- 58th Jnanpith Award to two writers - Sanskrit scholar Jagadguru Rambhadracharya and Urdu poet and lyricist Gulzar, for 2023.
- The Jnanpith Award is the oldest & highest literary honour of India given to writers who have excelled in literature in different Indian languages.
- The award carries with it a cash of Rs 11 lakh, a bronze statue of the Hindu Goddess Vagdevi and a citation.

About Jnanpith Awards

- Instituted in 1961
- It is presented annually by the Bharatiya Jnanpith to an author for their outstanding contribution towards literature.
- The award is bestowed only on Indian writers writing in Indian languages included in the Eighth Schedule to the Constitution of India and English (22+1 = 23 languages).

Consider the following pairs regarding the Sahitya Akademi Awards 2025:

Author	Work
1. Mamta Kalia	Jeete Jee Allahabad
2. Navtej Sarna	Crimson Spring
3. Pritpal Singh Betab	Safar Jaari Hai
4. Devabrat Das	Karhi Khelar Sadhu

Sahitya Akademi announces literary awards for 2025

Sahitya Akademi Award 2025

- Recently, the Sahitya Akademi has announced its annual Sahitya Akademi Awards in 24 Indian languages recognised by it.
- 8 books of poetry, 4 novels, 6 books of short stories, 2 essays, 1 literary criticism, 1 autobiography and 2 memoirs have won the Sahitya Akademi Awards 2025.
- Meanwhile, one literary criticism, one autobiography, and two memoirs have also been selected for the award.
- Prominent writer Mamta Kalia will be awarded for her Hindi memoir Jeete Jee Allahabad.
- The noted diplomat Navtej Sarna will be awarded for his English novel Crimson Spring.
- The award will also be conferred to the Urdu Poetry titled Safar Jaari Hai by Pritpal Singh Betab.
- Devabrat Das for his novel Karhi Khelar Sadhu in the Assamese language and Prasun Bandyopadhyay for his Bengali poetry Shrestha Kabita.

About Sahitya Akademi Award

- It is awarded for the most outstanding books of literary merit published in any of the major Indian languages recognised by the Akademi.

- Languages Recognised: Along with the 22 languages enumerated in the Constitution of India, the Sahitya Akademi has recognised English and Rajasthani as languages in which its programme may be implemented.
- Award: The authors and poets will receive a plaque, a shawl and an amount of ₹1 lakh in an award.

Key Facts about the Sahitya Akademi

- It was formally inaugurated by the Government of India on 12 March 1954.
- It was registered as a society under the Societies Registration Act, 1860.
- It is the central institution for literary dialogue, publication and promotion in the country and the only institution that undertakes literary activities in 24 Indian languages, including English.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Culture.
- Head office: New Delhi

Full List of Sahitya Akademi Award 2025 Winners

S. No	Language	Title and Genre	Name of the Author
1.	Assamese	Karhi Khelar Sadhu (Novel)	Devabrat Das
2.	Bengali	Shrestha Kabita (Poetry)	Prasun Bandyopadhyay
3.	Bodo	Dwngnwi Lama Mwnse Gathwn (Novel)	Sahaisuli Brahma
4.	Dogri	Thakur Satsayie (Poetry, Couplets)	Khajur Singh Thakur
5.	English	Crimson Spring (Novel)	Navtej Sarna
6.	Gujarati	Bhattkhadaki (Poetry)	Yogesh Vaidya
7.	Hindi	Jeete Jee Allahabad (Memoir)	Mamta Kalia
8.	Kannada	Dada Seerisu Tande (Short Stories)	Amaresh Nugadoni
9.	Kashmiri	Najdavanek'y Pot Aalav (Poetry)	Ali Shaida
10.	Konkani	Konkani Kavyem: Rupani Ani Rupakam (Essays)	Henry Mendonca (H.M. Pernal)
11.	Maithili	Dhatri Paat San Gaam (Memoir)	Mahendra
12.	Malayalam	Maayaamanushyar (Novel)	N. Prabhakaran
13.	Manipuri	Kanglamdriba Eephut (Short Stories)	Haobam Nalini
14.	Marathi	Kalyanilya Resha (Autobiography)	Raju Baviskar
15.	Nepali	Nepali Paramparik Sanskriti Ra Sabhyata Ko Dukuti (Essays)	Prakash Bhattarai
16.	Odia	Padapurana (Poetry)	Girijakumar Baliyar Singh
	Punjabi	Safety Kit (Stories)	Jinder
18.	Rajasthani	Bharkhama (Stories)	Jitender Kumar Soni
19.	Sanskrit	Prasthanacatustaye Brahmaghosah (Poetry)	Mahamahopadhyaya Sadhu Bhadreshdas
20.	Santali	Mid Birna Chenne Saon Inag Sagai (Short Stories)	Sumitra Soren
21.	Sindhi	Waghoo (Stories)	Bhagwan Atlani
22.	Tamil	Thamiz Sirukathaiyin Thadangal (Literary Criticism)	Sa. Tamilselvan
23.	Telugu	Animesha (Poetry)	Nandini Sidha Reddy
24.	Urdu	Safar Jaari Hai (Poetry)	Pritpal Singh Betab

Amol Palekar to Receive META Lifetime Achievement Award 2026

- Veteran actor, director and theatre practitioner Amol Palekar will be honoured with the Lifetime Achievement Award at the 21st Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards (META) 2026.
- The prestigious theatre festival will be held in New Delhi from 19 to 25 March 2026.
- Instituted by the Mahindra Group and produced by Teamwork Arts
- The festival hosts productions in multiple languages including Hindi, Malayalam, Bengali, Marathi and Sanskrit.

Sportstar Aces Awards 2026

- The eighth edition of the Sportstar Aces Awards was held at the Taj Mahal Palace

Category	Winner
Best State for Promotion of Sports	Bihar
Sportsman of the Year (Olympic Sports)	Samrat Rana (Shooting).
Sportswoman of the Year (Olympic Sports)	Shared by Mirabai Chanu (Weightlifting) and Suruchi Singh (Shooting).
Sportswoman of the Year (Team Sports)	Deepti Sharma (Cricket).
Sportswoman of the Year (Non-Olympic Sports)	Jyothi Surekha (Archery).
Sportsman of the Year (Non-Olympic Sports)	R. Praggnanandhaa
International Icon	Glenn McGrath (Cricket).
Ace of Aces	Mary Kom (Boxing) and Sakshi Malik (Wrestling).
Lifetime Achievement	Nari Contractor (Cricket)male and M.D. Valsamma (Athletics) female.
National Team of the Year	Indian Women's Cricket Team (ODI World Cup Champions).

Club/State Team of the Year	Vidarbha (Ranji Trophy 2024–25 Champions).
Best Corporate for Promotion of Sport	GMR Sports.
Best PSU for Promotion of Sport	Indian Oil Corporation Ltd..
Best Educational Institution	International Institute of Sports & Management (IISM).
Award of Excellence	Tania Sachdev (Chess), Manika Batra (Table Tennis), and Rani Rampal (Hockey).
Comeback of the Year	Murali Sreeshankar (Athletics).
Young Achievers of the Year	Jonathan Gavin Antony (Boys) and Suruchi Singh (Girls)
Mentor of the Roots	Pritam Siwach (Hockey Coach)
Sports for Social Good	Project Nanhi Kali
Captain of the Year	Harmanpreet Kaur
Special Recognition Award	Indian Blind Women's Cricket Team
Sportsman Of The Year (Team Sports)	Shubman Gill
Sportswoman Of The Year (Team Sports)	Deepti Sharma
Sportsman Of The Year (Para Sports)	Harvinder Singh
Sportswoman Of The Year (Para Sports)	Sheetal Devi
Special Jury Recognition	Preethi Pal
Coach Of The Year	Amol Muzumdar, Naval Singh

The BCCI Naman Awards 2026

- The BCCI Naman Awards 2026 were celebrated the achievements and contributions of Indian cricket with grand ceremony held in New Delhi on March 15 2026

Category	**Winner**
Polly Umrigar Award (Best international men's cricketer)	Shubman Gill
Best international women's cricketer	Smriti Mandhana
Col. C. K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award	Roger Binny
Col. C. K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award	Rahul Dravid
Col. C. K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award	Mithali Raj
Best International Cricketer in 2024-25 – Women	Smriti Mandhana
Best International Debut in 2024-25 – Men	Harshit Rana
Best International Debut in 2024-25 - Women	N Sree Charani
Highest Run Getter in One Day Internationals - 2024-25 - Women	Smriti Mandhana
Highest Wickets in One Day Internationals - 2024-25 - Women	Deepti Sharma
Lala Amarnath Award for the Best All-Rounder In Domestic Limited-Overs Competitions, 2024-25	Ayush Mhatre (Mumbai)
Lala Amarnath Award for the Best All-Rounder in the Ranji Trophy, 2024-25	Harsh Dubey (Vidarbha)
Madhavrao Scindia Award: Highest Run Getter In The Ranji Trophy in 2024-25 , Elite Group:	Y V Rathod (Vidarbha)
Madhavrao Scindia Award: Highest Run Getter In The Ranji Trophy in 2024-25 -Plate Group:	Snehal Kauthankar (Goa)
Madhavrao Scindia Award: Highest Wicket-Taker In The Ranji Trophy in 2024-25 -Elite Group:	Harsh Dubey (Vidarbha)
Madhavrao Scindia Award: Highest Wicket-Taker In The Ranji Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group:	Suchith J (Nagaland)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U23) Col. C K Nayudu Trophy in 2024-25 -Elite Group:	Macneil H N (Karnataka)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U23) Col. C K	R Jashwanth Shreeram (Puducherry)

Nayudu Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group:	
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U23) Col. C K Nayudu Trophy in 2024-25 - Elite Group	Vicky Ostwal (Maharashtra)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U23) Col. C K Nayudu Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group	Dipjyoti Saikia (Assam)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U19) Cooch Behar Trophy in 2024-25 - Elite Group	Nitya J Pandya (Baroda)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U19) Cooch Behar Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group	Ragavan Ramamoorthy (Puducherry)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U19) Cooch Behar Trophy in 2024-25 - Elite Group	Hemchudeshan J (Tamil Nadu)
M.A. Chidambaram Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U19) Cooch Behar Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group	Arkajit Roy (Tripura)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U16) Vijay Merchant Trophy in 2024-25 - Elite Group	Shanthanu Singh (Uttar Pradesh)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Highest Run Getter In (U16) Vijay Merchant Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group	Pritam Raj (Bihar)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U16) Vijay Merchant Trophy in 2024-25 - Elite Group	Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan (Madhya Pradesh)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Highest Wicket-Taker In (U16) Vijay Merchant Trophy in 2024-25 - Plate Group	Kishan Sarkar (Tripura)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Best Woman Cricketer (Sr Domestic) of 2024-25	Shafali Verma (Haryana)
Jagmohan Dalmiya Trophy: Best Woman Cricketer (Jr Domestic) of 2024-25	Ira Jadhav (Mumbai)
Best Performance in BCCI Domestic Tournaments of 2024-25	Mumbai Cricket Association
Best Umpire In Domestic Cricket in 2024-25	Ulhas Gandhe (Vidarbha C A)

Critics' Choice Awards 2026

- The Film Critics Guild announced the winners of the 8th Critics' Choice Awards 2026.
- Leading was Homebound, which bagged four major honours — Best Film, Best Director for Neeraj Ghaywan, Best Actor for Vishal Jethwa, and Best Supporting Actress for Shalini Vatsa.

Documentary

- Best Documentary: I, Poppy

Special Award

- Extraordinary Contribution to Cinema: Farida Jalal

Feature Films

- Best Film: Homebound
- Best Director: Neeraj Ghaywan — Homebound
- Best Actor: Vishal Jethwa — Homebound
- Best Actress: Priyanka Bose — Agra
- Best Supporting Actor: Pasupathy — Bison Kaalamaadan
- Best Supporting Actress: Shalini Vatsa — Homebound
- Best Writing: Rohan Parashuram Kanawade — Sabar Bonda (Cactus Pears)
- Best Cinematography: Sunil Borkar — Jugnuma (The Fable)
- Best Editing: Chaman Chakko — Lokah Chapter 1: Chandra
- Gender Sensitivity Award: Sthal (A Match)

Full list of winners at the 8th Critics' Choice Awards 2026: Short Films

- Best Film: Maaybaapache Aashirwaad (Blessings)
- Best Director: Apurva Bardapurkar — Maaybaapache Aashirwaad (Blessings)
- Best Actor: Sunny Hinduja — That's A Wrap
- Best Actress: Sheeba Chaddha — Nighiyaan Chhavan (Warm Shadows)
- Best Writing: Apurva Bardapurkar — Maaybaapache Aashirwaad (Blessings)
- Best Cinematography: Saurabh Suman — Aasmaani Jhoola (The Giant Wheel of Life)

Web Series

- Best Web Series: Black Warrant
- Best Director: Vikramaditya Motwane, Satyanshu Singh, Arkesh Ajay, Rohin Raveendran Nair, Ambiecka Pandit — Black Warrant
- Best Actor: Jaideep Ahlawat — Paatal Lok S2
- Best Actress: Monika Panwar — Khauf
- Best Supporting Actor: Rahul Bhat — Black Warrant
- Best Supporting Actress: Tillotama Shome — Paatal Lok S2
- Best Writing: Satyanshu Singh, Arkesh Ajay — Black Warrant

Karnataka Grameena Bank Wins National SHG Linkage Award

- Karnataka Grameena Bank has been honoured with the National Award for Outstanding Performance in Self-Help Group (SHG) Bank Linkage for 2024–25 by the Union Ministry of Rural Development.
- The recognition highlights the bank's significant contribution to rural economic empowerment and financial inclusion, particularly through strengthening SHG-based credit systems.
- The award was presented at the National Conference on Financial Literacy and Capacity Building, alongside the 25th Central Level Coordination Committee meeting held in Hyderabad.

Adani Gangavaram Port of Andhra Pradesh bags gold for 'Best Safety Performer 2025' at CII Safety Awards

- Adani Gangavaram Port Limited (AGPL) has been honored with the Gold Award for 'Best Safety Performer 2025' in the Ports and Logistics category at the CII Andhra Pradesh Industrial Safety Excellence Awards.
- The port has integrated advanced safety protocols, including technology-driven monitoring, a vehicle management system focused on driver wellness, and robust emergency response mechanisms.

The central government has opened nominations for the Rashtriya Vigyan Puraskar (RVP) 2026

- It is a prestigious national award recognizing outstanding contributions in the fields of science, technology, and innovation.
- The RVP seeks to honour scientists, technologists, and innovators whose work has significantly advanced India's scientific landscape and contributed to national development.

Eligibility

- Scientists/technologists/innovators working in government or private sector organizations or any individual working outside any organization, who have made distinguished contributions in terms of path- breaking research or innovation or discovery in any field of science, technology, or technology-led innovation shall be eligible for the awards.
- People of Indian Origin staying abroad with exceptional contributions benefiting the Indian communities or society shall also be eligible for the awards.

The awards will be presented in four categories:

- Vigyan Ratna (VR): For lifetime achievements in science and technology.
- Vigyan Shri (VS): For distinguished contributions in the field.
- Vigyan Yuva–Shanti Swarup Bhatnagar (VY-SSB): To encourage young scientists (up to 45 years) showing exceptional promise.
- Vigyan Team (VT): For collaborative excellence by research teams of three or more members.
- The awards are administered by the RVP Secretariat, Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), Ministry of Science & Technology, under the guidance of the Principal Scientific Advisor to the Government of India.

International

Actor Awards 2026 complete list of winners

- The Actor Awards 2026, previously known as the Screen Actors Guild Awards (SAG Awards), took place on March 1 at the Shrine Auditorium in Los Angeles.
- Catherine O'Hara wins posthumous Best Actress award - The late actor won the Actors Award for Best Female Actor in a Comedy Series for her role in The Studio.

Category	Winner
Outstanding performance by a male actor in a leading role	Michael B. Jordan, Sinners
Outstanding performance by a female actor in a leading role	Jessie Buckley, Hamnet
Stunt ensemble in a motion picture	Mission: Impossible – The Final Reckoning
Outstanding performance by an ensemble in a drama series	The Pitt
Outstanding performance by a male actor in a television movie or limited series	Owen Cooper, Adolescence
Outstanding performance by an ensemble in a comedy series	The Studio
Outstanding performance by a male actor in a drama series	Noah Wyle, The Pitt
Outstanding performance by a female actor in a comedy series	Catherine O'Hara, The Studio
Outstanding performance by a female actor in a drama series	Keri Russell, The Diplomat
Outstanding performance by a cast in a motion picture	Sinners
Outstanding performance by a female actor in a comedy series	Catherine O'Hara, The Studio
Outstanding performance by a male actor in a comedy series	Seth Rogen, The Studio

Saturn Awards 2026

- The 53rd Saturn Awards were announced on March 8, 2026 at

CATEGORY	WINNER
Best Independent Film	*Dust Bunny* (Roadside Attractions / Lionsgate)
Best International Film	*Sisu 2: Road to Revenge* (Screen Gems / Sony Pictures)
Best International Animated Film	*Demon Slayer: Kimetsu no Yaiba Infinity Castle* (Crunchyroll / Sony Pictures)
CATEGORY	WINNER
Best Science Fiction Film	*Avatar: Fire and Ash* (20th Century Studios / Lightstorm)
Best Fantasy Film	*Wicked: For Good* (Universal Pictures)
Best Horror Film	*Frankenstein (Netflix)*
Best Cinematic Film Adaptation	*The Fantastic Four: First Steps*(Marvel Studios / Walt Disney Studios)
Best Thriller Film	*Sinners* (Warner Bros.)
Best Action/Adventure Film	*Mission: Impossible – The Final Reckoning*(Paramount Pictures)
Best Actor in a Film	Tom Cruise for *Mission: Impossible – The Final Reckoning*
Best Actress in a Film	Elle Fanning for *Predator: Badlands*
Best Supporting Actor in a Film	Jacob Elordifor *Frankenstein*
Best Supporting Actress in a Film	Sigourney Weaver for *Dust Bunny*
Best Younger Performer in a Film	Jack Champion for *Avatar: Fire and Ash*
Best Film Direction	James Cameron for *Avatar: Fire and Ash*
Best Film Screenwriting	James Cameron, Rick Jaffa & Amanda Silver –*Avatar: Fire and Ash*
Best Visual/Special Effects	Joe Letteri, Richard Baneham, Daniel Barrett, Eric Saindon – *Avatar: Fire and Ash*
Best Film Music	Nine Inch Nails (Trent Reznor & Atticus Ross)for*Tron: Ares*

Oscars 2026: the 98th Academy Awards

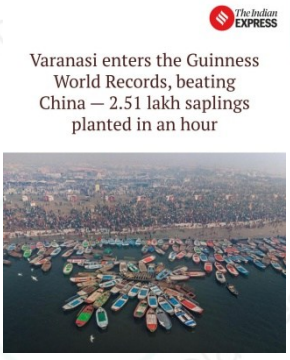
- All the Oscar winners at the 98th Academy Awards
- Autumn Durald Arkapaw became the first woman to win the Best Cinematography Oscar recognized for her work on Ryan Coogler's Sinners.

Category	Winner
Best Picture	'One Battle After Another'
Best Actress	Jessie Buckley
Best Actor	Michael B. Jordan
Best Director	Paul Thomas Anderson
Best Original Song	"Golden"
Best International Feature Film	'Sentimental Value'
Best Picture nominee:	Paul Thomas Anderson's 'One Battle After Another'
Best Cinematography	'Sinners' - Autumn Durald Arkapaw
Best Film Editing	'One Battle After Another'
Best Sound	'F1'
Best Original Score	'Sinners'
Best Picture nominee:	Kleber Mendonça Filho's 'The Secret Agent'
Best Documentary Feature	'Mr. Nobody Against Putin'
Best Documentary Short Film	'All the Empty Rooms'
Best Picture nominee	Ryan Coogler's 'Sinners'
Best Visual Effects	'Avatar: Fire & Ash'
Best Production Design	'Frankenstein'
Best animated feature film	KPop Demon Hunters – WINNER
Best animated short film	The Girl Who Cried Pearls
Best costume design	Frankenstein (Kate Hawley)
Best casting	One Battle After Another (Cassandra Kulukundis)
Best supporting actor	Sean Penn, One Battle After Another
Best original screenplay	Sinners (Ryan Coogler)
Best film editing	One Battle After Another

Meet Fancy, the oldest living horse in the world and a Guinness World Record holder

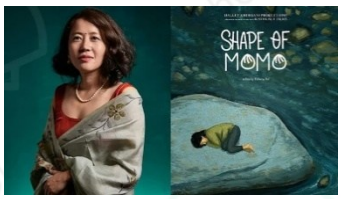
- At 37 years old, Fancy — she's officially the world's oldest living horse.
- Recently recognised by Guinness World Records, the Virginia-based Quarter Horse earned the title at 37 and is set to turn 38 in April 2026.

Varanasi enters the Guinness World Records, beating China — 2.51 lakh saplings planted in an hour



- Varanasi has entered the Guinness World Records by planting 2,51,446 saplings within one hour during a mega plantation drive at the Sujabad Domari area surpassing China's 2018 record of 1,53,981 saplings.
- The plantation was carried out over nearly 350 bighas.
- The forest area has been divided into 60 sectors, each named after prominent ghats of Kashi, including Dashashwamedh, Manikarnika, Kedar, and Lalita. More than 4,000 saplings were planted in each sector.

Sikkimese film Shape of Momo gains new European festival selections after Glasgow screening



- Sikkimese film 'Shape of Momo' continues its successful journey on the international festival circuit, adding new selections across Europe after its earlier screening at the Glasgow Film Festival.
- Sikkimese film 'Shape of Momo' directed by Tribeny Rai
- Later this month, it will also compete at the 35th African, Asian and Latin American Film Festival in Italy, where it has been selected for the "Windows on the World" Feature Film Competition.
- Currently, Director Tribeny Rai and producer Geeta Rai are attending the 'Spirit of Fire International Debut Film Festival' at Khanty- Mansiysk in Russia, which is dedicated to debut films by emerging directors from various nations.
- 'Shape of Momo' film will next travel to the Cinema Asia Film Festival in Amsterdam, where it will have its Dutch premiere in April.

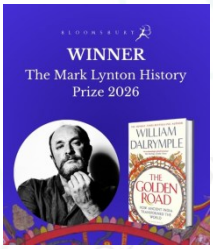
Kaveh Madani has been named the 2026 recipient of the Stockholm Water Prize

- He is the youngest laureate and first UN official to receive the award for linking water science with policy, diplomacy, and public outreach.
- It is regarded as the world's most prestigious award for water-related work.
- It has been presented annually since 1991.
- It is awarded by the Stockholm Water Foundation in collaboration with the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences.

Eligibility for Stockholm Water Prize

- The Prize is awarded to a person or organization who contributes to the conservation and protection of water resources, and to the well- being of the planet and its inhabitants.
- Everyone who has made extraordinary water-related achievements is eligible.
- The prize is presented by H. M. King Carl XVI Gustaf of Sweden, who is the official patron of the prize, at the awarding ceremony during World Water Week in August.
- Nomination: Anyone can submit a nomination for the Stockholm Water Prize, however, self-nominations or nominations by persons with direct professional or family ties to the candidate are not permitted

William Dalrymple Wins Mark Lynton History Prize 2026



- Historian William Dalrymple has been awarded the 2026 Mark Lynton History Prize for his book "The Golden Road: How Ancient India Transformed the World" for combining "literary grace, commitment to serious research and social concern".
- The Mark Lynton History Prize is an annual USD 10,000 award given to a book "of history, on any subject, that best combines intellectual or scholarly distinction with felicity of expression".
- The prize is named after the late Mark Lynton, a business executive and author of "Accidental Journey: A Cambridge Internee's Memoir of World War II".

Hyderabad airport wins Skytrax 'Best Airport Staff in India and South Asia 2026' award

- Hyderabad's Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) has once again secured global recognition, winning the 'Best Airport Staff in India and South Asia 2026' award at the Skytrax World Airport Awards.
- The airport has received this honour for the fifth time.
- Singapore Changi Airport has been named the world's best airport for the second consecutive year in the 2026 Skytrax
- Hamad International Airport and Tokyo Haneda Airport followed Singapore Changi Airport in the global rankings.

Rituparna Sengupta Honoured at UK Parliament for Cultural Contribution

- Renowned Indian actress Rituparna Sengupta has been honoured with the Women Empowerment Award for Art and Culture at the House of Commons, UK.
- The recognition was conferred during an event organised to mark International Women's Day, celebrating women's achievements across diverse fields.

Nandamuri Balakrishna Receives Lifetime Achievement at IFFD 2026

- Veteran Telugu actor Nandamuri Balakrishna was honoured with the Lifetime Achievement Award at the International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) 2026.
- The recognition marks his remarkable contribution to Indian cinema spanning five decades.
- The award ceremony, held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, celebrated his enduring legacy and influence in the film industry.

Kalpana Soren Honoured with Women Empowerment Award

- Jharkhand MLA Kalpana Soren was honoured with the 'Women Empowerment Trailblazer Award' at the BRICS CCI WE Annual Women Summit and Felicitation 2026
- The award was presented at an event hosted by the women empowerment vertical of the BRICS Chamber of Commerce and Industry, recognising her contributions towards advancing women-led initiatives and community development.
- Veteran actor Shabana Azmi, honoured with the "Trailblazer: Living Legend" award.
- Debjani Ghosh, recipient of the Lifetime Achievement Award.

US National Book Critics Circle Award 2026

- Indian Booker-winning novelist Arundhati Roy was awarded the United States National Book Critics Circle award for her memoir, Mother Mary Comes to Me in the Autobiography section.
- The book was also shortlisted for the 2026 Women's Prize for Non-Fiction.

Sheetal Devi named 'Para Archer of the Year 2025'

- India's Sheetal Devi has been named 'Para Archer of the Year 2025' by World Archery.
- The 19-year-old from Jammu and Kashmir became the first and only female armless archer to win gold at the World Para Archery Championships by claiming the top honours in the women's compound individual event at Gwangju in South Korea last year.
- The 2025 World Archery Awards, launched in 2011, honour excellence and outstanding contributions to the sport, celebrating the athletes who have defined the international archery season.
- This year, the awards were presented across eight categories, including 'Archer of the Year', which went to Emircan Haney of Turkey.
- 'Young Archer of the Year' was awarded to Baptiste Addis of France, and 'Best Team of the Year' was claimed by Korea's recurve men's team.

Obituaries

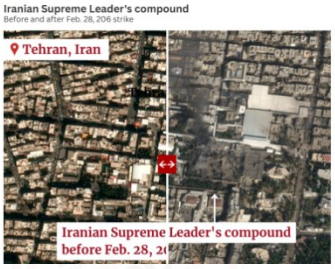
Former General Secretary of All India Football Federation Kushal Das passes away

- Former All India Football Federation (AIFF) General Secretary Kushal Das passed away at the age of 66 .
- Das served the federation for 12 years spanning 2010 to 2022.

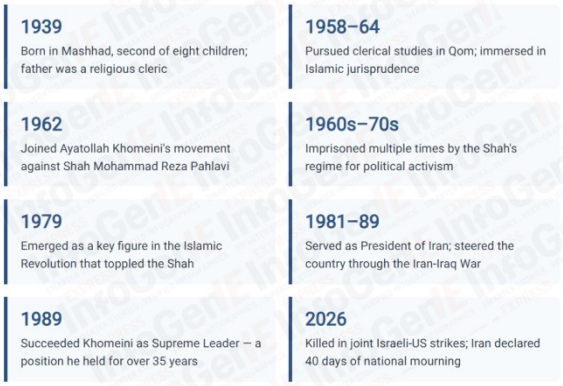
Renowned Urdu writer Jeelani Bano passes away at 90

- She received the Padma Shri in 2001.
- Prolific literary career spanning short stories, novels, radio plays, screenplays, essays and children's literature.

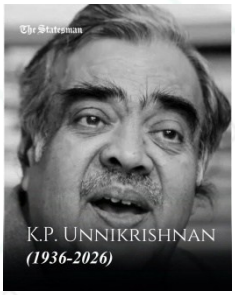
Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran's Supreme Leader dead at 86



- Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei died following a major attack by Israel and the United States.
- Ayatollah Ali Khamenei had been Iran's hardline spiritual guide and top political authority since 1989, when he succeeded Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini as supreme leader.
- In Iran's theocratic system, the Supreme Leader is the most powerful figure in the country ranking above the president, parliament, and judiciary
- Ali Khamenei was born in 1939, in the northern Iranian city of Mashhad.
- Khamenei emerged as a key figure in the 1979 revolution.

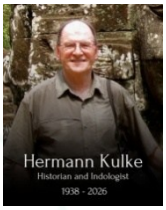


K P Unnikrishnan, Former Union Minister, Dies at 89



- Senior Congress leader, socialist and seven-term parliamentarian K P Unnikrishnan died in Kozhikode, He was 89.
- Represented Kerala's Vadakara Lok Sabha constituency for seven consecutive terms from 1971 to 1996.
- He served as Union minister for Surface Transport, Shipping and Telecommunications in the latter's government between 1989 and 1990.
- During the 1990 Gulf crisis, he played a key role in coordinating the evacuation of Indians stranded abroad.

Prof Hermann Kulke, renowned Indologist who became global voice of Odisha history, passes away



- Eminent historian and Indologist, Prof Hermann Kulke, considered the foremost global voice of Odisha's culture and history, died. He was 87 years old.
- He was based in Odisha for several years and was conferred with the Padma Shri in 2010.

1965 India-Pakistan war hero K.G. George dies in Kerala at 95

- Lance Havildar K.G. George (retd), who was awarded a Vir Chakra for his heroics in the 1965 India-Pakistan War, passed away in Kerala at the age of 95.
- Vir Chakra is the country's third highest wartime gallantry award.
- George had served in the Indian Army's Corp of Signals, a key unit that was established in 1911.

Pulitzer-winning author Tracy Kidder, who turned unlikely subjects into bestsellers, dies at 80

- Kidder won the Pulitzer Prize and the National Book Award for his 1981 work "The Soul of a New Machine",

S. Thyagarajan, veteran sports journalist, passes away

- S. Thyagarajan, 85, veteran sports correspondent, who worked with The Hindu for more than five decades, passed away
- Specialised in covering hockey

Senior Yakshagana artist Surikumeri K. Govinda Bhat passes away

- Senior Yakshagana artist Surikumeri K. Govinda Bhat passed away at Heddur, near Tirthahalli.
- A recipient of the Kendra Sangeet Natak Akademi Award for 2016 and Karnataka Rajyotsava Award for 2008
- He was the recipient of awards including Karnataka Janapada Academy award.

Yakshagana

- Origin: Traditional folk dance-drama of coastal Karnataka, combining dance, music, song, and elaborate costumes.
- Meaning: Yakshagana = "Celestial Music" (Yaksha = celestial, Gana = music), presenting a divine world through scholarly dialogues and night-long performances.
- Performance Setting: Conducted in open-air theatres, often in village paddy fields after harvest. Traditionally male- dominated, but now women also participate in Yakshagana Melas (troupes).

Former Raymond Group chairman Vijaypat Singhania passes away at 87

- Air Commodore (Dr.) Vijaypat Singhania, recipient of Padma Bhusan, former chairman of Raymond Group and former Sheriff of Bombay passed away
- He held the world record for highest altitude gained in a hot air balloon and winning the gold medal in an around-the-world air race.

National

Appropriation Bill 2026

- Parliament has passed the Appropriation Bill 2026, with the Rajya Sabha returning it to the Lok Sabha after a discussion where Finance Minister defended the government's budgeting as transparent and realistic.
- An Appropriation Bill is a specialized piece of legislation that authorizes the government to withdraw funds from the Consolidated Fund of India (CFI) to meet its expenditures for a specific financial year.
- Without the passage of this Bill, the government cannot legally spend a single rupee from the CFI, even if the Budget has been presented.

Constitutional Article Associated:

- Article 114: This article mandates that no money shall be withdrawn from the Consolidated Fund of India except under appropriation made by law.
- Article 115 & 116: Related to Supplementary, Additional, or Excess grants and Votes on Account, respectively, which may also require subsequent Appropriation Bills.

Budgetary Process:

- Presentation: The Finance Minister presents the Annual Financial Statement (Budget).
- Discussion: General discussion takes place in both Houses.

- Voting on Demands for Grants: The Lok Sabha votes on the specific expenditure requests of various ministries.
- Introduction of the Bill: Once the Demands for Grants are voted upon, the Appropriation Bill is introduced in the Lok Sabha.
- Passage: After being passed by the Lok Sabha, it is sent to the Rajya Sabha. Since it is treated as a Money Bill, the Rajya Sabha has limited powers and must return it within 14 days.
- Presidential Assent: Once passed by both Houses (or returned by the Rajya Sabha), it receives the President's assent to become an Act.

Government Withdraws Jan Vishwas Amendment Bill 2025

- Union Minister Piyush Goyal will move a motion in the Lok Sabha seeking permission to withdraw The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2025, as Parliament continues the second phase of the Union Budget 2026-27 session.
- The Bill, originally introduced in 2025, seeks to amend various laws to decriminalise and rationalise minor offences, with the aim of promoting trust-based governance and improving ease of living and doing business.

Key Features of the Bill

- First-time contraventions: For 76 offences under 10 different Acts, the Bill provides that first-time violations will attract only an advisory or warning instead of punishment.
- Decriminalization of minor offences: Removes imprisonment clauses with monetary penalties or warnings for minor, technical, and procedural defaults.
- E.g., Some Acts like the Tea Act, 1953, Legal Metrology Act, 2009 (already amended in 2023 are further decriminalized).
- Rationalization of penalties: Fines are rationalized and made proportionate, with incremental penalties for repeat offences.
- Automatic revision of fines: Provides for an automatic increase of 10 per cent in fines and penalties every three year which ensures that penalties remain effective as a deterrent without the need for frequent legislative amendments.

The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026

- The Union Government introduced a Bill in the Lok Sabha to amend the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019.
- The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 proposes modifications to the 2019 law that protects transgender persons from discrimination and ensures their welfare.
- The original Act was enacted following the Supreme Court's landmark judgment in the NALSA v. Union of India (2014) case, which recognised transgender persons as the third gender and affirmed the right to self- determination of gender identity under Article 21.

Proposed Changes in the Amendment Bill:

- Removal of right to self-perceived gender identity
- The amendment proposes deleting Section 4(2) of the 2019 Act, which recognises a person's right to self-perceived gender identity.

Redefinition of transgender person:

The Bill narrows the definition to include:

- Socio-cultural identities such as hijra, kinner, aravani, jogta, eunuch
- Persons with intersex variations
- Individuals with congenital biological variations in sexual characteristics
- It excludes persons identifying solely based on self-perceived gender identity or gender fluidity.
- The definition also includes individuals forced to adopt transgender identity through mutilation, castration, hormonal procedures or coercion.

- The Bill introduces the concept of an authority (medical board headed by a Chief Medical Officer) to examine gender certification cases.
- Changes in transgender certificate procedure: Instead of automatic issuance, the District Magistrate must review recommendations from the medical authority before granting a certificate.
- Mandatory gender certificate revision after surgery: Persons undergoing Sex Reassignment Surgery (SRS) must apply for a revised gender certificate, whereas earlier it was optional.
- A new provision allows transgender persons to change their first name in official records, subject to the new definition criteria.

The Bill expands criminal provisions with graded punishments (including imprisonment and fines up to ₹5 lakh) for crimes such as:

- Denial of access to public places
- Forced labour
- Expulsion from homes

Initiatives Taken to Empower Transgender Persons

- SMILE Scheme: The Support for Marginalized Individuals for Livelihood and Enterprise provides comprehensive rehabilitation and medical cover for SRS.
- National Portal for Transgender Persons: A digital interface launched to allow trans persons to apply for ID cards and certificates without physical interface with offices.
- Garima Greh: Shelter homes provided by the government to offer safe spaces, food, and skill development for transgender persons in distress.
- Inclusive Education: The NCERT has introduced teacher training modules (updated in 2024-25) to sensitize educators about gender diversity and inclusion.

FM Nirmala Sitharaman announces revamped Stand-up India scheme for SC, ST and women entrepreneurs

- The government will launch a revamped version of the Stand-up India scheme to provide more benefits to SC, ST and Women entrepreneurs across the country.
- The Stand-up India scheme, which was launched in April 2016, came to an end in March last year.
- Objective: Promote entrepreneurship amongst women, SC & ST category;Provide loans for greenfield enterprises in manufacturing, services or the trading sector and activities allied to agriculture;
- Facilitate bank loans between Rs.10 lakh and Rs.1 crore to at least one Scheduled Caste/ Scheduled Tribe borrower and at least one woman borrower per bank branch of Scheduled Commercial Banks.

Eligibility

- SC/ST and/or women entrepreneurs, above 18 years of age;
- Loans under the scheme available for only green field project.
- Green field signifies, in this context, the first-time venture of the beneficiary in the manufacturing, services, agri-allied activities or the trading sector.
- In case of non-individual enterprises, 51% of the shareholding and controlling stake should be held by either SC/ST and/or Women Entrepreneur.

Sujal Gaon ID

- The Union Ministry of Jal Shakti has launched Sujal Gaon ID, a unique digital identifier for mapping rural piped water supply schemes across India.
- Sujal Gaon ID is a scheme-based unique digital identifier assigned to each rural piped drinking water supply scheme in India.
- It enables digital mapping of rural water supply assets and service areas, integrating them into a unified national water management platform.
- It has been introduced under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0, the flagship programme aimed at providing Functional Household Tap Connections (FHTCs) to all rural households.
- Every rural drinking water scheme is assigned a distinct Sujal Gaon ID, ensuring traceability of assets and services.
- The ID is linked with Sujalam Bharat IDs, combining infrastructure ID and service-area ID for complete mapping of water supply systems.

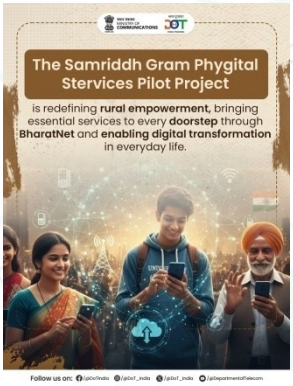
Dumpsite Remediation Accelerator Programme (DRAP)

- The Government of India has launched the Dumpsite Remediation Accelerator Programme (DRAP) to fast-track the clearance of legacy waste dumpsites across urban India.
- It follows a structured and fast-tracked approach to remove garbage mountains and reclaim land for productive use such as parks, community facilities, and waste-management infrastructure.
- Launched in: November 2025.
- Ministry: Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).
- Implemented under Swachh Bharat Mission – Urban 2.0 (SBM- U 2.0)
- Achieve 100% dumpsite clearance within one year of adoption.

Key Features:

- Lakshya Zero Dumpsites Target: Supports SBM-U 2.0 goal of eliminating dumpsites by September 2026.
- Focus on High-Impact Sites: Prioritizes 214 major dumpsites across 202 urban local bodies, where about 80% of legacy waste is concentrated.
- Financial Support: Central Financial Assistance (CFA) provided at ₹550 per tonne for legacy waste remediation.
- 5P Framework: Implementation based on Political leadership, Public financing, Partnerships, People's participation, and Project management.

Samriddh Gram Phygital Services Pilot Initiative



- The Union Minister of Communications is set to inaugurate the Samriddh Gram Phygital Services Pilot Project at Umri village in Madhya Pradesh.
- Samriddh Gram is a pilot project for integrated Phygital (Physical + Digital) service delivery in rural areas.
- It aims to create village-level service hubs called Samriddhi Kendras that provide multiple citizen services using digital connectivity.
- Implemented by: the Department of Telecommunications.
- Built on the digital infrastructure of BharatNet, one of the world's largest rural broadband connectivity projects.

Pilot Locations:

The pilot project is being implemented in three villages representing diverse socio-economic contexts:

- Umri
- Narakoduru
- Chaurawala
- Each Samriddhi Kendra is designed to serve multiple villages within a 5 km radius.

Amit Shah unveils mascots, soft launches four digital tools to power Census 2027

- Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched four digital tools that will drive the country's first fully digital Census, with the first phase starting April 1.
- The Census will be conducted in two phases – houselisting and housing census from April to September 2026, and population enumeration (PE) in February 2027.
- The mascots — 'Pragati' (female) and 'Vikas' (male) — symbolise equal participation of women and men in fulfilling the resolve to make India a developed nation by 2047.
- The four digital platforms that will be at the centre of the Census exercise have been developed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC)

- Launched the Houselisting Block Creator (HLBC) web application for digital mapping using satellite imagery, which will ensure standardised geographic coverage across the country;
- The HLO mobile application, which is a secure offline mobile app for enumerators to collect and upload houselisting data;
- A Self-enumeration (SE) portal that will for the first time allow users to submit their household information online before field operations; and core of the Census,
- The Census Management and Monitoring System (CMMS) — a dedicated digital portal engineered to orchestrate one of the largest administrative exercises in the world.

Removal of the Chief Election Commissioner

- The INDIA bloc parties, led by the Trinamool Congress, are set to move an impeachment motion against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.
- The removal of the CEC is a formal, quasi-judicial process designed to ensure the independence of the Election Commission of India (ECI) from executive interference.
- To protect the sanctity of the democratic process, the CEC is granted security of tenure similar to that of a judge of the Supreme Court of India.

Constitutional Article:

- Article 324(5): This article explicitly states that the Chief Election Commissioner shall not be removed from his office except in like manner and on the like grounds as a Judge of the Supreme Court.

Criteria for Removal:

A CEC can only be removed on two specific grounds:

- Proved Misbehavior: Acts that violate the code of conduct or involve corruption/partiality.
- Physical or mental inability to perform the duties of the office.

Procedure for Removal:

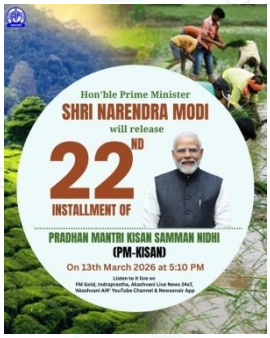
The process is rigorous and requires a Special Majority in Parliament:

- A motion must be signed by at least 100 members in the Lok Sabha or 50 members in the Rajya Sabha and submitted to the Speaker/Chairman.
- Investigation: If the motion is admitted, the Chair constitutes a three-member committee to investigate the charges.
- Parliamentary Vote: If the committee finds the CEC guilty, the motion is taken up for voting. It must be passed by:
- A majority of the total membership of that House.
- A majority of not less than two-thirds of the members present and voting.
- Once both Houses pass the motion in the same session, an address is presented to the President of India, who then issues the formal order of removal.
- Note: Unlike the CEC, other Election Commissioners or Regional Commissioners can be removed by the President simply on the recommendation of the Chief Election Commissioner.

Government launches logo design contest for VB-G RAM G Act

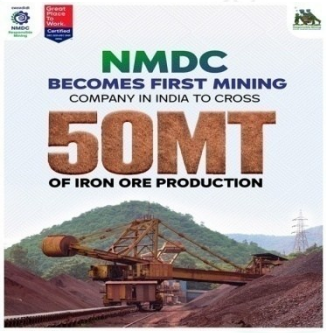
- The Rural Development Ministry said a logo design competition for the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act (VB-G RAM G) has been launched.
- The Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025, replaces the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, 2005
- It provides a statutory guarantee of up to 125 days of wage employment in a financial year to rural households whose adult members volunteer for unskilled manual work.
- The new Act will further strengthen the rural employment guarantee by providing 125 days of work, compared to the 100 days provided under MGNREGA.

Prime Minister to release 22nd installment of Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi



- Prime Minister Narendra Modi will release the 22nd instalment of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana from Guwahati, Assam.
- The PM-KISAN is a central sector scheme launched by the Government of India in 2019 to provide essential income support to landholding farmer families across the country.
- NOTE : inception in 2018,
- Under this initiative, eligible farmers receive a total of Rs 6,000 per year, which is disbursed in three equal installments of Rs 2,000 every four months.
- These funds are transferred directly into the bank accounts of the beneficiaries through the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system, ensuring transparency and eliminating the need for middlemen.

NMDC Limited has become the first mining company in India to produce 50 million tonnes (MT) of iron ore in a single financial year.

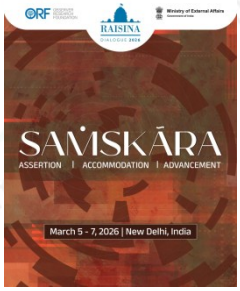


- NMDC Limited (formerly National Mineral Development Corporation) is a Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE).
- Incorporated in 1958, it is under the administrative control of the Ministry of Steel, Government of India.
- Since inception, it has been involved in the exploration of a wide range of minerals, including iron ore, copper, rock phosphate, limestone, dolomite, gypsum, bentonite, magnesite, diamond, tin, tungsten, graphite, beach sands, etc.
- It also operates the only mechanized diamond mine in the country at Panna in Madhya Pradesh.
- It has its registered office in Hyderabad, Telangana.

Government Launches Free SATHEE App

- The Ministry of Education, in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kanpur, introduced the 'SATHEE' app as a free learning platform to help students prepare for national-level competitive exams such as the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE), National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET), and Common University Entrance Test (CUET).
- SATHEE (Self-Assessment, Test and Help for Entrance Exams) offers video lectures and study notes prepared by experts from IITs and other reputed institutions.
- The platform also provides multilingual learning resources free of cost.

11th Edition of the Raisina Dialogue 2026



- The Raisina Dialogue is India's premier conference on geopolitics and geoeconomics, held annually in New Delhi since 2016.
- Organized by the Observer Research Foundation in partnership with the Ministry of External Affairs.
- The theme for 2026 is "Saṁskāra: Assertion, Accommodation, Advancement".
- Dates : Mar 05, 2026 – Mar 07, 2026
- Finland President Alexander Stubb will be the Chief Guest of the premier geopolitical forum.

Dirghavadhi Krishak Punji Sahakar Yojana to strengthen long-term credit

- National Cooperative Development Corporation a statutory organization working under administrative control of Ministry of Cooperation launched 'Dirghavadhi Krishak Punji Sahakar Yojana' to ensure increased and uninterrupted credit flow for capital formation in agriculture and allied sectors.
- The "Dirghavadhi Krishak Punji Sahakar Yojana" has strengthened Agricultural Credit Cooperatives by supplementing their resources with long term financial assistance for onward lending.
- The eligibility criteria and appraisal parameters to assess proposals under the 'Dirghavadhi Krishak Punji Sahakar Yojana' scheme are:-

- The cooperative should have been in operation for not less than 3 years.
- The cooperative should have positive net worth, not less than 100% paid up share capital, i.e. there should be no erosion in the paid up share capital.
- The co operative should not have incurred any cash loss during last three years and there should be net profit in at least two of previous three years.

PM Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY)

- The Union Government has allocated ₹2,500 crore for the fisheries sector under the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) in the Union Budget 2026– 27.
- PM Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) is a flagship umbrella scheme for the sustainable and responsible development of India's fisheries sector, designed to modernize the fisheries value chain and improve the socio-economic welfare of fishers and fish farmers.
- Launched in: The scheme was launched on 10 September 2020.
- Ministry: It is implemented by the Department of Fisheries under the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, Government of India.

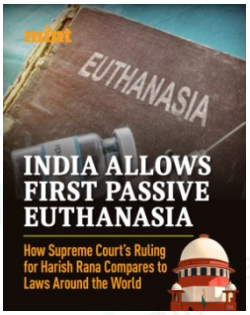
Key Features of the Scheme:

- Large Investment Framework: The scheme was approved with a total investment of about ₹20,050 crore for holistic fisheries sector development.
- Two Implementation Components: It operates through Central Sector (CS) and Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) components.
- Infrastructure Development: Focus on fishing harbours, cold chain facilities, processing units, and modern fish landing centers.
- Aquaculture Promotion: Support for activities such as biofloc farming, sea cage farming, seaweed cultivation, ornamental fisheries, and pearl farming.
- Fisher Welfare Measures: Financial assistance for fishing boats, gear upgrades, and support during fishing ban periods.
- Sustainable Fisheries Management: Promotion of artificial reefs, mariculture, and ecosystem restoration to replenish fish stocks.
- Capacity Building: Training programmes and skill development initiatives for fishers and entrepreneurs.

Union Cabinet approves Jal Jeevan Mission extension until 2028 with lower allocation

- The Union Cabinet approved the extension of Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) till 2028, with an allocation of Rs 1.51 lakh crore.
- Launched in August 2019, the JJM aimed to provide Functional Household Tap Connections (FHTC) to deliver 55 litres per capita per day (lpcd) drinking water to all rural households in the country by 2024.
- It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme, implemented by the Ministry of Jal Shakti.
- The mission is implemented in partnership with States, with funding shared between the Centre and States.

Supreme Court Allows Passive Euthanasia in Harish Rana Case



- The Supreme Court of India has allowed the withdrawal of life- sustaining treatment for Harish Rana, a 32-year-old in a permanent vegetative state since 2013.
- This decision represents the first practical application of passive euthanasia in the country, emphasizing the right to die with dignity.
- The court permitted the withdrawal of all medical support, including Clinically Assisted Nutrition and Hydration (CANH), highlighting a humane and dignified process.
- A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K.V. Viswanathan directed that the process should be supervised by the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, ensuring a robust palliative care plan.
- Gian Kaur Case (1996): A Five-judge bench ruled that the Right to Life under Article 21 does not include the Right to Die, but it distinguished between dying unnaturally and dying with dignity.

- Aruna Shanbaug Case (2011): The landmark case of a nurse in a vegetative state for 42 years led the SC to legalize Passive Euthanasia in India for the first time, subject to High Court approval.
- Common Cause Case (2018): The SC recognized the Right to die with dignity as a fundamental right and legalized Living Wills (advance medical directives).
- 2023 Amendment: The SC simplified the 2018 guidelines, removing the requirement for a judicial magistrate's countersignature on living wills to make the process more practical.
- Euthanasia refers to the deliberate act of ending the life of a person suffering from an incurable disease or irreversible condition to relieve pain and suffering. Euthanasia can only be administered by a physician.

Active euthanasia

- Active euthanasia involves directly causing the death of a patient through deliberate medical intervention, such as administering a lethal injection.
- This form of euthanasia is illegal in India and may amount to culpable homicide or abetment to suicide under criminal law.

Passive euthanasia

- Passive euthanasia involves withdrawing or withholding life-sustaining medical treatment such as ventilators, artificial nutrition or other medical support.
- In such cases, death occurs naturally due to the underlying illness rather than a direct medical action.
- Passive euthanasia is legally permitted in India under strict safeguards laid down by the Supreme Court of India

International Context

- In the US, courts recognize the withdrawal of life support based on patient autonomy and best interests.
- In the UK, withdrawal decisions follow the best-interests doctrine for incapacitated patients.
- Australia allows stopping artificial nutrition when treatment serves no therapeutic purpose.
- New Zealand permits withdrawal when treatment no longer benefits the patient.
- The European Court of Human Rights upholds withdrawal within a regulated legal framework in cases like Lambert v France.

The Supreme Court judgement on creamy layer exclusion for OBC quota

- The Supreme Court (SC) of India has ruled that parental income alone cannot determine the "creamy layer" status of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) candidates, clarifying long-standing confusion in applying reservation rules in civil services examinations.
- Quashing the 2004 Clarificatory Letter: The judgement resolves confusion created by the 1993 Office Memorandum (OM) of the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) and the 2004 clarificatory letter.
- The 1993 DoPT OM had clearly stated that income from salaries and agricultural land should not be counted in the income/wealth test for creamy layer determination.
- However, the 2004 DoPT clarification directed inclusion of salary income of PSU/private sector employees, which resulted in unequal treatment between government employees' children and PSU/private sector employees' children.
- Status-Based over Income-Based: The SC held that creamy layer determination is status-based, not purely income-based, and must consider the parent's employment status and post category (Group A/B/C/D), not just income.
- Constitutional Validity: The SC held that the government engaged in "hostile discrimination" by allowing children of lower-tier government employees to retain OBC reservation benefits based on the status of the parent's post, even if salaries increased.
- Children of equivalent PSU/private sector employees were denied OBC reservation solely because parental salary crossed Rs 8 lakh, treating equals unequally and violating Articles 14, 15, and 16 of the Constitution.
- Relief for PSU/PSB Wards: The verdict may expand OBC reservation eligibility, especially for children of PSU employees and private sector workers previously excluded due to salary-based calculations.
- The Court also directed the government to create supernumerary posts if necessary to accommodate candidates wrongly excluded earlier.

- Creamy Layer: The concept of "creamy layer" was first applied in the 1992 Indra Sawhney vs Union of India judgment to exclude socially advanced OBCs from reservation benefits.
- Under Existing Rules: Children of Group A officers or those promoted before age 40 are excluded from the OBC quota.
- Children of two Group B officers also fall under the creamy layer.
- For non-government occupations, the income limit for creamy layer is Rs 8 lakh annually (since 2017).

Indian Railways launch 'SHINE' to empower women at workplace

- The Indian Railways has launched a customised app for women employees to lodge complaints about sexual harassment at the workplace.
- Sexual Harassment Incident Notification for Empowerment (SHINE) was made operational on the occasion of the International Women's Day on Sunday (March 8, 2026).
- This facility would be in addition to the existing internal complaints committee formed in every organisation in compliance with the Visakha guidelines of the Supreme Court in 1997
- SHINE also allows reporting incidents or complaints on behalf of outsiders (visitors), contractual staff, students and others who may not have access to the app.

Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh launches Bharat Tex

- Union Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh launched Bharat Tex 2026, India's flagship global textile event, which is expected to become one of the largest integrated textile fairs in the world.
- Bharat Tex 2026 is an industry-led initiative organised by the Bharat Tex Trade Federation (BTTF), an umbrella body comprising 11 textile-related Export Promotion Councils and other industry organisations.
- The event will be held from July 14 to July 17, at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi
- The event reflects the Prime Minister's 5F vision -Farm to Fibre, Fibre to Factory, Factory to Fashion, and Fashion to Foreign markets – under the Make in India initiative.

The Department of Posts launched 24 Speed Post

- The Department of Posts launched 24 Speed Post on 17 March 2026 to provide next-day guaranteed delivery services.
- The premium service will initially be introduced in six major metro cities to strengthen India Post's express delivery capabilities.
- 4 Speed Post is a premium next-day guaranteed delivery service introduced by India Post for urgent and time-sensitive consignments.
- It offers assured D+1 delivery timelines with enhanced tracking and secure delivery features.
- Department Involved: The service is launched by the Department of Posts, functioning under the Ministry of Communications.

Aim:

- Provide fast, reliable, and guaranteed next-day delivery for urgent consignments.
- Strengthen India Post's premium express logistics services.
- Support businesses and individuals with time-sensitive shipments.
- The service will initially be available across all PIN codes of six metro cities: New Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad

SWAYATT Initiative

- Recently, the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) celebrated the seven-year journey of its flagship initiative, SWAYATT – Startups, Women and Youth Advantage through e-Transactions.
- SWAYATT Initiative was launched in February 2019.
- It was conceptualised with a clear objective of invigorating participation of women-led enterprises and youth in public procurement.
- It democratizes government procurement by enabling startups, women entrepreneurs, youth, Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs), Self Help Groups (SHGs) and last-mile sellers to directly participate in the public procurement ecosystem through Government e-Marketplace.
- It is rooted in GeM's foundational pillar of social inclusion
- SWAYATT focuses on addressing three critical challenges often faced by emerging enterprises—access to markets, access to finance and access to value addition.

Government e Marketplace

- It is an Online Market platform that was set up in 2016.
- It facilitates the procurement of goods and services by government ministries, departments, public sector undertakings (PSU) etc.
- It has been envisaged as the National Procurement Portal of India.
- It was developed by the Directorate General of Supplies and Disposals (Ministry of Commerce and Industry) with technical support from the National e-governance Division (Ministry of Electronic and Information Technology).

The Blue Book

- A controversy arose after West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and her ministers were absent during President Droupadi Murmu's visit to Bagdogra Airport, triggering allegations of a protocol breach.
- The Blue Book is a confidential protocol and security manual issued by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).
- It lays down detailed procedures for the reception, security, and logistics during visits of the President, Vice-President, and Prime Minister within India.
- Prepared and periodically updated by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs.
- Copies are circulated to relevant authorities and maintained at the district level by the District Magistrate and the district police chief.

Aim:

- To ensure uniform protocol, security arrangements, and administrative coordination during visits of high constitutional dignitaries.
- To maintain dignity, security, and smooth conduct of official engagements of the President, Vice-President, and Prime Minister.

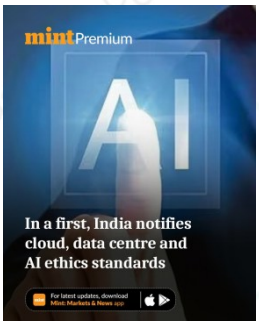
Key Features:

- Reception Protocol – The visiting dignitary is typically received and seen off by the Governor and Chief Minister, or a designated minister if the CM is unavailable.
- Security Arrangements – Mandates high-level multi-layered security coordination involving district administration and police authorities.
- Advance Approval of Protocol Lists – The list of officials who will receive or meet the dignitary must be approved by the respective secretariats (President, VP, PM) beforehand.
- Logistical Guidelines – Covers arrangements related to transport, venue security, routes, crowd management, and emergency preparedness.
- Table of Precedence – Recognizes the President as Rank 1, followed by the Vice-President and Prime Minister, reflecting the constitutional hierarchy.

Commerce Minister Piyush Piyush Goyal Inaugurates 40th AAHAR International Food and Hospitality Fair

- The Union Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will inaugurate the 40th edition of AAHAR 2026, one of the world's premier B2B trade platforms for the food and hospitality industry, on March 10 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.
- Organised by India Trade Promotion Organisation (ITPO).
- Held from March 10 to 14, 2026,
- Italy will feature as the Partner Country for AAHAR 2026
- ITPO also announced the launch of the AAHAR 2026 Official Mobile App,
- The mobile application will allow participants to access a digital exhibitor directory, navigate interactive floor plans, schedule B2B meetings, use smart search filters and receive real-time notifications, enabling exhibitors and visitors to connect more efficiently.

India's New Standards for Cloud, Data Centre, and Ethical AI



- The Indian government, through the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), notified the nation's first-ever standards for cloud computing, data centre performance, and ethical AI deployment.
- The notification under the BIS Rules, 2018, establishes a voluntary but formal framework for digital infrastructure.
- It marks India's shift toward a globally aligned digital ecosystem, ensuring that as conglomerates invest in AI-ready infrastructure, they adhere to recognized performance and ethical benchmarks.

Key Features and Summary of Notification:

- The standards are directly derived from the ISO (International Organization for Standardization) and IEC (International Electrotechnical Commission) frameworks.
- Establishes common definitions and foundational norms for cloud systems to be used across finance, healthcare, and government services.
- Cooling Efficiency Ratio (CER): Formalizes a methodology to measure how efficiently data centres remove heat relative to electrical energy consumed.
- Voluntary Status: Currently, the standards are not mandatory; compliance will only become compulsory if the government issues a Quality Control Order (QCO).

Yoga Mahotsav to commemorate the 100-day countdown to International Day of Yoga-2026

- The Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga (MDNIY), Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, is organising Yoga Mahotsav-2026 .
- An event to mark the beginning of the 100-day countdown to International Day of Yoga-2026, on March 13, 2026 at Vigyan Bhawan.
- The International Day of Yoga (IDY) 2026 will be celebrated on Sunday, June 21, 2026.

Government Launches Campaign Against 'Sarpanch Pati' Practice

- The Union government has launched a nationwide social media campaign to address the practice of "Sarpanch Pati", where male relatives exercise authority in place of elected women leaders in village governance.
- Announced by the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR), the campaign titled "Say No To Proxy Sarpanch" aims to empower women sarpanches and strengthen democratic participation in grassroots governance.
- The initiative coincides with International Women's Day and will run until March 18.

Important Facts for Exams

- The Panchayati Raj system provides local self-government in rural India.
- The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 institutionalised Panchayati Raj institutions.

- The amendment introduced reservations for women in local bodies, often at least one-third of seats.
- Gram Panchayat is the lowest tier of the three- level Panchayati Raj system.

Purple Fest

- Rashtrapati Bhavan hosted the 'Purple Fest' to celebrate the achievements and talents of Divyangjan (persons with disabilities) and promote inclusivity.
- Purple Fest is an inclusive awareness and celebration event organised by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment to recognise the talent, achievements, and aspirations of Divyangjan.
- Aim: It aims to promote awareness, dignity, and equal participation of persons with disabilities in society.

Govt to organise National Conference of Women Elected Representatives of Panchayats

- The Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) will organise a one-day national conference of Women Elected Representatives (WERs) of panchayats under the Sashakt Panchayat–Netri Abhiyan on March 11 in New Delhi.
- The conference will mark one year of the launch of the Sashakt Panchayat–Netri Abhiyan and serve as a national platform to promote women-led grassroots governance in India.
- The Sashakt Panchayat–Netri Abhiyan was launched on March 4, 2025, as a targeted capacity-building initiative aimed at strengthening the leadership and governance role of women elected representatives at the grassroots.

Jal Mahotsav 2026 marks the beginning with Nationwide Observance of Jal Arpan Diwas, observed as "Sujalam Shakti Diwas"

Ministry of Jal Shakti

Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav

Jal Mahotsav 2026 marks the beginning with Nationwide Observance of Jal Arpan Diwas, coinciding with International Women's Day, observed as "Sujalam Shakti Diwas" across the country.

Union Minister of Jal Shakti, Shri C.R. Paatil, marks the Shubharambh of Jal Mahotsav 2026 from Navsari, Gujarat.

Minister of State for Ministry of Jal Shakti, Shri V. Somanna, graces Jal Arpan celebrations in Karli village, Sindhudurg, Maharashtra & Minister of State for Ministry of Jal Shakti, Shri R.B Choudhary, participates in Jal Arpan celebrations from Kudhni, Muzaffarpur, Bihar.

Nationwide Campaign Strengthens Jan Bhagidari Through Gram Panchayat and Advances the Vision of Sujal Gram

Posted On: 08 MAR 2026 7:16PM by PIB Delhi

On the occasion of International Women's Day, the **Union Minister of Jal Shakti, Shri C. R. Paatil, marked the Shubharambh of Jal Mahotsav 2026**, a nationwide campaign of the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS), Ministry of Jal Shakti, from Village Rahej in Gandevi Block of Navsari district, Gujarat, with the observance of **Jal Arpan Diwas**, symbolising **handing over of drinking water assets to the Gram Panchayat** to strengthen community ownership of rural drinking water systems under the Jal Jeevan Mission. The shubharambh of Jal Mahotsav coincides with **International Women's Day**, observed as **"Sujalam Shakti Diwas."**

While the **Minister of State for Jal Shakti, Shri V. Somanna**, participated in the programme from Village Panchayat Parulebajar, Karli village, Sindhudurg district,

- Union Minister of Jal Shakti, Shri C. R. Paatil, marked the Shubharambh of Jal Mahotsav 2026, a nationwide campaign of the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS), Ministry of Jal Shakti, from Gujarat.
- Jal Mahotsav campaign will be observed annually from 8th to 22nd March.
- Under the tagline "**गाँव का उत्सव, देश का महोत्सव**".
- Also the observance of Jal Arpan Diwas, symbolising handing over of drinking water assets to the Gram Panchayat to strengthen community ownership of rural drinking water systems under the Jal Jeevan Mission.

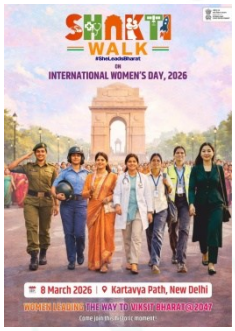
C-DOT receives recognition at Mobile World Congress 2026 for indigenous AI-driven fraud detection solution

- India's Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT) received global recognition at the Mobile World Congress 2026 in Barcelona for its AI-driven fraud detection solution Fraud Pro.
- C-DOT is India's premier telecom research and development (R&D) organization working on indigenous telecom technologies and digital network solutions.
- It functions as an autonomous telecom technology centre under the Department of Telecommunications (DoT).
- Established in August 1984 by the Government of India.
- Registered as a society under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 and recognized as a Public Funded Research Institution by the Department of Scientific and Industrial Research (DSIR).

Aim:

- To design, develop, and deploy indigenous telecom technologies suited to India's diverse and large-scale communication needs.
- To strengthen self-reliance in telecom infrastructure and digital communication technologies.

#SheLeadsBharat – Shakti Walk Initiative



- The Ministry of Women and Child Development organised the Shakti Walk #SheLeadsBharat at Kartavya Path, New Delhi to mark International Women's Day 2026.
- #SheLeadsBharat is a national campaign highlighted through the Shakti Walk initiative, aimed at celebrating the leadership and contributions of women in India.
- Symbolic route – The walk covered Kartavya Path from India Gate to Vijay Chowk, symbolising unity and national commitment to gender equality.

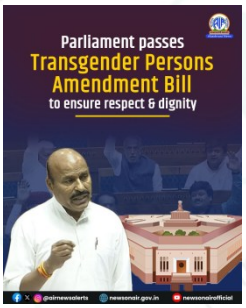
BEE Marks 25 Years of Energy Efficiency Leadership

- Recently, the 25th Foundation Day of the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE), Ministry of Power, Government of India, was celebrated in New Delhi on 1st march .
- It is a statutory body which was established in 2002 under the provisions of the Energy Conservation Act, 2001.
- Objective: The primary objective of BEE is to reduce energy intensity in the Indian economy.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Power.

Schemes of Bureau of Energy Efficiency

- National Mission for Enhanced Energy Efficiency (NMEEE),
- Energy Conservation Building Code (ECBC),
- Standards and Labeling Scheme,
- Municipal Demand Side Management (MuDSM) Scheme,
- Agricultural Demand Side Management (AgDSM) Scheme.

Parliament Passes Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026



- The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 proposes modifications to the 2019 law that protects transgender persons from discrimination and ensures their welfare.
- The original Act was enacted following the Supreme Court's landmark judgment in the NALSA v. Union of India (2014) case, which recognised transgender persons as the third gender and affirmed the right to self- determination of gender identity under Article 21

Changes in the Amendment Bill:

- Removal of right to self-perceived gender identity
- The amendment proposes deleting Section 4(2) of the 2019 Act, which recognises a person's right to self-perceived gender identity.

Redefinition of transgender person:

Narrows the definition to include:

- Socio-cultural identities such as hijra, kinner, aravani, jogta, eunuch
- Persons with intersex variations
- Individuals with congenital biological variations in sexual characteristics
- It excludes persons identifying solely based on self-perceived gender identity or gender fluidity.
- The definition also includes individuals forced to adopt transgender identity through mutilation, castration, hormonal procedures or coercion.
- Introduces the concept of an authority (medical board headed by a Chief Medical Officer) to examine gender certification cases.
- Changes in transgender certificate procedure: Instead of automatic issuance, the District Magistrate must review recommendations from the medical authority before granting a certificate.

- Mandatory gender certificate revision after surgery: Persons undergoing Sex Reassignment Surgery (SRS) must apply for a revised gender certificate, whereas earlier it was optional.
- A new provision allows transgender persons to change their first name in official records, subject to the new definition criteria.

IT expands criminal provisions with graded punishments (including imprisonment and fines up to ₹5 lakh) for crimes such as:

- Denial of access to public places
- Forced labour
- Expulsion from homes

Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions- 2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0)

- The Government of India has launched the Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions-2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0) to inject ₹20,000 crore into the microfinance sector.
- A specialized credit guarantee framework where the government provides a guarantee to Member Lending Institutions (MLIs) against potential defaults on loans extended to NBFC-MFIs and other MFIs.
- This scheme acts as a financial cushion for banks, encouraging them to lend to microfinance bodies that might otherwise be considered high-risk during periods of financial stress.
- Launched In: March 2026

Key Features of the Scheme:

- Provides a safety net covering 80% of the defaulted amount for small MFIs, 75% for medium, and 70% for large MFIs, prioritizing smaller players.
- A nominal fee of 0.50% p.a. is charged to the lending institutions, making the risk-mitigation affordable.
- The scheme is valid until June 30, 2026, or until a total guarantee limit of ₹20,000 crore is reached.

The union cabinet approved the 'Small Hydro Power (SHP) Development Scheme for the period FY 2026-27 to FY 2030-31'

- It supports the installation of small hydro projects (1-25 MW capacity each) with a total capacity of 1,500 MW across the country.
- Its special focus is on hilly and North-Eastern states that hold high untapped potential.
- Time Period: FY 2026-27 to FY 2030-31'.

Key Features of Small Hydro Power Development Scheme

- Higher central financial assistance (CFA) of ₹3.6 crore per MW (or 30% of cost, capped at ₹30 crore per project) for North Eastern states and international border districts.
- CFA of ₹2.4 crore per MW (or 20% of cost, capped at ₹20 crore per project) for other states.
- Allocation of ₹30 crore to support government agencies in preparing Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for about 200 future projects.
- Mandates 100% sourcing of plant and machinery from domestic manufacturers to boost the local industrial base.
- The initiative emphasises environment-friendly "run-of- the-river" technology that generates power directly from the natural flow of rivers without large dams, minimising displacement, deforestation and ecological disruption.

Regional Connectivity Scheme – Modified UDAN

- The Union Cabinet has approved the Regional Connectivity Scheme – Modified UDAN with an outlay of ₹28,840 crore for 2026–2036.
- Modified UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) is the evolved second phase of India's flagship regional airport development program, designed to make air travel sustainable and accessible for the next decade.
- While the original scheme began in 2016, the Modified UDAN was approved by the Union Cabinet on March 25, 2026, for implementation starting from FY 2026-27.
- The scheme seeks to transform India into a globally competitive aviation ecosystem by connecting underserved regions, reducing travel costs for the common citizen, and supporting the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Key Features:

- An outlay of ₹12,159 crore to develop 100 airports from existing unserved airstrips over the next eight years.
- Development of 200 modern helipads at a cost of ₹15 crore each to solve connectivity challenges in hilly, island, and remote areas.
- Viability Gap Funding (VGF): A dedicated fund of ₹10,043 crore to provide financial support to airline operators, ensuring routes remain profitable while keeping fares low for passengers.
- Focused on indigenous manufacturing by procuring HAL Dhruv helicopters and HAL Dornier aircraft for state-run carriers like Pawan Hans and Alliance Air.

India's Nationally Determined Contribution (2031-2035)

- The Union Cabinet has approved India's updated Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) for 2031- 2035 to be submitted to the UNFCCC.
- Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) are climate action plans submitted by countries under the Paris Agreement to describe their self-defined targets for reducing greenhouse gas emissions and adapting to climate impacts.
- Term: This specific NDC covers the period from 2031 to 2035, building upon the targets previously set for 2030.

Key Targets Announced:

- Emissions Intensity: Reduce the emissions intensity of its GDP by 47% by 2035 (from 2005 levels).
- Non-Fossil Fuel Power: Achieve 60% cumulative electric power installed capacity from non-fossil fuel- based energy resources by 2035.
- Carbon Sink: Create an additional carbon sink of 3.5 to 4.0 billion tonnes of CO2 equivalent through expanded forest and tree cover by 2035.

Other Key Features:

- Whole-of-Government Approach: Formulated through 10 NITI Aayog working groups involving central ministries, industry bodies, and civil society to ensure targets are realistic and inclusive.

- Promotes the LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment) movement and community-driven actions like Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam to turn climate action into a mass movement.
- Leverages the Green Hydrogen Mission, PM Surya Ghar (Solar Rooftop), and Carbon Capture, Utilization, and Storage (CCUS) technologies.
- Reaffirms India's role in international alliances like the International Solar Alliance (ISA) and the Global Biofuel Alliance.

Commerce Ministry launches RELIEF scheme to support exporters amid West Asia crisis

- Recently, the Government of India has approved the RELIEF (Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation) scheme to support exporters facing severe maritime disruptions in West Asia.
- It is aimed at supporting Indian exporters affected by extraordinary freight escalation, heightened insurance premiums and war-related export risks arising from disruptions in the Gulf and wider West Asia maritime corridor.
- It is a time-bound and targeted intervention launched under the Export Promotion Mission (EPM)

Features of RELIEF Scheme

- Exporters with existing ECGC cover for shipments between 14 February and 15 March 2026 receive up to 100% risk coverage for additional conflict-linked losses.
- For shipments planned between 16 March and 15 June 2026, the government supports up to 95% risk coverage to maintain exporter confidence.
- Non-insured MSME exporters can claim up to 50% reimbursement (capped at ₹50 lakh per exporter) for extraordinary freight and insurance surcharges incurred during the initial disruption month.
- Regional Scope: Applies to all consignments destined for or transshipped through the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Israel, Qatar, Oman, Bahrain, Iraq, Iran, and Yemen.
- Implementation: By ECGC Ltd.

The union Cabinet has approved the Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA)

- It aims to develop world-class industrial infrastructure, unlocking manufacturing potential and driving India's growth story.
- Target: Developing 100 plug-and-play industrial parks across the country.
- Implementation: BHAVYA will be implemented in partnership with states and private sector players
- Total expenditure of ₹33,660 crore, providing up to ₹1 crore per acre for park development.
- Plug-and-Play Ecosystem: Provides ready-built factory sheds, testing labs, and underground utilities to enable industries to move from "intent to production" with speed.
- Plug-and-play infrastructure refers to industrial parks that are fully equipped with all necessary utilities and regulatory clearances before an investor arrives
- Aligned with PM GatiShakti principles for seamless multimodal connectivity; external infrastructure support is provided up to 25% of the project cost.

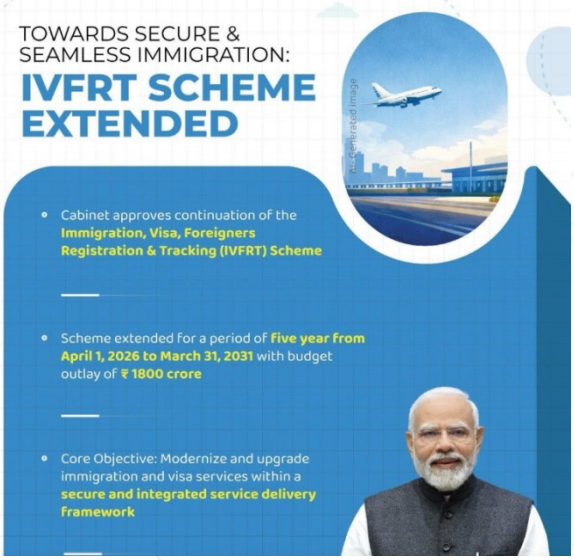
RISA: Timeless Tribal

- The Ministry of Tribal Affairs has launched RISA: Timeless Tribal, a premium signature brand to promote tribal crafts and textiles.
- RISA: Timeless Tribal is a premium national brand for tribal textiles, embroidery, and handicrafts, designed to showcase India's indigenous craftsmanship in domestic and global premium markets while preserving cultural heritage.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Tribal Affairs
- Implementing Agency: TRIFED (Tribal Cooperative Marketing Development Federation of India)
- To preserve and promote tribal weaves, embroidery, and crafts.
- To support Vocal for Local and Atmanirbhar Bharat through value addition
- First phase covers 10 clusters including weaves, embroidery, and crafts across states.

Diverse craft inclusion: Covers iconic tribal products like:

- Eri silk (Assam)
- Pashmina (Ladakh)
- Dokhra art (Chhattisgarh)
- Toda embroidery (Tamil Nadu)

Cabinet extends immigration, visa tracking system for another five years



- The Union Cabinet has approved the continuation of the Immigration, Visa, Foreigners Registration & Tracking (IVFRT) Scheme for five years (2026–2031) with an outlay of ₹1,800 crore.
- The IVFRT is a mission-mode project designed to create a secure, integrated, and service-oriented framework for managing the lifecycle of travelers—from visa application and entry into India to their activities within the country and final exit.
- The newly approved phase will run from April 1, 2026, to March 31, 2031.
- Implemented by: the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).
- It was originally approved in 2010; the project has undergone multiple phases of expansion and extension.
- The latest approval comes in the backdrop of the recently enacted Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025,

Features of IVFRT Scheme

The scheme will concentrate on three broad areas —

- Emerging technology innovations, transformation of core infrastructure and optimisation of technology-enabled service delivery
- The scheme will modernize the immigration and visa ecosystem through adoption of emerging technologies, including mobile-based services and self-service kiosks for seamless and secure passenger movement.
- It will upgrade and expand core infrastructure across Immigration Posts, FRROs, and Data Centres to build a resilient and scalable system nationwide.
- It will optimize technology and service delivery by introducing unified digital platforms, revamping core application architecture, and strengthening network and deployment frameworks for improved efficiency and user experience.

Exported Products (RoDTEP) Scheme

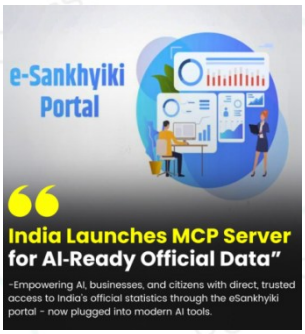
- The Government of India has decided to restore the rates and value caps under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) Scheme for all eligible export products.
- It was introduced through an amendment to the Foreign Trade Policy 2015-20, and it became effective for exports starting January 1, 2021.
- The primary aim of this scheme is to offset the taxes and duties incurred on exported goods that wouldn't otherwise be credited, reimbursed, or refunded in any way, and are integrated into the exported goods.

- It is compliant with World Trade Organization (WTO) norms and is implemented via a comprehensive end-to-end digital platform to ensure transparency and efficiency.
- It was enforced to repeal and reduce taxes on exported products, thereby encouraging exports and increasing the number of exports in the country.
- The scheme is administered by the Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance.
- It replaced the Merchandise Export Incentive Scheme (MEIS).

RoDTEP Scheme Eligibility Criteria

- All sectors are covered under the scheme.
- Labor-intensive sectors will be accorded priority.
- Both manufacturer exporters and merchant exporters (traders) are eligible for the scheme.
- The exported products should have India as their country of origin to be eligible for benefits under the scheme.
- Special Economic Zone Units and Export Oriented Units are also eligible.
- The scheme also applies to goods that have been exported via courier through e-commerce platforms.
- Re-exported products are not eligible under this scheme.

Model Context Protocol (MCP)



- The Government of India has launched a Model Context Protocol (MCP) server to link AI tools with the e-Sankhyiki portal, allowing AI applications to access verified official statistical data directly.
- The Model Context Protocol (MCP) is an open-source standard designed to connect Artificial Intelligence models (like Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini) to external data sources, tools, and workflows
- It acts as a universal interface that allows AI to reach out and interact with databases or local files securely and efficiently.
- Originally introduced as an open standard in late 2024 (by Anthropic), with the Indian Government's specific implementation for official statistics launched in early 2026.

Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) Framework

- Recently, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy has introduced ALMM List-III for ingots and wafers, which will come into effect from the 1st of June, 2028.
- It is a quality-and-reliability framework that ensures solar equipment used in the country's solar projects meet the domestic manufacturing standards.
- It was introduced under the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) Order, 2019.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), Government of India.

Krishi Sakhi Initiative

- The Agriculture Insurance Company of India Limited has launched the Krishi Sakhi Initiative to empower women farmers.
- Krishi Sakhi Initiative is a nationwide program aimed at empowering women farmers through awareness, participation, and capacity building in agriculture and crop insurance.
- Organisation: Launched by Agriculture Insurance Company of India Limited.
- Structured activities (videos, walkathons, workshops) conducted throughout 2026.

GARBH-INi Initiative

- Recently, the Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology said that India's largest pregnancy cohort study of 12,000 women under the GARBH-INi initiative is aimed at developing indigenous, AI-driven solutions to address preterm births.

GARBH-INi Initiative

- It promotes Maternal and Child Health and develops prediction tools for preterm birth.
- It is an interdisciplinary Group for Advanced Research in BirtH outcomes- DBT India Initiative (GARBH-Ini) has initiated a cohort study of pregnant women in May 2015.

- To acquire deep fundamental knowledge on adverse pregnancy outcomes such as preterm birth (PTB) and fetal growth restriction (FGR)
- Apply this knowledge to identify efficient and sustainable solutions that would assist in reducing associated mortality, immediate and long term morbidity.
- It is an initiative under the Department of Biotechnology of the Union Ministry of Science and Technology as a collaborative interdisciplinary programme.
- This program is led by the Translational Health Science and Technology Institute (THSTI), NCR Biotech cluster, Faridabad.
- It is part of the Atal Jai Anusandhan Biotech Mission – Undertaking Nationally Relevant Technology Innovation (UNaTI).

What is a Preterm Birth?

- It is defined as babies born alive before 37 weeks of pregnancy are completed.

There are sub-categories of preterm birth, based on gestational age:

- Extremely preterm (less than 28 weeks)
- Very preterm (28 to 32 weeks)
- Moderate to late preterm (32 to 37 weeks).

Districts as Export Hubs (DEH) Initiative.

- Recently, the Minister of State for Ministry of Commerce & Industry informed the Lok Sabha about the Districts as Export Hubs (DEH) Initiative.
- It was launched in August 2019 to foster balanced regional development across all districts of the country.
- The objective of DEH is to identify, brand, and promote products from each district, encouraging their sale in both domestic and international markets.
- It is an initiative of the Directorate General of Foreign Trade, Department of Commerce.
- An institutional mechanism has been set up in all States/UTs by forming the State Export Promotion Committee (SEPC) and District Export Promotion Committee (DEPC) at the district level.
- The initiative has identified export potential in 734 districts across the country, spanning critical sectors like agriculture, toys, and GI products.
- Coverage: The DEH initiative has identified products and services with export potential in all districts across the country, including GI products, agricultural clusters, and toy clusters

The Union Minister for Information & Broadcasting launched the national AI Skilling Initiative

- It is aimed at strengthening AI capabilities in areas such as animation, visual effects, gaming, comics (AVGC) and media technology.
- It was launched by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, in partnership with Google and YouTube.
- Implementation: It is being implemented through the Indian Institute of Creative Technologies (IICT).

Features of National AI Skilling Initiative

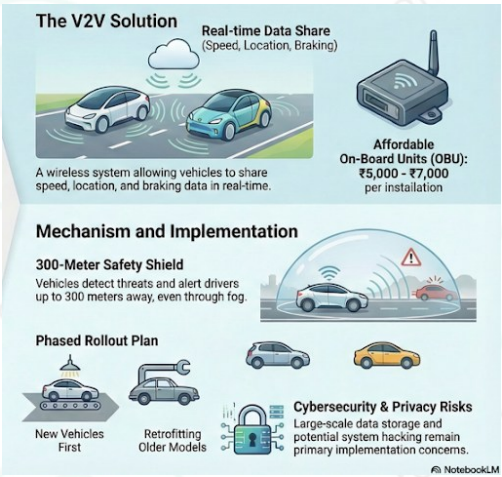
It will be conducted in two phases.

- Phase I: It will focus on foundational AI learning at scale through Google Career Certificates and Google Cloud Generative AI learning paths.
- Participants will undergo courses such as AI Essentials, Prompting Essentials, Introduction to Generative AI, and Generative AI Leader Path. Successful completion of this phase will be mandatory for progression to the next stage.
- Phase II: It will focus on advanced, hands-on and project-based specialization for the creative industry.

Jal Seva Aankalan Framework

- The Government has operationalised the 'Jal Seva Aankalan' framework under the Jal Jeevan Mission to assess rural water service delivery.
- A village-level assessment and monitoring framework under the Jal Jeevan Mission, where service delivery of rural tap water is evaluated through community participation and digital reporting.
- To ensure regular, adequate, and safe drinking water supply by identifying service gaps and enabling evidence-based planning for sustainable water management.

'Talking cars' Vehicle-to-Vehicle (V2V) safety technology



- The government is planning to launch Vehicle-to-Vehicle (V2V) safety technology to prevent road accident deaths and reduce traffic.
- India ranks first in the world in total road accident fatalities, far ahead of second- and third-ranked countries: China accounts for just 36%, and the United States for 25%, of India's road deaths.
- — V2V or vehicle-to-vehicle communication is a wireless technology that will enable the vehicles to communicate or talk with one another to share real-time information like speed, location, acceleration, braking, etc.
- It is the sub-category of Vehicle-to-Everything (V2X) and comes under the umbrella of the Intelligent Transport System.
- The system is similar to the aviation sector technology, where aircraft broadcast their position, speed, altitude, and the nearby aircraft and ground stations receive it.
- Usually, V2V systems have a range of 300 metres and can detect vehicles in this range.

V2V is only a sub-category of V2X (Vehicle-to-Everything). V2X includes:

- Vehicle-to-Infrastructure (V2I)
- Vehicle-to-Pedestrian (V2P)
- Vehicle-to-Network (V2N)

NHAI to roll out AI-powered dash cams to monitor road maintenance, safety

- To enhance road maintenance and improve safety, the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has decided to deploy AI-based dashcam systems across approximately 40,000 km of the national highway network.
- Under this initiative—known as Dashcam Analytics Services (DAS)—specialised high-resolution dashboard cameras will be installed on Route Patrol Vehicles (RPVs). These vehicles will conduct weekly surveys of highway stretches.
- The primary focus will be on pavement condition, including potholes, cracks, rutting, and surface deterioration, along with issues such as faded lane markings, damaged crash barriers, and non- functional streetlights.
- The system will also identify other safety concerns, including illegal median openings, unauthorised signboards, encroachments, and illegal parking

PRISM-SG Portal

- Recently, the Minister for Road Transport and Highways launched the PRISM-SG Portal in New Delhi.
- PRISM-SG (Portal for Rail-Road Inspection & Stages Management – Steel Girders) Portal aimed at enhancing efficiency, transparency, and inter-agency coordination in infrastructure development.
- It has been developed to digitise key approval and inspection processes related to the construction of
- The portal enables end-to-end online submission of documents, scrutiny, raising and resolution of queries, approvals, scheduling of inspections, and uploading of inspection reports, photographs, test results, supported by a complete audit trail and real- time monitoring capabilities.
- It addresses challenges by providing an integrated digital platform that brings together all key stakeholders, including Road Owning Departments, Indian Railways, contractors, fabricators, and inspection agencies.

PRISM-SG Portal launched to Digitise and Accelerate Approval Processes for ROB in Highway and Railway Projects

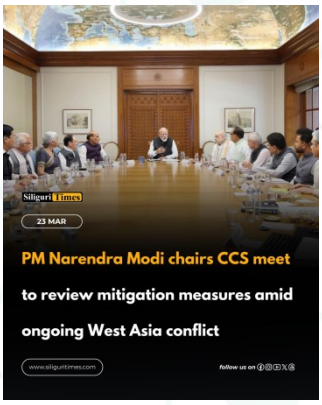
Posted On: 25 MAR 2026 6:26PM by PIB Delhi

In a major step towards enhancing efficiency, transparency, and inter-agency coordination in infrastructure development, Hon'ble Minister for Road Transport and Highways, Shri Nitin Gadkari, along with the Hon'ble Minister for Railways, Information & Broadcasting, Electronics & IT, Shri Ashwini Vaishnaw, today launched the PRISM-SG (Portal for Rail-Road Inspection & Stages Management – Steel Girders) Portal in New Delhi.

NHAI-sponsored Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust (RIIT) is being officially listed on the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) in March 2026.

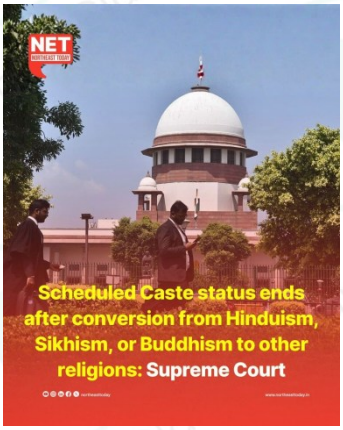
- RIIT is an Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT), a collective investment vehicle similar to a mutual fund but specifically designed for infrastructure assets.
- It is registered with SEBI and constituted as an irrevocable trust under the Indian Trusts Act, 1882.
- Trust Registered: December 22, 2025.
- Raajmarg Infra Investment Managers Private Limited (RIIMPL) – responsible for day-to-day management.

Cabinet Committee on Security



- Recently, the Prime Minister Of India chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the global situation and various mitigating measures taken so far across sectors amid the conflict in West Asia.
- It is headed by the Prime Minister, and is responsible for important discussions and decisions on defence policy, expenditure, and matters related to national security.
- A committee comparable to the current CCS structure was first formed in independent India in 1947 by then-Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru.
- It was reportedly chaired by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, with Home Minister Sardar Patel and Defence Minister Baldev Singh as its members.
- It was after the 1999 Kargil War that the committee evolved to adopt the present formal structure of the CCS and became a high-powered committee for defence and national security.
- With the Prime Minister as its chairperson, the committee typically comprises the Home Minister, Defence Minister, Finance Minister, and External Affairs Minister as members.
- The National Security Advisor (NSA) acts as secretary-level coordinator on matters within its purview.
- While the defence minister is a permanent invitee to the panel.
- Function: The CCS concerns itself with all matters related to defence, foreign affairs, intelligence, nuclear issues, space policy, and major appointments related to national security.
- It is also the apex body when it comes to the appointments of the officials in the national security bodies.

Supreme Court concludes only Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists can claim Scheduled Caste status



- The Supreme Court ruled that a person who professes a religion other than Hinduism, Sikhism, or Buddhism cannot be a member of a Scheduled Caste.
- A two-judge bench headed by Justice P K Mishra.
- While upholding the April 30, 2025, order of the Andhra Pradesh High Court, the bench said the position is made clear by the Constitution (Scheduled Caste) Order, 1950.
- Mandates that "no person who professes a religion different from Hinduism shall be deemed to be a member of a Scheduled Caste"
- A Scheduled Caste person who converts to Christianity can not claim violation of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.
- This bar is absolute and admits no exception.

National Dental Commission

- The Government of India has formally constituted the National Dental Commission (NDC), replacing the decades-old Dental Council of India (DCI) effective March 19, 2026.
- A statutory regulatory body that replaces the Dental Council of India (DCI) following the repeal of the Dentists Act, 1948. The National Dental Commission is the new apex regulatory body for dental education and profession in India, established to align oral healthcare with global standards.
- Established In: March 19, 2026 (following notifications issued on the same date).

Governing Structure: Supported by three specialized boards:

- Undergraduate and Postgraduate Dental Education Board: Oversees dental education standards.
- Dental Assessment and Rating Board: Regulates accreditation and institutional assessments.
- Ethics and Dental Registration Board: Governs professional conduct and the national register of dentists.

Suraksha Sankalp Karyashala

- The Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, through NACO, organised the Suraksha Sankalp Karyashala to strengthen district-level HIV/AIDS response in Haryana and Delhi.
- Suraksha Sankalp Karyashala is a national-level workshop initiative aimed at strengthening district-level HIV/AIDS response through coordinated, data-driven planning and stakeholder engagement.

Aim:

- Strengthen HIV care continuum: Improve diagnosis, treatment linkage, and viral suppression at district level.
- Accelerate epidemic control: Achieve 95:95:99 targets and move towards ending HIV/AIDS by 2027–2030.

GlobE Network

- India hosted the 12th Steering Committee Meeting of the Global Operational Network of Anti-Corruption Law Enforcement Authorities (GlobE Network) in New Delhi.
- The GlobE Network is a global platform of specialised anti-corruption law enforcement authorities.
- It was established under the Riyadh Initiative during Saudi Arabia's G20 Presidency.
- It is operating under the framework of the United Nations Convention Against Corruption (UNCAC)
- The Network comprises 135 member countries and 250 member authorities, along with 18 observers including EUROPOL, the World Bank, and the International Association of Anti-Corruption Authorities.
- The Ministry of Home Affairs is the central authority for GloBE Network, while the CBI and the Enforcement Directorate are its member authorities from India.
- The GlobE Network complements formal legal assistance mechanisms by enabling faster, more flexible, and direct agency-to- agency engagement.

India Hosts 12th Steering Committee Meeting of the GlobE Network

The 12th Steering Committee Meeting of the Global Operational Network of Anti-Corruption Law Enforcement Authorities (GlobE Network) commenced today in New Delhi, with India serving as host. The opening session was attended by the Director, Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Director, Directorate of Enforcement (ED), Special Directors, senior representatives of the GlobE Secretariat under the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), and delegates from across the GlobE Network's member nations. The three-day meeting, being held from 23 to 25 March 2026, brings together the fifteen member nations of the Steering Committee to deliberate on the Network's strategic direction, operational priorities, and evolving frameworks for international cooperation.

About the GlobE Network

The GlobE Network is a global platform of specialised anti-corruption law enforcement authorities, established under the Riyadh Initiative during Saudi Arabia's G20 Presidency. Operating under the framework of the United Nations Convention Against Corruption (UNCAC), the Network enables direct, practitioner-level cooperation among member agencies for the investigation, prosecution, and recovery of proceeds of corruption. Today, the Network comprises **135 member countries and 250 member authorities**, along with 18 observers including EUROPOL, the World Bank, and the International Association of Anti-Corruption Authorities. The GlobE Network complements formal legal assistance mechanisms by enabling faster, more flexible, and direct agency-to-agency engagement.

The fifteen nations currently serving on the GlobE Steering Committee are: **Azerbaijan, Brazil, China (including Hong Kong and Macau SARs), Ethiopia, Grenada, India, Italy, Nigeria, Romania, Russia, Saudi Arabia, Spain, South Africa, South Korea, and the United Arab Emirates.**

- It enables direct, practitioner-level cooperation among member agencies for the investigation, prosecution, and recovery of proceeds of corruption.
- The Network is governed by its members and is supported by the United Nations Office against Drugs and Crime (UNODC) which provides the Network's secretariat

India Conducted First BRICS Youth Coordination Meeting 2026

- The Department of Youth Affairs, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, Government of India organized the first BRICS Youth Coordination Meeting on 25th March 2026 in virtual format.
- The meeting was attended by representatives from all BRICS member countries.
- As India assumed the BRICS Chairship for 2026, the theme "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability," setting the direction for youth cooperation during the year.

About BRICS

- British economist Jim O' Neill in 2001 coined the acronym 'BRIC' representing the emerging economies of Brazil, Russia, India, and China.
- BRIC started functioning as a formal grouping on the margins of the G8 Outreach Summit in 2006. The 1st BRIC Summit was held in Russia in 2009.
- BRIC became BRICS with the inclusion of South Africa in 2010.
- Aim: To reform global governance and provide alternatives to Western-dominated institutions (IMF, World Bank, UNSC).
- Chairmanship: Rotates annually among member countries.
- Initial members (BRICS): Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa.
- New members (BRICS+): Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Indonesia, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates.

The Ministry of Railways has planned to introduce the B28 trainset.

The Indian EXPRESS

Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train project: Here's why B28 trainset is crucial for 2027 launch

- The B28 train is the Bharat made Bullet trainset.
- The manufacturing of B28 bullet trainset is currently underway at BEML's (Bharat Earth Movers Limited) Bengaluru rail coach complex.
- The defence PSU was awarded the contract in October 2024 by Chennai-based Integral Coach Factory (ICF) to design, manufacture and commission two high-speed trainsets
- According to Railways, bullet train project is a very complex and technology intensive project.
- The project involves technology transfer and procurement/supply from Japan and other countries.
- The development of E10 series of Shinkansen is underway in Japan.
- However, a decision has been taken to start the operation using B28.
- Efforts are underway to start operation using B28 (Bharat made Bullet, 280 kmph) for Surat to Vapi (97km) in Aug 2027.

MY Bharat to Organise Nationwide Shaheed Diwas Padyatra 2026 across 763 Districts under the theme "MY Bharat, My Responsibility"

- In a solemn tribute to the unparalleled sacrifice of India's young freedom fighters - Shaheed Bhagat Singh, Shaheed Shivaram Rajguru, and Shaeed Sukhdev Thapar, the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, through Mera Yuva Bharat (MY Bharat), will organise a nationwide Padyatra on March 23rd, 2026, marking Shaheed Diwas.
- The initiative will be conducted under the theme "MY Bharat, My Responsibility."
- Padyatras will be organised across all 763 districts of the country, with a major event to be organised in Faridabad, Haryana

The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026

- The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which was introduced in the Lok Sabha
- seeks to amend the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, known as FCRA.
- The Act regulates the acceptance and utilisation of foreign contributions and hospitality by NGOs to ensure such "inflows do not adversely affect national interest, public order or national security".
- The Act has been amended thrice already, in 2016, 2018 and 2020.

What is the amendment?

- The amendment seeks to provide a comprehensive framework for such cases by establishing a designated authority to supervise and manage the foreign contributions and assets in case the FCRA certificate is cancelled or ceased.
- The amendment gives the Central government the power to appoint the designated authority that would control the funds and assets in case the FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered or ceased.
- Clause 16A (7) of the amendment says that in case of a place of worship, the designated authority can entrust the management or operation of the asset to a person in such manner as may be prescribed.
- It must be ensured "that the religious character of such place of worship is maintained,

Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026

- The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) has notified the Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026, which will replace the existing 2016 framework starting April 1, 2026.
- The SWM Rules, 2026, are a comprehensive regulatory framework designed to modernize India's waste management system.
- They shift the focus from a collect-and-dump model to a circular economy approach that prioritizes resource recovery, recycling, and accountability for all waste generators.
- Legal Basis: Issued under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986.
- Predecessor: These rules supersede the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016.

Key Features of the New Rules:

- Mandatory Four-Stream Segregation: Waste must be separated at the source into four categories:
- Wet Waste: (Organic/Food) to be composted or bio-methanated.
- Dry Waste: (Plastic, paper, metal) to be sent to Material Recovery Facilities (MRFs).
- Sanitary Waste: (Diapers, napkins) to be wrapped securely for separate handling.
- Special Care Waste: (Domestic hazardous items like paint, bulbs, medicines).
- Extended Bulk Waste Generator Responsibility (EBWGR): Entities generating more than100 kg/day, consuming more than 40,000 liters of water/day, or having more than 20,000 sq.m. area must process organic waste on-site or obtain EBWGR certificates.
- Digital Governance: A Centralised Online Portal will track waste from generation to final disposal, including registrations, reporting, and audits.
- Polluter Pays Principle: Introduction of Environmental Compensation for non-compliance, such as operating without registration or submitting false data.
- Refuse-Derived Fuel (RDF) Promotion: Mandates industries (like cement plants) to increase RDF substitution from 5% to 15% over six years.

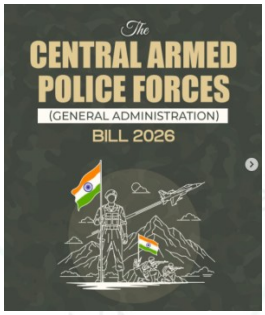
PM e-Drive Scheme

- Recently, the Ministry of Heavy Industries has extended subsidies for electric two-wheelers till 31 July 2026, and for electric rikshaw and electric carts till 31 March 2028 under the PM E- DRIVE scheme.
- The PM E-DRIVE (Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement) scheme is a flagship initiative launched in October 2024.
- It came into effect from October 1, 2024.
- Its primary aim is to accelerate the adoption of electric vehicles (EVs), establish charging infrastructure, and build a robust EV manufacturing ecosystem in the country.

The PM E-DRIVE scheme to be implemented through the following key components:

- Demand incentives to be provided for electric vehicles such as e-2 wheelers (e-2W), e-3 wheelers (e-3W), e-ambulances, e-trucks, and other emerging categories of EVs.
- Funding to be provided for the acquisition of electric buses (e-buses), the establishment of a comprehensive network of charging stations, and the upgrading testing facilities of the Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI).
- Under this, states are encouraged to offer additional fiscal and non-fiscal incentives, such as road tax waivers, reduced toll and parking fees, and permit exemptions, to further promote EV adoption.
- The PISC will be responsible for monitoring progress and ensuring the scheme's successful rollout.
- To qualify for the PM E-DRIVE incentives, vehicles must be registered as "Motor Vehicles" under the Central Motor Vehicle Rules (CMVR) and equipped with advanced battery technology.

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026



- The Central Government introduced the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026 in the Rajya Sabha.
- The Bill is a regulatory framework designed to govern the recruitment, promotion, and service conditions of Group 'A' General Duty Officers and other personnel within specified CAPFs.
- It seeks to provide legislative clarity to the historical practice of IPS officers leading these forces, ensuring that the unifying link between the Union and the States remains structurally intact.

Key Features of the Bill:

- Scope of Application: Applies to five primary CAPFs: CRPF, BSF, CISF, ITBP, and SSB. The government can add more forces via notification.
- Rule-Making Power: Empowers the Central Government to frame rules for recruitment, deputation, and service conditions, overriding any existing laws or court orders.
- Mandatory IPS Deputation: Explicitly earmarks high-level posts for IPS officers:
- 50% of Inspector General (IG) posts.
- Minimum 67% of Additional Director General (ADG) posts.
- 100% of Special Director General (SDG) and Director General (DG) posts.
- Protection of Benefits: Saves and continues all existing financial benefits granted to Group 'A' officers prior to the Act.
- Personnel Coverage: Includes Group 'A' executive officers (Assistant Commandant and above), IPS officers on deputation, and Army officers on deputation or re-employment.

Superior Kerosene Oil (SKO)

- The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has issued a gazette notification allowing the distribution of Superior Kerosene Oil (SKO) under the Public Distribution System (PDS) across 21 States and UTs, including Delhi and Gujarat.
- Superior Kerosene Oil (SKO) is a highly refined middle distillate fraction of crude oil.
- In India, it is primarily distributed through the Public Distribution System (PDS) to provide energy security to low-income households.
- It is a specific grade of kerosene that has undergone extra processing to remove impurities (like sulphur and aromatics), ensuring it meets stringent quality standards for domestic and industrial use.

Applications:

- Domestic Cooking: Used in wick stoves and pressure stoves as a primary or backup cooking fuel.
- Lighting: Widely used in hurricane lanterns and simple lamps in areas with unreliable power grids.
- Industrial Use: Used as a solvent in paints, a degreaser in mechanical workshops, and a base for some pesticide formulations.
- Aviation: When further refined and treated with additives, a similar fraction serves as Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF).

How it differs from Regular Kerosene?

Feature	Superior Kerosene Oil (SKO)	Regular/Low-Grade Kerosene
Refining Level	Highly refined with fewer impurities.	Less refined; contains more aromatics.
Burning Quality	Clean-burning; produces minimal soot/smoke.	Produces more smoke and a distinct odor.
Sulphur Content	Strictly controlled (very low).	Higher sulphur content, leading to more indoor pollution.
Primary Use	Household cooking and lighting.	Often used for heating or as an industrial furnace fuel.
Safety	Higher flash point for domestic handling.	May have more volatile components.

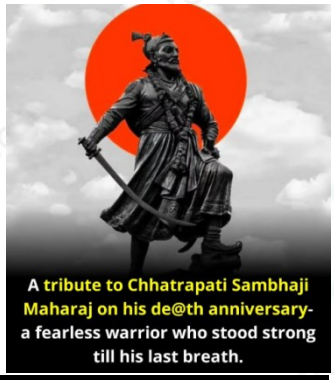
'Stable' live-in couples to be considered married in Census 2027

- Live-in couples, who consider "their relationship as a stable union" will be counted as a married couple in 2027 Census.

The 2027 Census will be conducted in two phases.

- The first phase of Census 2027 set to launch this April 1
- Phase 1 will include house listing and housing census where house-to-house field work will be done in 30 days between April and September 2026.
- In phase 1, information regarding housing conditions, household details, availability of amenities such as drinking water, toilets, electricity, fuel used for cooking, internet, etc.; and possession of assets such as radio, TV, computer, two wheelers, four-wheelers, etc. by the household is collected.
- Phase 2 will include population enumeration beginning February 2027 across India except UT of Ladakh and snow-bound areas of the UT of J&K, and the States of Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand where it will be conducted in September 2026.

Eminent Personalities in News



March 11 Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj death anniversary

- He was born on 14 May 1657 at Purandar Fort near Pune
- Predecessor: Shivaji Maharaj
- Sambhaji ruled from 1681 to 1689 as the second king of the Maratha Empire.
- He was the eldest son of Shivaji, the founder of the Maratha Empire
- Battle of Burhanpur (1681): Successful Maratha raid on the Mughal garrison.
- Cause of Death : Executed by the Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb in 1689

Dr Ram Manohar Lohia birth anniversary

- Birth: 23rd March, 1910 in Akbarpur, Uttar Pradesh.
- Ram Manohar Lohia was an Indian political activist of the Indian independence movement and a socialist politician.

Lohia's Idea of Socialism:

Lohia identified five kinds of inequalities that need to be fought against simultaneously:

- Inequality between man and woman,
- Inequality based on skin colour,
- Caste-based inequality,
- Colonial rule of some countries over others, and
- Economic inequality.

Pre-Independence Role:

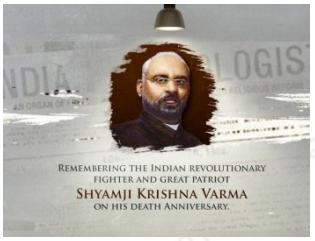
- In 1934, he became actively involved in the Congress Socialist Party.
- A vehement opponent of Indian participation on the side of Great Britain in World War II (1939-45), he was arrested for anti-British remarks in 1939 and again in 1940.
- With the emergence in 1942 of the Quit India movement—a campaign initiated by Mahatma Gandhi to urge the withdrawal of British authorities from India—Lohia and other CSP leaders (such as Jaya Prakash Narayan) mobilized support from the underground.

  For such resistance activities, he was jailed again in 1944–46.
- Some of his works include: 'Wheel of History', 'Marx, Gandhi and Socialism', 'Guilty Men of India's Partition', etc.
- Death: 12th October, 1967.

Sikkim's Stuti Pradhan Selected to Represent India at World Youth Parliament

- Stuti Pradhan, a promising young leader from Sikkim, has been selected to represent India at the prestigious World Youth Parliament.
- The World Youth Parliament is an international platform that brings together young delegates from countries such as South Korea, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, Chad, Thailand, Yemen, and several others to discuss pressing global issues and explore youth-led policy solutions.
- Stuti Pradhan, a state-level winner of the Viksit Bharat Youth Parliament 2025.

The Prime Minister of India paid homage to freedom fighter Shyamji Krishna Varma on his death anniversary on 30th March



- Shyamji Krishna Varma was born on 4th October, 1857 in Mandvi town of Kachchh district of Gujarat.
- He was an Indian freedom fighter, lawyer and journalist.
- He became the first President of Bombay Arya Samaj and was an admirer of Dayanand Saraswati.

Contributions

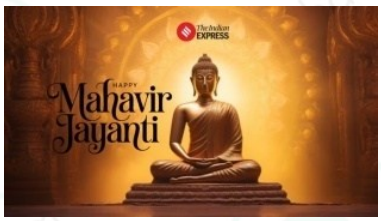
Indian Home Rule Society (IHRS)

- It was founded by Shyamji Krishna Varma, with support from Bhikaji Cama, Dadabhai Naoroji and S.R. Rana.
- It was an Indian organisation founded in London in 1905 that sought to promote the cause of self-rule in British India.

India House

- It was founded by him in London.
- It was a student residence that existed between 1905 and 1910 which was opened to promote nationalist views among Indian students in Britain.
- Indian Sociologist: It was started in London. The monthly Indian Sociologist became an outlet for nationalist ideas..

2624th birth anniversary of Lord Mahavir



- Mahavir Jayanti, or Mahaveer Janma Kalyanak, is one of the most important festivals of Jainism, marking the birth of Lord Mahavir, the 24th and last Tirthankara.
- Also known as Vardhamana, Lord Mahavir established the fundamental principles of Jainism
- The festival is widely celebrated among Jain communities in India, Nepal, the United States, and the United Kingdom.
- Lord Mahavir was born on the Trayodashi Tithi during the Shukla Paksha of the Chaitra month, which is the 13th day of the rising moon of March and April as per the Gregorian calendar, resulting in different dates each year.
- Born as Vardhamana into the royal family of Queen Trishala and King Siddhartha in Kundagram, present- day Bihar, India, in 599 BC.
- Mahavira teaching his philosophy of Ahimsa (nonviolence), Satya (truth), Asteya (non-stealing), Brahmacharya (chastity), and Aparigraha (non- attachment), which later became the essential principles of Jainism

State Specific News

Jammu & Kashmir

Jammu University Hosts Goonj 2026 Youth Festival

- The University of Jammu is going to organise 3rd edition of its flagship multi-genre youth festival, Goonj 2026.
- The journey of Goonj was started in 2024 and the initiative was conceived with a clear vision, to promote holistic development of students
- The Goonj 2026 comprises three major segments – Sports, Cultural Activities and the Best Practices Showcase.

Sharansthli Initiative

- The Lieutenant Governor of Jammu & Kashmir, distributed compassionate appointment letters to 50 next of kin of terrorism victims under the Sharansthli initiative in Srinagar.
- Sharansthli is a rehabilitation initiative of the Jammu & Kashmir administration aimed at supporting families of victims who lost their lives due to terrorism.
- Under the programme, compassionate government employment is provided to the next of kin of terror victims to help them rebuild their livelihoods and restore dignity.

Aim:

- Provide stable government employment to families affected by terrorism.
- Acknowledge the suffering of terror victims and ensure institutional support.
- Eligible family members of terror victims receive government jobs under compassionate appointment rules to ensure long- term livelihood security.
- Cases are processed through coordination between police and civil administration to verify victims and ensure legitimate appointments.
- The government is reviewing additional cases of terror victim families, ensuring more beneficiaries receive employment assistance.

Zojila Pass

- A tragic avalanche at the high-altitude Zojila Pass, resulted in the death of five individuals and left several others injured or trapped.
- Zojila is a strategic high mountain pass in the Western Himalayas.
- Often referred to as the mountain pass of blizzards (though scientifically named after the Tibetan goddess Du-Zhi-lha-mo), it serves as the only terrestrial link between the Kashmir Valley and the high-altitude cold desert of Ladakh.
- It is situated at an elevation of approximately 3,580 metres (though some sections reach up to 5,008 metres), making it the second-highest pass on the Srinagar–Leh Highway after Fotu La.
- It connects Sonmarg (Kashmir) to the Dras and Suru valleys, eventually leading to Leh.

History:

- 1948 Indo-Pak War: The pass was a major battleground during the First Kashmir War. It was initially seized by Gilgit rebels/Pakistan forces in 1948.
- Operation Bison: In a historic military feat on November 1, 1948, Indian forces recaptured the pass using tanks.
- The Tunnel Era: To overcome the pass's vulnerability to heavy snowfall and avalanches, the Zoji-la Tunnel (14 km long) is currently under construction. Once finished, it will be the longest bidirectional tunnel in Asia.

Himachal Pradesh

Himachal Pradesh Government Presents ₹54,928 Crore Budget for 2026-27

- Himachal Pradesh chief minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu presented the state budget for the financial year 2026–27, with a total outlay of Rs 54,928 crore.
- The budget estimates an economic growth rate of 8.3 per cent for 2025-26, a per capita income of 2,83,626 Rs. and a GSDP of 2.54 lakh crore Rs.
- The Budget for 2026-27 pegs fiscal deficit at Rs 9,698 crore, or 3.49 per cent of the State Gross Domestic Product.
- To protect crops from wild animals, Rs 10 crore has been allocated under the 'Mukhya Mantri Khet Badhbandi Yojana'.
- In a move to strengthen the fisheries sector, the chief minister announced the 'Mukhya Mantri Machhuara Sahayata Yojana'.
- The scheme sets the MSP for reservoir fish at Rs 100 per kg and reduces the royalty rate on fish caught from reservoirs from 7.5% to 1%, benefiting approximately 6,000 fishermen.
- Outlining a vision of a prosperous Himachal through "Vyavastha Parivartan" (systemic transformation) in rural economy, announced the establishment of the Himachal Pradesh State Farmers' Commission.

Uttarakhand

Uttarakhand Govt Introduces 'e-Swasthya Dham' for Real-Time Health Monitoring During Char Dham Yatra

- Uttarakhand government has made special health arrangements for this year's Char Dham Yatra.
- The health of pilgrims visiting the Yatra will be monitored in real time through the 'e-Swasthya Dham' portal so that medical assistance can be provided immediately when required.

Uttarakhand govt introduces Devbhoomi Family Bill- 2026 in Assembly during budget session

- The Uttarakhand government introduced the "Devbhoomi Family Bill-2026" in the Assembly during the budget session at Gairsain.
- The bill aims to ensure the effective implementation of welfare schemes and provide transparent assistance to beneficiaries.
- it will establish a unified and verified family-based database called the "Devbhoomi Family".

- Under this system, the eldest female member of the family, aged 18 or above, will be registered as the head of the family.
- This will make scheme administration more effective, transparent, and coordinated.

Roopkund Lake

- Roopkund Lake, often called Skeleton Lake, is famous for the hundreds of human skeletons found around its icy waters.
- Roopkund, also known as the " lake of skeletons" is a glacial lake in Uttarakhand.
- It is situated at 5,029 metres (16,500 ft) above sea level at the base of Mt. Trishul in the Garhwal Himalayas.
- The lake is encased in ice for the majority of the year.
- It is called the "lake of skeletons" as the glacial body conceals numbers of human skeletons, some with preserved flesh.

Key discoveries from scientific studies:

- The remains belong to more than 300 individuals.
- The skeletons came from different time periods.

Lipulekh Pass Trade to Resume Between India and China

- The historic cross-border trade between India and China through the Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand's Pithoragarh district is set to resume this June.
- Location: It is a high-altitude mountain pass located in the Kumaon region of Uttarakhand, near the trijunction of India, Nepal, and China.
- It links the Indian state of Uttarakhand with the Tibet region of China.
- Altitude: It lies at an altitude of approximately 5,334 meters (17,500 feet).

- Its elevation and strategic location make it a gateway to the higher reaches of the Himalayas.
- It is the first Indian border post opened for trade with China in 1992.
- Other passes: This was followed by the opening of Shipki La Pass, Himachal Pradesh in 1994 and Nathu La Pass, Sikkim in 2006.
- Ancient Trade Route: Lipulekh Pass has been utilized for centuries as a trade route, connecting the Indian subcontinent with the Tibetan plateau.
- Religious Significance: It is a key corridor for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra and plays an important role in connecting border communities, especially tribal groups such as the Bhotiyas who depend on cross-border trade

Punjab

Punjab Government Launches 'Punjab Sikhya Kranti 2.0' to Reform School Education in Collaboration with World Bank

- The Punjab Government has launched a new phase of school education reform, 'Punjab Sikhya Kranti 2.0', in collaboration with the World Bank to prepare the state's education system to compete with the best in the world.
- According to government sources, the second phase has been launched with a total investment of Rs 3,500 Crore over the next six years.

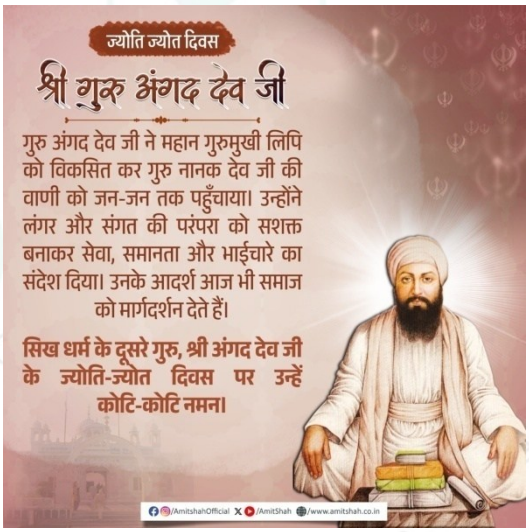
Punjab Budget: Rs 1,000 per month for women under Mukh Mantri Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojana

- Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema, presenting the State Budget for 2026-27.
- The fiscal deficit is estimated at 4.08% of the GSDP, with the effective revenue deficit pegged at 2.06%.
- The GSDP is projected to reach ₹9,80,635 crore in FY 2026-27, marking a 10% growth rate.
- Committed liabilities are estimated to consume approximately 72% of its revenue receipts — in actual terms, ₹90,335 crore out of the estimated collections of ₹1,26,190 crore — in the 2026-27 financial year.
- The centrepiece of the budget is the ₹9,300-crore Mukh Mantri Mawan Dhian Satikar Yojna, a direct benefit transfer scheme.
- Government will transfer ₹1,000 per month to all adult women. For women belonging to the Scheduled Caste community, the monthly payout is set at ₹1,500.
- The only exclusions are government employees, income tax payees, and current or former MPs/MLAs.
- Women already receiving social security pensions (old- age, widow, or disability) will remain eligible for this additional benefit.
- FM allocated ₹2,000 crore for the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna, providing ₹10 lakh annual health cover per family.

Punjab Assembly Passes Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur World-Class University Bill 2026

- Punjab Vidhan Sabha has unanimously passed Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur World Class University Punjab Bill, 2026, to establish a cutting-edge world-class university on the name of the 9th Guru on the sacred land of Sri Anandpur Sahib.
- A total of 300 crore rupees has been proposed for investment over the next three years, with an initial allocation of Rs. 20 crore in the current budget.
- The university will offer North India's first specialised courses in defence, aerospace, cyber security and quantum computing.

HM Amit Shah Pays Tributes to Guru Angad Dev on Jyoti Jyot Day



- Recently, the Union Home Minister paid tributes to the second Sikh Guru, Shri Angad Dev on the occasion of his Jyoti-Jyot Diwas.
- Guru Angad (31 March 1504–29 March 1552) was born with the birth name of Lahna the village of Matte-di-Sarai (now known as Sarai Naga), near Muktsar of Punjab, India.
- He was the second Sikh Guru (1539–52).
- He introduced the Gurmukhi script, standardizing the Punjabi language.
- He introduced the teaching of Punjabi in Gurmukhi script by modifying the existing alphabet.
- He improved literacy among the Sikhs and started school at Khadur Sahib to teach Gurmukhi to the children.
- He composed 62 hymns in 10 Ragas.
- He consolidated the institution of Langar started by Guru Nanak Dev Ji.
- He also established hundreds of new Sangats (Sikh religious Institutions) and thus strengthened the base of Sikhism

Haryana

'Abhedya': Haryana Police's new app to block threat calls before they reach citizen

- Conceptualised as a "proactive digital shield to counter extortion, stalking and cyber harassment", Haryana Police launched 'Abhedya', a mobile-based system that prevents citizens from even coming into contact with threatening or abusive communication.
- The application works by automatically rejecting suspicious calls, blocking numbers and removing messages, voice notes or notifications before they can be accessed by the user

Biotechnology Research and Innovation Council (BRIC)

- The inaugural meeting of the BRIC-Research Advisory Board (BRIC-RAB) was held at the Regional Centre for Biotechnology (RCB), Faridabad.
- BRIC is an Apex Autonomous Body established as a registered Society under the Department of Biotechnology (DBT), Ministry of Science and Technology.
- It was formed by subsuming 14 distinct Autonomous Institutes (AIs) into a single, cohesive entity to centralize research efforts and optimize resource utilization in the biotech sector.
- The restructuring was initiated in late 2023, and the operational transition into the current BRIC framework reached its strategic maturity with the constitution of the Research Advisory Board (RAB) in 2026.
- Aim: The primary aim of BRIC is to transform India's fragmented biotechnology research landscape into a decentralized national laboratory.

Delhi

Delhi Cantonment Board Launches SMART for Sanitation Monitoring

- The Delhi Cantonment Board (DCB) has launched a new digital platform called Swachhata Monitoring & Automated Reporting Tool (SMART) to improve transparency, efficiency and real-time monitoring of sanitation and civic services across the cantonment area.
- The initiative aims to address long-standing challenges such as manual reporting, delays in data collection and fragmented monitoring systems by introducing an automated and integrated digital solution.

Its key features and benefits include:

- Real-Time Monitoring: Enables real-time tracking of works carried out by staff across sanitation, horticulture, civil, and electrical departments.
- Automated Reporting: Reduces manual effort by generating accurate and timely reports for informed decision-making.
- User Role Management: Provides secure, role-based access aligned with user responsibilities.
- Centralised Dashboard: Offers a single platform for monitoring key performance indicators across all departments.
- Enhanced Accountability: Improves operational workflows by ensuring timely submission of verified data.

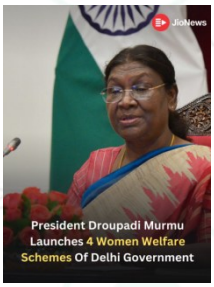
Second Phase of Viksit Bharat Yuva Connect Programme Launched in Delhi

- The Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports launched the second phase of the Viksit Bharat Yuva Connect Programme in Delhi .
- The initiative is being organised through Mera Yuva Bharat, or MY Bharat, to strengthen youth engagement with the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.
- Interactive sessions, dialogues and engagement activities will be organised to connect young citizens with India's development journey and encourage their role as responsible nation builders.

PM Modi Inaugurates India's First Ring Metro In Delhi

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated two new corridors of the Delhi Metro, including India's first fully operational 'Ring Metro'.
- The launch includes the Majlis Park–Maujpur-Babarpur corridor of the Pink Line and the Deepali Chowk–Majlis Park extension of the Magenta Line.
- With the addition of this stretch, the Pink Line has expanded to about 71.56 km, making it India's first fully operational 'Ring Metro'.
- The Delhi Metro is one of the largest metro rail networks in the world.
- The Delhi Metro project is implemented by the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC).

President Droupadi Murmu launches four women welfare schemes of Delhi Government



- President Droupadi Murmu launched the Pink National Common Mobility Card and three other women-centric welfare schemes of the Delhi government.
- The President launched a scheme providing two free LPG cylinders annually to ration card-holding families on Holi and Diwali.
- She further launched the Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana and the "Meri Poonji, Mera Adhikar" initiative - the Delhi government helps its citizens to claim their money that is lying unclaimed in banks, post offices, insurance companies, mutual funds or pension accounts for many years.

The new Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojna

Aid	Rs 56,000
Eligibility	Domicile or resident of Delhi for last three years
Annual family income	Rs 1.2 lakh
Deposits	Rs 11,000 within one year of birth
	Rs 5,000 each on admission to classes I, 6, 8, 10 and 12; Rs 25,000 in all
	Rs 20,000 in phases after diploma or graduation
Cap	2 girls per family
Transfer of aid	To be credited phase wise via Aadhar-linked DBT
Maturity amount	After Class 12 and 18 years of age, or completed graduation/diploma and 21 years of age
Unclaimed amounts	To be credited back to the government
Aid under existing Delhi Ladli Scheme	Rs 36,000

Delhi set to hold first International Film Festival

- Delhi is set to host its first international film festival from March 25 to 31, with more than 140 films from 47 countries to be screened across multiple venues in the national capital.
- The International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) 2026 will feature free public screenings, discussions, workshops and cultural programmes

Smog-Eating Photocatalytic Coating

- Recently, the Delhi government and Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras collaborated to study "smog- eating" photocatalytic coatings on roads.
- It is designed to neutralize harmful gases like nitrogen dioxide and volatile hydrocarbons that contribute to toxic air.
- Compound used: It usually uses titanium dioxide as a coating which has advantages for being low-cost and chemically stable.
- Titanium dioxide is also known for its compatibility with traditional construction materials.
- It has been "demonstrated that TiO_2-based photocatalytically active construction materials can be useful for gaseous depollution and environmental cleaning processes.
- Working: Photocatalytic activity helps fight pollution by breaking down harmful substances and organic waste into less toxic or harmless matters using light energy, thereby making air and water cleaner.

Uttar Pradesh

Yaksh App

- The Uttar Pradesh Police's recently launched Yaksh App helped in tracing and identifying robbers within three hours of the incident in Jaunpur..
- The app maintains multi-angle photographs of criminals, enabling the victim to confirm the identity of the perpetrator(s).
- The app will instantly display relevant missing reports registered at any police station, enabling faster identification and reunification with families if a child, elderly person, woman or mentally ill individual is found abandoned anywhere in the state.
- Also play a key role in identifying unidentified bodies

UP Cabinet approves 90% fee concession for UP T-20 League matches at Green Park Stadium

- The Uttar Pradesh Cabinet approved a proposal granting a 90 per cent concession in the standard event fee for UP T-20 League matches organised by the Uttar Pradesh Cricket Association (UPCA) at Green Park Stadium in Kanpur.
- Under the new arrangement, UPCA will receive a 90 per cent concession on the standard event fee of Rs 25 lakh for events organised under the talent search programme.
- As a result, UP T-20 league matches will attract a charge of Rs 2.5 lakh per match per day.
- For second-tier international matches, such as games involving India 'A' teams, the government has fixed a fee of Rs 5 lakh per match per day.

Other important decisions

Amendment to Higher Judicial Service rules, alters promotion quota:

- Under the revised provisions, the promotion quota from civil judge (senior division) has been reduced from 65 per cent to 50 per cent, with promotions based on merit, seniority and suitability examinations.
- Meanwhile, the quota through the Limited Departmental Competitive Examination has been increased from 10 per cent to 25 per cent, while the 25 per cent quota for direct recruitment from advocates remains unchanged.

Asset disclosure norms for government employees tightened:

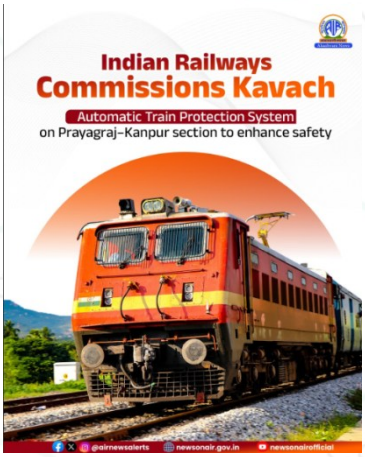
- The Cabinet also approved amendments to the Uttar Pradesh Government Servants Conduct Rules, 1956, introducing stricter disclosure requirements for investments and assets of government employees.
- Under the revised rules, employees must inform the competent authority if their investments in stocks, shares or other instruments exceed six months of their basic pay in a calendar year.
- Purchases of movable property exceeding two months of basic pay must also be reported.
- In addition, government employees will now be required to declare details of their immovable property every year instead of once every five years.

Kalinjar Fort

- The hill region surrounding the Kalinjar Fort in Banda was officially declared a National Geo-Heritage Site by the Geological Survey of India (GSI) recently.
- It is located in the Banda district of Uttar Pradesh.
- It is situated on an isolated hilltop, surrounded by the Vindhya Mountains and the Ken River.
- Historical documents and inscriptions indicate that a strategic fort was established during the Gupta period (4th-6th century).
- Later, Kalinjar came under the Chandela dynasty (9th-13th century) and became one of their capitals.
- During the rule of the Chandela kings, the fort developed into a military fort on one side and a religious centre on the other.

- Mahmud Ghaznavi, Qutubuddin Aibak, and Humayun attacked it and wanted to win it but could not succeed.
- Finally, in 1569 AD, Akbar won this fort and gifted it to Birbal.
- After Birbal, this fort came under the Bundel king Chhatrasal.
- After them, the fort was occupied by Hardev Shah of Panna.
- In 1812, this fort became under the British.
- The fort also houses mosques, temples, palaces, and stepwells.
- One of the main attractions of Kalinjar is the Neelkanth Temple.
- The Shiva lingam is of blue stone in addition to the giant 18-arm statue in the temple.

Railways Commission Kavach System on Prayagraj– Kanpur Section



- Kavach is an indigenously developed Automatic Train Protection (ATP) system designed to enhance railway operational safety.
- It has been developed by the Research Design and Standards Organisation (RDSO) under Indian Railways (IR) in collaboration with Medha Servo Drives Pvt Ltd, HBL Power Systems Ltd, and Kernex Microsystems.
- Kavach is a highly complex digital safety ecosystem consisting of five major integrated components, including continuous Optical Fibre Cable (OFC) laid along tracks and telecom towers for uninterrupted communication.
- The system uses a combination of electronic devices and Radio Frequency Identification (RFID) installed in locomotives, signalling systems, and railway tracks, which communicate using ultra-high radio frequencies.
- Based on pre-programmed safety logic, Kavach can alert loco pilots, automatically apply brakes, and prevent unsafe train movements.

President DroupadiMurmu extends greetings to citizens in India and abroad on the eve of RamNavami.

- It is a spring Hindu festival.
- The festival marks the birth of Lord Rama, the seventh incarnation of Lord Vishnu.
- The day is the ninth and last day of Chaitra Navaratri.
- This typically occurs in the Gregorian months of March or April every year.

'Surya tilak' illuminates the forehead of RamLalla in Ayodhya's Shree Ram Janmabhoomi Mandir.

- The Surya Tilak Project, a remarkable endeavour, recently unfolded at Ayodhya, bringing sunlight to the forehead of Sri Ram Lalla.
- The Surya Tilak Project represents a unique fusion of technology and tradition, meticulously engineered to illuminate the forehead of Lord Ram's idol with a precise beam of sunlight during the revered festival of Ram Navami.

Surya Tilak Project

- Core: Opto-mechanical system → integrates optical +mechanical components for precise sunlight control.
- Works like a periscope system (mirrors/prisms to redirect light).
- Uses 19-gear mechanism → adjusts yearly for Sun's position.
- Every year → 1 gear tooth manually turned → changes pickup mirror angle.
- Implementation by: Central Building Research Institute (CSIR)

Bihar

Nitish Kumar resigns from Bihar Legislative Council

- Bihar Chief Minister and Janata Dal (United) President Nitish Kumar has resigned from his membership of the State Legislative Council, complying with constitutional provisions, after his recent election to the Rajya Sabha.
- An official announcement regarding the Chief Minister's resignation is expected soon.

March 22- Bihar Diwas

- The day commemorates the establishment of Bihar as an independent province in 1912 after it was separated from the Bengal Presidency.
- It is bounded by Nepal to the north and by West Bengal to the northeast and Uttar Pradesh to the west.
- In November 2000 the new state of Jharkhand was created from Bihar's southern provinces and now forms the state's southern and southeastern borders.
- Capital : Patna
- State Flower: Genda/ Marigold
- State Tree: Peepal
- State Bird: House Sparrow
- State Animal: Bullock
- Ex Chief Minister: Nitish Kumar
- Governor: Shri Arif Mohammed Khan
- Rivers: Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Panar, Pun-Pun, Saura, Bagmati, Ghagra, Son, Mahananda, Sapt Koshi, Bhutahi Balan
- Dance and Music forms : Jat-Jatin dance of the Mithila region, Bidesia (popular folk theatre), Jhijhian dance, Kajari dance, Sohar-khilouna dance
- State Arts: Madhubani painting
- Two Ramsar wetlands - Nagi and Nakti bird sanctuaries
- World Heritage site: Mahabodhi temple complex at Bodh Gaya, Nalanda Mahavihara (Nalanda University) at Nalanda
- Tribes: Santhal, Oraon, Munda, Ho, Kharwar, Kharia, and Bhumij
- Bihar Vidhan Sabha : 243
- Bihar Legislative Council : 75 (63 Elected + 12 Nominated)

Jharkhand

The President of India extended greetings to thecountrymen on the occasion of the Sarhul festival

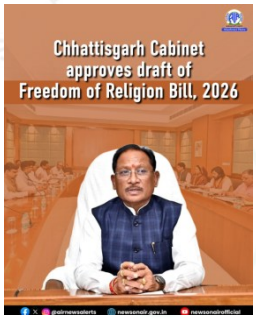
- Sarhul, literally "worship of the Sal tree", is among the most revered Adivasi festivals.
- It is rooted in nature worship and celebrates the symbolic union of the Sun and the Earth.
- The Sal tree is revered as the abode of Sama Maa, the village- protecting deity.
- Sarhul marks the renewal of life.
- It is celebrated by various tribes, including the Oraon, Munda, Santal, Khadia, and Ho, each with unique names and traditions associated with the festival.
- Sarhul is celebrated in Jharkhand and parts of Odisha, West Bengal, and Chhattisgarh.

Three-Day Festival

- Preparations begin, with homes and Sarna Sthals cleaned, Sal flowers gathered, and the village priest (pahan) observing a strict fast.
- Main rituals are performed at Sarna Sthals (Sacred Groves), including sacrifices, prayers for prosperity, and cultural performances.
- Concludes with a community feast, featuring Handia (rice beer), ceremonial fishing, and traditional Adivasi cuisine.
- Only after its rituals are completed do Adivasis begin agricultural activities like ploughing, sowing, and forest gathering, emphasizing the festival's deep ties to nature and sustenance.

Chhattisgarh

Chhattisgarh Cabinet approves new anti-conversion law draft



- The cabinet approved the draft of the Chhattisgarh Dharm Swantantraya Vidheyak, 2026 (Chhattisgarh Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026), which seeks to effectively curb conversion from one faith to another through force, allurement, undue influence or false representation.
- Currently, the Chhattisgarh Dharm Swantantraya Adhiniyam (Freedom of Religion Act), 1968, is in force in the state, which came into existence on November 1, 2000.
- The bill is likely to be introduced in the ongoing budget session of the assembly.
- The new proposed anti-conversion law of the State government would have a provision to curb 'changai sabha' or faith healing meetings.
- The draft made after studying laws in nine states, suggests to follow a standard procedure for religious conversion, that includes prior intimation to the district administration, 60 days before taking up another religion.

Chhattisgarh Assembly passes Chhattisgarh Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026

- The legislation seeks to prohibit religious conversions carried out through deceit, force, allurement, or digital means.
- Under the provisions of the new Bill, any attempt at religious conversion through fraudulent means, coercion, or digital platforms will be a cognizable and non-bailable offence.
- The legislation prescribes stringent punishment, including imprisonment ranging from seven to ten years.
- Convicts will also face a minimum fine of five lakh rupees.

Chandigarh

Chandigarh achieves 99.93% literacy, gets 'fully literate U.T.' tag

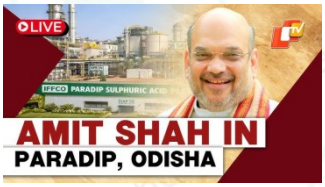
- Chandigarh attained 99.93% literacy rate, thus making it a fully literate Union Territory,
- It is the sixth State/U.T. in the country and the second Union Territory to achieve the feat.
- Among Union Territories, only Ladakh had earlier achieved the milestone.
- India's first widely recognised fully literate state was Kerala
- The success achieved under the Understanding Lifelong Learning for All in Society (ULLAS) has helped the city surpass the 95% literacy benchmark set under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- Mizoram is the first state declared fully functionally literate under the ULLAS programme. This means an individual (aged 15+) can read, write, and compute with comprehension, moving beyond just signing their name.
- Kerala, on the other hand, is widely recognised as India's first fully literate state, achieving this through the Total Literacy Campaign in 1991.In the video, we referred to the overall first fully literate state in India.

Odisha

Kusunpur Set to Become Odisha's First Smart Village

- Kusunpur village in Odisha's Kendrapada district is set to become the state's first "smart village" under a technology-driven rural development initiative led by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR).
- The Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) operates under the Ministry of Science and Technology.
- The concept of "smart villages" focuses on technology- driven rural development and sustainable resource use.

Amit Shah Inaugurates Sulphuric Acid Plant at IFFCO Paradeep



- Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah dedicated the newly commissioned Sulphuric Acid Plant– III (SAP–III) at the Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Limited (IFFCO) complex in Paradeep, Odisha.
- The plant has a production capacity of nearly 2,000 metric tonnes per day.
- Sulphuric acid is a key raw material used in the production of phosphatic fertilisers.

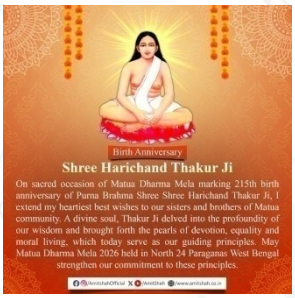
Medieval Gajapathi Inscription Found in Guntur Temple

HISTORIC GAJAPATI INSCRIPTION SURFACES

- A Telugu medieval inscription associated with the Gajapathi rulers of Odisha has been recently discovered on a stone pillar of the historic Lakshmi Narasimha Swamy Temple at Ramachandrapura Agraharam in Guntur city.
- Gajapati Empire was a medieval Hindu dynasty in the Indian subcontinent, originally from the region of Odisha, that reigned from c. 1434 to 1541.
- It succeeded the Eastern Gangas as the Gajapati monarchs and was founded by Kapilendra Deva of the Suryavamsa lineage after the death of the last ruler of the Eastern Ganga, king Bhanu Deva IV.
- Initially, the capital of the Gajapati Empire was located in Cuttack.
- However, during the reign of Prataparudra Deva (1497 to 1540), the capital was shifted to Kataka, now known as Konark.
- The Gajapatis, at the height of their power in the 15th century, ruled over an empire extending from the Ganges in the north near Hoogly to the Kaveri in the south.
- The empire's architectural prowess is exemplified by the iconic Sun Temple at Konark, a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- Gajapatis' patronage of the Odia language, literature, and performing arts contributed to the cultural renaissance of Odisha.

West Bengal

Matua Dharma Mela



- The 2026 Matua Dharma Mela, celebrating the 215th birth anniversary of Sri Sri Harichand Thakur, is held in North 24 Parganas, West Bengal, in March 2026
- The Matua Dharma Mela is an important religious and cultural gathering for followers of the Matua faith and is observed annually to commemorate the legacy and teachings of Harichand Thakur, who founded the Matua movement advocating social equality and spiritual devotion.

PM Modi Inaugurates Fully Automated Haldia Bulk Terminal

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the Haldia Bulk Terminal, a fully automated dry bulk handling facility developed by Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Limited (APSEZ) at the Haldia Dock Complex of Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port in Kolkata.
- The terminal has an annual handling capacity of 4 million metric tonnes (MMTPA).
- It is recognised as India's first fully automated dry bulk cargo facility on the Hooghly river.

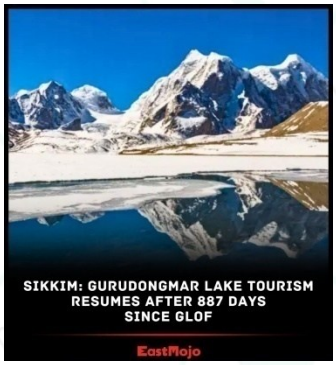
Bascule Bridge

- The Union government recently approved a Rs 117.54 crore project for the renovation of the Bascule Bridge at Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata.
- Bascule Bridge is a type of bridge that can be raised to provide clearance for waterway traffic and is also referred to as a lifting bridge or a drawbridge.
- It makes use of a counterweight to balance a span through its upward trajectory.

- The word 'bascule' is French in origin and translates loosely as a seesaw or a balancing mechanical device.
- It is thought that bascule bridges were first designed during the mediaeval era in Europe, when they served defensive purposes.
- The longest double-leaf bascule bridge in the world is the Broadway Bridge in Portland, Oregon, USA.

Sikkim

Gurudongmar Lake



- Tourism to the high-altitude Gurudongmar Lake in North Sikkim has begun to revive after more than two years of disruption following the devastating South Lhonak Lake GLOF, which severely damaged road infrastructure.
- Gurudongmar Lake is located on the northern-most edge of Sikkim, very close to the Chinese Tibetan border.
- It is one of the highest lakes in the world and in India, located at an altitude of 17,800 ft (5,430 m).
- The lake is primarily fed by glaciers and is a source stream for the Tso Lahmu Lake that later forms the source of the Teesta River.
- It is considered sacred by Buddhists, Sikhs, and Hindus.
- The lake is named after Guru Padmasambhava— also known as Guru Rinpoche—founder of Tibetan Buddhism.
- Guru Padmasambhava visited the lake in the 8th century on the way back from Tibet.
- Even in extreme winters, a part of this lake never freezes.
- The myth behind this is that Guru Padmasambhava had once touched and consecrated this lake and made it partially frozen throughout the year.

Assam

Assam's GI-Tagged Joha Rice Exported to UK and Italy

- India has facilitated the export of 25 metric tonnes of Assam's GI-tagged Joha rice to the United Kingdom and Italy, expanding access to niche agricultural products in global markets
- Joha rice is a short-grain aromatic rice variety known for its distinctive fragrance, soft texture, and traditional cultivation practices.
- It received Geographical Indication (GI) status in 2017.
- The rice originates from Assam in Northeast India, where it has been cultivated for centuries as part of traditional agricultural systems.
- It is culturally associated with Assamese cuisine and festivals, often used in special dishes. Mainly grown in Upper Assam and parts of Central Assam.

Key Characteristics:

- Aromatic variety: Emits a strong natural fragrance similar to other premium aromatic rice varieties.
- Short-grain winter paddy: Typically cultivated during the Sali (winter) rice season.
- Nutraceutical properties: Contains omega-3 and omega-6 fatty acids, antioxidants, flavonoids, and phenolic compounds.
- Health benefits: Research indicates potential anti-diabetic and cardio-protective properties due to bioactive compounds such as oryzanol, ferulic acid, and tocotrienols.

Sonowal Launches Three Brahmaputra Waterway Projects

- Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW), Sarbananda Sonowal, inaugurated three major inland waterways infrastructure projects in Dibrugarh on National Waterway-2 (River Brahmaputra),
- The projects include the Customs and Immigration Complex at Bogibeel, the Customs and Immigration Complex at Dhubri, and the renovated Heritage Building of the Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI) at Dibrugarh.
- The Customs and Immigration Complex at Bogibeel has been developed as part of a modern tourist-cum-cargo terminal integrating customs, immigration and IWAI administrative functions within a single complex.
- The Dhubri Customs and Immigration Complex is designed to enhance regulatory oversight and boost export-import operations in western Assam, positioning the town as a strategic gateway for inland water transport and cross-border commerce with Bangladesh and Bhutan.
- Under the National Waterways Act, 2016, 20 rivers in the Northeast have been declared National Waterways, with the Brahmaputra (NW-2), Barak (NW-16), Dhansiri (NW-31) and Kopili (NW-57) being actively developed.

Assam Launches Mission Basundhara 3.0 Land Pattas

- Under the Assam Government's Mission Basundhara 3.0 initiative, land allotment certificates were formally distributed across Sonitpur district to ensure land rights for indigenous people as well as educational, social, and religious institutions.
- Mission Basundhara was launched to streamline historically disorganised land records that denied families legal ownership and access to institutional credit
- Mission Basundhara 1.0 resolved conversion and record correction.
- Mission Basundhara 2.0 granted land rights to indigenous people on government land
- Mission Basundhara 4.0 and 5.0 will address remaining land issues, reclassification and settlement of non-tribal forest villagers.

Karbi Anglong Ginger

- Assam has marked a major agricultural milestone by flagging off its first-ever trial export consignment of 1.2 metric tonnes of GI-tagged Karbi Anglong Ginger to London.
- Karbi Anglong Ginger is a premium variety of ginger known for its distinct aroma, strong pungency, and medicinal properties.
- It has received a Geographical Indication (GI) tag, certifying its unique origin and quality attributes.
- Grown in the Karbi Anglong district of Assam.
- Cultivated mainly in the Singhasan Hills using traditional Jhum (shifting cultivation) and Tila cultivation methods.
- Aromatic & Pungent: Known for a strong, earthy flavour with high essential oil content.
- Medicinal Value: Used in traditional medicine for digestive and anti-inflammatory properties.

Nagaland

Morung Education System

- In the 132nd edition of Mann Ki Baat, Prime Minister highlighted the Naga community's Morung education system.
- He praised its blend of traditional cultural learning with modern subjects like mathematics and science.
- Morung is a traditional community-based indigenous education system of the Naga tribes.
- Historically, it functioned as a youth dormitory and learning space, where elders transmitted history, customs, warfare skills, ethics, folklore, and community values to younger generations.

Aim:

- To preserve tribal heritage, oral traditions, and community values
- To ensure holistic development by integrating traditional wisdom with modern education

Key Features:

- Elder-Led Learning: Knowledge is transmitted through elders using storytelling, oral traditions, and lived experiences.
- Integrated Modern Curriculum: Traditional learning is now combined with subjects such as science, mathematics, and language skills.
- Experiential & Cultural Pedagogy: Uses folk songs, traditional games, storytelling, and community interaction for practical learning.

Manipur

Third North-East India Film Festival 2026 begins in Imphalc

- Third North-East India Film Festival (NEIFF) 2026 begins at TanthaPolis Cinema Lamphel, Imphal, Manipur
- The two-day film festival will showcase nine films from across the North East Region, including four Manipuri, four Assamese and one Meghalaya (Khasi) film.

Mizoram

Chapchar Kut Showcases Mizoram's Rich Cultural Heritage

- Recently, Mizoram's most important and largest spring festival Chapchar Kut concluded a week-long series of cultural festivities.
- It is a spring festival celebrated in the state of Mizoram.
- It is celebrated during March after completion of their most arduous task of jhum operation i.e., jungle-clearing (clearing of the remnants of burning).
- Background: It is estimated to have started in 1450–1700 A.D. in a village called Suaipui.
- During this festival, both the men and women get dressed in their traditional attire with distinguished headgears and traditional jewelry
- All the people gather for a huge community fest to sing and dance to the tune of flute, cymbals, drums and gongs.
- One of the greatest highlights of Chapchar Kut is the popular bamboo dance called Cheraw
- Other Festivals of Mizoram: Pawl Kut, Lyuva Khutla and Anthurium Festival.

Rajasthan

PM Modi launches nationwide HPV Vaccination Programme for girls aged 14 years

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched a nationwide campaign for Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination for girls aged 14 years in Ajmer, Rajasthan.
- The HPV vaccine is a series of shots that can protect you from an HPV infection.
- It prevents HPV infections that can progress to cancer or genital warts.
- The HPV vaccination is more efficacious if given between the age group of 9-26 years.
- Once a person gets HPV, the vaccine may not be as effective.
- The HPV vaccine isn't given during pregnancy.
- HPV is the most common sexually transmitted infection (STI), and there are more than 100 types of HPV. Most do not cause health problems.
- However, some types of HPV infection cause skin growths called warts, and some types of HPV infection can cause cancer.
- More than 95% of cervical cancer is caused by the HPV virus.
- The virus that causes HPV infection is transmitted through skin-to-skin contact.

- Most people get a genital HPV infection through direct sexual contact, including vaginal, anal, and oral sex.
- The body most often clears the virus before it causes any health problems.
- Symptoms may include warts on the genitals or anus or cancerous growths in the mouth or throat.
- Treatment: There's no cure for HPV.

Mount Abu Renamed Aburaj! Rajasthan Changes 3 Historic City Names

- Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma announced in the Assembly that three historic cities will be renamed.
- Mount Abu will now be called Abu Raj.
- Mount Abu is the only hill station in Rajasthan. It is perched on the Aravalli Range while Kaman and Jahazpur have been renamed Kamvan and Yagyapur, respectively.
- Jahazpur is a historic town located in the Bhilwara district of Rajasthan.
- Kaman is a prominent town in the Bharatpur district of Rajasthan. It is known for its cultural heritage and its deep association with the Braj region.

Rajasthan Assembly passes Bill to repeal two-child norm for ULB elections

THE HINDU
दिल्ली संस्करण

Now, Rajasthan Assembly passes Bill to repeal two-child norm for ULB elections

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

A day after scrapping the two-child norm for panchayat elections, the Rajasthan Assembly on Tuesday passed a Bill for removing the restriction preventing individuals with more than two children from contesting the urban local body (ULB) elections. The provision for disqualification existed in the State for the last three decades.

The Rajasthan Municipalities (Amendment) Bill, 2026, was passed by voice vote in the House after a brief debate in which the Opposition Congress MLAs raised the issues of delimitation of wards, corruption in local bodies and the use of old electoral rolls for the upcoming municipal elections.

The Bill's passage paved the way for the candidates having more than two children to contest the polls and become municipal councillors, mayors, and chairpersons of municipalities and municipal councils in the urban areas of the State.

The disqualification, removed with an amendment to Section 24 of the Rajasthan Municipalities Act, 2009, was introduced in the State in 1995 during the government led by then Chief Minister Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. A similar restriction was imposed for the panchayat elections, which was repealed by another Bill passed in the Assembly on Monday.

'No clarity on polls'

Congress MLA and Pradesh Congress Committee president Govind Singh Dotasra asked the State government if it intended to scrap the two-child norm for a number of schemes of both the Centre and the State as well. "Even after bringing this Amendment Bill, there is no clarity about the dates of local body polls," he said.

Replying to the debate, Minister of State for Local Self Government Jhabar Singh Kharra said the removal of disqualification was a step towards ensuring greater participation in the democratic process. "It will give an opportunity to contest the polls to those who were earlier excluded because of the two-child limit," he said.

Mr. Kharra said the State government was in a position to hold simultaneous elections for municipal bodies under the 'one State, one election' system, but it had to fulfil the condition for providing reservation to Other Backward Classes. It was mandatory to wait for the OBC Commission's report for the purpose, he said.

Speaker Vasudev Devnani adjourned the Assembly sine die after the passage of the Bill, while bringing the Budget Session to a closure.

- A day after scrapping the two-child norm for panchayat elections, the Rajasthan Assembly passed a Bill for removing the restriction preventing individuals with more than two children from contesting the urban local body (ULB) elections along with removing disqualification based on leprosy.
- The provision for disqualification existed in the State for the last three decades.
- The two-child policy was introduced in 1995 to promote population control by disqualifying individuals with more than two children from contesting panchayat and municipal elections.
- Alignment with Central Law: The change aligns with the spirit of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016 and public health reforms that discourage discrimination against people cured of or living with leprosy.

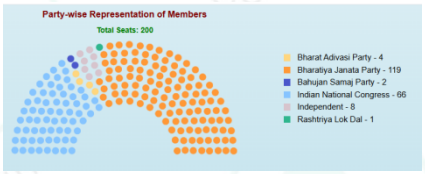
Nagauri Paan Methi Registered as Community Farmers' Variety

- The Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers' Rights Authority (PPVFRA) formally granted a patent to 'Nagauri Pan Methi' (Nagori fenugreek) (Trigonella corniculata L.) under the 'community farmers' variety' category.
- So far, in the absence of intellectual property rights, the 'methi variety' was being categorised as grass and sold as 'kasuri methi' by traders and businessmen.
- Nagauri Methi is cultivated exclusively in the Nagaur district of Rajasthan.
- The registration provides multiple benefits to farmers. It offers protection against biopiracy and unauthorised commercial use of the variety.
- Farmers will also gain safeguards against the sale of spurious or substandard seeds, a common problem in the absence of formal seed chains.
- Additionally, the community becomes eligible for benefit-sharing if the genetic resources of Nagauri methi are used in research or commercial products.

30 March Rajasthan Day

- Marking the foundation of the state in 1949.
- Rajasthan is the largest state in terms of area.
- Before independence, the region was known as 'Rajputana'. After the integration of the princely states was completed in seven phases (from March 18, 1948, to November 1, 1956), the name of the region was changed to 'Rajasthan'.

- On January 14, 1949, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel announced the merger of the princely states of Jaipur, Bikaner, Jodhpur, and Jaisalmer in a public meeting in Udaipur. To implement this announcement, Patel inaugurated Greater Rajasthan in a ceremony in Jaipur on March 30, 1949.
- With this merger and formation of Greater Rajasthan 30 March is celebrated every year as Rajasthan Day.



- State Animal of Rajasthan – Chinkara
- State Heritage Animal of Rajasthan – Dromedary Camel
- State Bird of Rajasthan – Great Indian Bustard
- State Tree of Rajasthan – Khejri
- State Flower of Rajasthan – Rohida
- Legislative assembly seats : 200
- Governor : Haribhau Kisanrao Bagde
- Speaker: Vasudev Devnani
- CM:Bhajan Lal Sharma

Gujarat

Gujarat Launches Statewide Vaccination Drive Against Foot and Mouth Disease

- It is a highly contagious viral infection that affects cloven-hoofed animals such as cattle, buffaloes, sheep and goats.
- Cause: It is caused by an Aphthovirus of the family Picornaviridae.
- FMD is characterised by fever and blister-like sores on the tongue and lips, in the mouth, on the teats and between the hooves.
- The disease is rarely fatal in adult animals, but there is often high mortality in young animals due to myocarditis.
- Transmission: It is transmitted through
- Infected animals newly introduced into a herd (carrying virus in their saliva, milk, semen, etc.);
- Contaminated pens/buildings or contaminated animal transport vehicles;
- Contaminated materials such as hay, feed, water, milk or biologics;
- Contaminated clothing, footwear, or equipment;
- Virus-infected meat or other contaminated animal products (if fed to animals when raw or improperly cooked);
- Treatment: Vaccination is the only effective preventive measure against FMD.

Gujarat Launches 'Lake and Air Watch' for Urban Environmental Monitoring

- The Gujarat government has launched the 'Lake and Air Watch' initiative to monitor and improve lake health and air quality across cities using satellite and real-time monitoring systems.
- The 'Lake and Air Watch' initiative is a technology- driven environmental monitoring programme launched by the Gujarat Urban Development Mission (GUDM) under the Urban Development and Urban Housing Department of Gujarat.
- Satellite technology will track lake area changes, algae growth, waste accumulation and water quality indicators.
- Installation of air quality monitoring stations across 17 municipal corporations and 152 municipal areas.

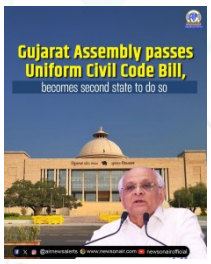
PM Modi inaugurate 'Samrat Samprati Museum', semiconductor plant in Gujarat

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the Samrat Samprati Museum in Koba, Gandhinagar, on the occasion of Mahavir Jayanti
- Named after Samrat Samprati, the grandson of Ashoka, the museum showcases the rich historical, cultural, and spiritual legacy of Jainism.
- Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugrated Rs 3,300 crore Kaynes Semiconductor Plant at Sanand GIDC in Ahmedabad.
- It is the second such plant in India and an achievement in the semiconductor sector.
- The facility will undertake chip packaging and testing, with a projected production capacity of around 60 lakh chips per day.

Madhavpur Mela in Gujarat

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi extended greetings on the occasion of the Madhavpur Mela being held in Gujarat's Porbandar
- The Madhavpur Mela, which began on Ram Navami, commemorates the marriage of Lord Krishna and Rukmini.
- According to folklore, Rukmini, believed to be from the Northeast, was married to Lord Krishna at Madhavpur in Gujarat.

Gujarat passes UCC Bill, becomes second state after Uttarakhand



- The proposed legislation, titled the Gujarat Uniform Civil Code, 2026, is intended to apply across the entire state, including to residents of Gujarat living outside its geographical boundaries.
- However, the bill specifies that it will not cover members of Scheduled Tribes (ST) and certain communities whose customary practices are safeguarded by the Constitution.
- A UCC provides for the formulation of one law for the entire country, which would apply to all religious communities in their personal matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption, and succession.
- Currently, Indian personal law is complex, with each religion adhering to its specific laws.

Personal Laws in India:

- Hindu Succession Act 1956 governs Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and Buddhists
- Muslim Personal Law governs Muslims
- Indian Succession Act 1925 applies to Christians, Parsis, and Jews
- The Special Marriage Act provides for the solemnization of interfaith marriage as well as registration by a Marriage Officer.

Important Judgements and committees recommending UCC

- Shah Bano Case (1985): SC Highlighted need for UCC, especially in maintenance matters.
- Sarla Mudgal Case (1995): SC Urged UCC for gender equality among religions.
- Paulo Coutinho vs Maria Luiza Valentina Pereira (2019): SC Highlights need for uniform laws for consistency.
- Law Commission (2018): No UCC needed now, amend existing laws.
- Law Commission of India (2022): It seeks public and religious input on UCC.

Maharashtra

Maharashtra's Freedom of Religion Bill

- The Maharashtra government introduced the Dharma Swatantrya or Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026, in the Legislative Assembly to regulate religious conversions and provide for punitive action
- The focus of the bill is on the ensuring conversions are voluntary and not influenced by illegal means.
- The Bill provides that any marriage undertaken solely for unlawful religious conversion shall be declared null and void by a competent court.
- A plea may be made by either party to the marriage alleging unlawful conversion by the other.
- Under the proposed law, a complaint alleging unlawful conversion may be filed by the converted person, parents, siblings or any other person related by blood, marriage or adoption.
- It will be investigated by an officer not below the rank of Sub-Inspector of Police.
- The proposed law places the burden of proving voluntary, non-coercive conversion on the person causing or aiding it, and makes offences cognisable and non-bailable.
- The fine increases to Rs. 5 lakh if the offence is committed against a person of unsound mind, a minor, a woman or a person belonging to the Scheduled Castes or the Scheduled Tribes.
- Mass conversions will also attract seven years' imprisonment and a fine of Rs. 5 lakh.
- For repeat offenders, including individuals or organisations, the Bill stipulates a stricter jail term of ten years and a fine of Rs. 7 lakh.
- Different states have prescribed stricter punishments, with Uttar Pradesh up to 14 years imprisonment in case of vulnerable groups, and Rajasthan up to 20 years jail term for mass conversions.

Maharashtra Assembly passes bills to use grazing land for public works, speed up stamp duty refunds

- The Maharashtra Legislative Assembly passed two key revenue related bills aimed at improving administrative efficiency and unlocking unused government land for development works.

  The House cleared the Maharashtra Land Revenue Code Amendment Bill 2026,
- which seek to decentralise administrative powers, enable the use of unused grazing land within municipal limits for public works and speed up the disposal of stamp duty refund cases.
- Allowing municipal corporations and municipal councils to utilise uncultivated grazing land, known as gairan land, within their jurisdiction for public purposes.
- These lands can only be used for public interest works and cannot be used for commercial purposes. They will be recorded as Collector's land and prior approval from the district collector will be mandatory.
- The Assembly also passed the Maharashtra Stamp Amendment Bill 2026, which aims to reduce the backlog of stamp duty refund applications by increasing the financial powers of authorities under the state's revenue department.
- At present, under Section 52A of the Maharashtra Stamp Act 1958, authorities can grant refunds of stamp duty up to Rs 20 lakh, while cases involving higher amounts must be referred to the Chief Controlling Revenue Authority.
- The amendment raises the financial limits for several officials to allow more cases to be resolved at district and regional levels.

Yadava Dynasty

LOKMAT TIMES • Anchor

Ancient Yadava-era temple pillar found at Vena river in Hinganghat

Remains date back to 12th century, say researchers

KHALIL KHATIB
LOKMAT NEWS NETWORK
HINGANGHAT (WARDHA)

A remarkable discovery has brought new light to the town's ancient heritage. Archaeology enthusiasts have identified stone pillar remains dating back to the 12th century Yadava period near the banks of the Vena River in Hinganghat.

The find was made by sculpture researchers Panchsheel Thul and Pravin Kadu while surveying old temple sites along the river.

Ancient temple pillar found near Vena river in Hinganghat.

The intricately carved basalt stone features a lotus motif, a symbol of auspicious-

ness in Indian temple architecture.

Experts believe the fragment may have formed part of a temple's foundation or column.

The style corresponds to the famed Hemadpanti architecture of the Yadava dynasty, known for its elaborate stone carvings during the 12th and 13th centuries. Local heritage groups have submitted a memorandum to the Hinganghat Municipal Council, urging officials to secure and preserve the relics.

According to researcher Pravin Kadu, the discovery confirms Hinganghat's prosperity and cultural significance during the Yadava era.

The stone pillar stands as testimony to the town's ancient temple traditions and its rich historical past.

- Remains of a 12th-century Mandir-style stone pillar from the Seuna (Yadava) dynasty have been recently discovered near the Vena River in Hinganghat, Wardha district, Maharashtra.
- The Yadava Dynasty, also known as the Seuna Dynasty, were rulers of a 12th–14th-century Hindu kingdom of central India.
- At its zenith they ruled a vast kingdom stretching from the River Tungabhadra to the River Narmada, including modern Maharashtra, the north of Karnataka, and parts of Madhya Pradesh.
- Originally a feudatory of the Eastern Chalukyas of Kalyani, the dynasty became paramount in the Deccan under Bhillama (c. 1187–91), who founded Devagiri (later Daulatabad) as his capital.

Oleum Gas Leak

- A major oleum gas leak at Bhageria Industries Ltd in Boisar, Maharashtra, forced the evacuation of over 2,000 residents, including 1,600 students.
- Oleum, commonly referred to as fuming sulfuric acid, is a highly corrosive chemical consisting of dissolved sulfur trioxide (SO_3) in concentrated sulfuric acid (H_2SO_4). It releases dense white fumes when exposed to moist air.
- Chemical Name: Oleum (Fuming Sulfuric Acid)
- Chemical representation: $H_2SO_4 \bullet xSO_3$

Physical Properties:

- Appearance: It appears as dense, white cloudish smoke when leaked into the air.
- Freezing Point: Its freezing point varies strongly with concentration; it can be solid at room temperature or remain liquid as low as zero degree.

Impact on Health:

- Acute Irritation: Exposure can cause minor to severe eye irritation.
- Respiratory Distress: Hazardous fumes can cause irritation to the respiratory tract; emergency responders use Self- Contained Breathing Apparatus (SCBA) to avoid inhalation.
- Sulfuric Acid Mist: In large releases, it creates a mist of micrometre-sized sulfuric acid particles that are hazardous over wide areas.

Jalna Celebrates 138th Hatti Risala Procession on Dhulivandan

- In Maharashtra, the historic 'Hatti Risala' procession, a cherished cultural tradition of Jalna, marked its 138th year this Dhulivandan.
- Organized annually on the occasion of Dhulivandan (the day following Holi), the grand procession passes through the city's main roads.
- A decorated elephant carries a symbolic king and his prime minister, who shower sweets (revdis) on the crowd.
- The 'Hatti Risala' procession stands as a symbol of Jalna's rich cultural heritage and communal harmony. People from all religions actively take part in the celebrations

SHORT NEWS

- The Maharashtra government has renamed the Divyang Welfare Department as Divyang Empowerment Department, marking a shift from welfare to empowerment.

Gudi Padwa Marathi New Year

- Gudi Padwa, also known as Samvatsar Padvo, is observed in Maharashtra and Goa.
- It marks the beginning of Marathi New Year and is also observed as the first day of Chaitra Month.
- Marks the beginning of the Hindu New Year and the Marathi New Year.

Maharashtra Goseva Commission to organize grand exhibition titled 'Gau-Tech 2026' from March 20 to 23

- The Maharashtra Goseva Commission, in collaboration with the Global Confederation of Cow- Based Industries (GCCBI) and various service-oriented organizations, will organize a grand exhibition titled 'Gau-Tech 2026' from March 20 to 23 at the Agriculture College in Pune

Airports in News

- Several greenfield and upgraded airports across India have been inaugurated or are nearing completion during 2025–26.

Navi Mumbai International Airport (DB Patil Airport):

- A major greenfield international airport developed to reduce congestion at Mumbai's existing airport.
- Location: Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra
- Type: Greenfield Airport

Noida International Airport (Jewar Airport):

- India's largest upcoming greenfield airport serving the Delhi-NCR region.
- Location: Jewar, Uttar Pradesh

Features:

- Phase-1 capacity of 12 million passengers annually.
- Planned as a major aviation hub with multi-modal connectivity.

Bhogapuram International Airport:

- A greenfield airport project to enhance connectivity in coastal Andhra Pradesh.
- Location: Near Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh

Dholera International Airport:

- A greenfield airport supporting the Dholera Special Investment Region (SIR).
- Location: Gujarat

Regional Greenfield / Upgraded Airports:

Satna Airport:

- A regional airport under UDAN scheme improving connectivity.
- Location: Madhya Pradesh
- Type: Greenfield/Revived Regional Airport

Datia Airport:

- A regional connectivity airport under UDAN.
- Location: Madhya Pradesh

- Type: Greenfield/Revived Regional Airport

Thoothukudi Airport (New Terminal):

- An upgraded airport with a new terminal building.
- Location: Tamil Nadu
- Type: Brownfield Expansion

Goa

Mulgao Kelbai Peth Festival Celebrated in Bicholim

- The traditional "Peth" festival of goddess Kelbai is being observed at Mulgao in Bicholim, Goa, with rituals commencing at midnight on March 23.
- It is believed that the goddess Kelbai, seated in a peth (a wooden rectangular box made of cane), travels to Gaonkarwada Mayem to meet her sister from the Maya
- Goddess Kelbai meets her sister once a year on the day of Chaitra Shuddha Panchami.
- On this occasion, she is accompanied by hundreds of Dhond devotees and the Chowgule community.
- After a three-day stay in Mayem village, the goddess returns to her temple in Mulgao via he forest route.
- It is only after the return that the Malyachi jatra is celebrated.
- The peth, decorated with aboli flowers, is carried on the head by a man called "Mode," who remains in a trance until reaching Mayem.

Telangana

Petroglyphs

- Researchers recently found two ancient rock carvings (petroglyphs) on a flat rock inside a rock shelter on a hill behind Beerappa Temple in Manchirevula, Telangana.
- Petroglyphs (also known as rock engravings) are symbolic images sculpted or engraved on the surface of rocks by removing material from its surface layer with instruments of superior hardness.
- The techniques used to create these images include pecking, incising, abrading, sculpting, polishing, drilling, and scratching.
- These processes remove part of the rock and therefore are different from images simply painted or drawn on rock, which are called petrographs.
- The word "petroglyph'' is derived from two Greek words, "petros'' meaning "stone," and "glyphein'' meaning "to carve."
- Petroglyphs took two primary forms, as images either appear as scratches or deeper visible indentations on rock.
- Example of Petroglyph Site in India: Edakkal Caves in Wayanad, Kerala

World Buddhist Peace Conference 2026

- Hyderabad is set to host the World Buddhist Peace Conference 2026, an international gathering aimed at promoting peace and cultural exchange with participation over 20 countries.
- Events scheduled between March 27 and March 29
- Organised by Buddhavanam, a unit of the Telangana Tourism Development Corporation, in association with the Vietnam Buddhist Sangha

Nd-Fe-B Rare Earth Permanent Magnets

- India has inaugurated a state-of-the-art pilot plant for manufacturing Nd-Fe-B (Neodymium-Iron-Boron) rare earth permanent magnets at the ARCI, Hyderabad.
- A member of the rare-earth magnet family, it is a sintered or bonded material capable of maintaining a high magnetic force indefinitely without the need for an external power source.
- Nd-Fe-B magnets, often called super magnets, are the strongest type of permanent magnets commercially available today.

Minerals Used:

- Neodymium (Nd): A rare-earth element that provides high magnetic anisotropy.
- Iron (Fe): The primary metallic component that provides high magnetization.
- Boron (B): A metalloid used to stabilize the crystalline structure.

Characteristics of Nd-Fe-B Magnets:

- They possess the highest energy product of any permanent magnet, allowing for very small magnets to produce very strong fields.
- They are highly resistant to becoming demagnetized once they have been charged.
- While powerful, their performance can decrease at very high temperatures unless specific heavy rare earths (like Dysprosium) are added.
- Because of the high iron content, these magnets require protective coatings (like nickel or epoxy) to prevent rusting.

Applications:

- Critical components in high-efficiency motors for Electric Vehicles (EVs).
- Used in the generators of large-scale wind turbines.
- Found in hard disk drives, smartphones, loudspeakers, and headphones.
- Essential for robotics, industrial automation, and high-precision sensors.
- Used in Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) machines and other diagnostic tools.

Andhra Pradesh

Andhra Pradesh set to become first State to get Pramaan certification for forest produce

- Andhra Pradesh Forest Development Corporation (APFDC) is set to become the first agency in the country to receive the Government of India's Pramaan certification under the Indian Forest and Wood Certification Scheme (IFWCS),
- The Pramaan (Programme for Recognition and Accreditation of Sustainable Management Practices for Agroforestry and Natural Forestry Resources), was launched in 2023 by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change.
- A voluntary market-based initiative aimed at promoting sustainable management of forest and agroforestry resources.

India Builds First Autonomous Maritime Shipbuilding Centre in Andhra

- India has taken a major step towards strengthening its maritime and defence manufacturing capabilities with the foundation of the world's first Autonomous Maritime Shipbuilding and Systems Centre in Andhra Pradesh.
- The facility is being developed by Mumbai-based Sagar Defence Engineering at the Juvvaladinne fishing harbour in Nellore district
- These include unmanned surface vessels (USVs), autonomous underwater vehicles (AUVs), intelligent navigation systems, maritime sensors, and secure communication networks

Project HANUMAN

- The Government of Andhra Pradesh launched Project HANUMAN on World Wildlife Day 2026 to address the rising human–wildlife conflict in the state.
- Project HANUMAN stands for Healing and Nurturing Units for Monitoring, Aid and Nursing of Wildlife.
- It is a state-level wildlife protection and conflict mitigation initiative aimed at rescuing, treating, rehabilitating, and monitoring wildlife while protecting communities near forests.

Police launch 'Operation Vajra Prahar' to combat drug trafficking in Anantapur

- The Anantapur district police launched Operation Vajra Prahar in March 2026 as a major initiative to combat drug trafficking and substance abuse.
- This operation is part of a statewide crackdown in Andhra Pradesh aimed at eliminating the sale and distribution of narcotics, particularly ganja (cannabis)

Karnataka

Karnataka's Proposal to Ban Social Media for Children Under 16

- Karnataka Chief Minister announced in the 2026– 27 Karnataka State Budget that the state plans to ban social media use for children below 16 years.
- The initiative seeks to protect minors from digital addiction, cyberbullying, misinformation exposure, and mental health issues linked to excessive online engagement.

Key Features:

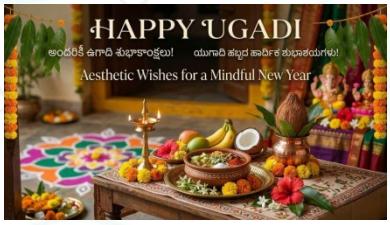
- Age Restriction: Children below 16 years will be prohibited from accessing social media platforms under the proposed regulation.
- Child Protection Focus: The policy is intended to mitigate psychological harm, online harassment, and screen addiction among minors.
- Digital Regulation Framework: The move may involve age-verification mechanisms and regulatory guidelines for digital platforms operating in the state.
- Holistic Digital Policy Context: The proposal accompanies broader initiatives to strengthen technology governance and responsible digital use.

Karnataka

India's first psychiatric 'data repository' launched at Bengaluru Nimhans

- Researchers at the Rohini Nilekani Centre for Brain and Mind (CBM), a partnership between the National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS) and the National Centre for Biological Sciences (NCBS) - TIFR, have developed CALM-Brain,
- It is a first-of-its-kind digital repository of data in India on brain structure and function from a range of psychiatric disorders.
- CALM-Brain collects clinical, neuro-imaging, behavioural, genetic and other datasets on five disorders – addiction, bipolar disorder, dementia, obsessive compulsive disorder (OCD) and schizophrenia.

Ugadi



- Ugadi (Yugadi) is the Telugu and Kannada New Year observed in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka.
- The terms Yugadi or Ugadi stem from the Sanskrit words yuga (age) and adi (beginning), denoting the start of a new age.
- Panchanga Sravanam, the reading of the almanac for the new year, is an important ritual.

Aghanashini–Vedavathi River-Linking Project

- Recently the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO) advised the Centre that the Aghanashini–Vedavathi river linking project must comply with the norms set under World Heritage Conservation frameworks.

Aghanashini River:

- It is in central Uttara Kannada district of Karnataka originates in the Western Ghats and flows westward towards Arabian Sea.
- Aghanashini, meaning the "Remover of Sins"
- Tributaries: Donihalla, Chandika hole, Masti mane halla, Benne hole etc
- Aghanashini Estuary: Where the Aghanashini River meets the Arabian Sea, this estuarine system is rich in mangroves and supports a variety of fish and bird species.
- Aghanashini Estuary has been designated as the Ramsar Site

Vedavati River

- East-flowing plateau river in South India; supports semi-arid Karnataka & Andhra
- Formed by Veda + Avati streams (origin: Bababudangiri hills, Western Ghats)
- Right-bank tributary of Tungabhadra → Krishna Basin → Bay of Bengal system

Kerala

Kerala Police launch 'Nirbhaya Nisha' to ensure safe night travel for women

- The Kerala Police has announced the launch of the Nirbhaya Nisha initiative to enhance the safety of women travelling at night across the state.
- Nirbhaya Nisha is a women's safety initiative launched by the Kerala Police to provide immediate assistance to women travelling at night.
- It focuses on strengthening night-time policing, emergency response, and digital safety mechanisms.
- Women can seek assistance through the 112 national emergency helpline during night hours. Night Safety Coverage – The initiative operates specifically between 9 PM and 5 AM.

Kerala Health Department launches MeHEALTH mobile application

- Kerala Health Department has launched the MeHEALTH app for getting information about the nearby government health facilities. With the help of this app, users can find details of nearby hospitals within 10 kilometres, including available specialities, laboratory tests and their rates.
- Information on services such as blood banks, radiology units, pharmacies, and pay wards in hospitals is also available on the platform.
- The app also allows patients to book Doctor appointments.

G- SPIDER Robot

- Recently, under Swachh Bharat Mission–Urban 2.0, Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation has deployed an AI-powered G- SPIDER robot
- It is an automated canal cleaning robot, created by Genrobotic Innovations.
- It is engineered to operate in complex, high- risk canal environments without any human entry.
- Efficient Operation: It is designed to function efficiently even during high water levels and continuous flow conditions.
- It is built on Cable-Driven Parallel Robotics (CDPR) architecture and powered by AI-enabled vision and sensor intelligence.
- It is capable of safely extracting mixed and hazardous waste—including plastics, sharp debris, and other harmful materials

Attukal Pongala festival - Kerala

- It is a 10-day long festival celebrated annually at Attukal Bhagavathy Temple in Trivandrum, Kerala.
- This festival is dedicated to Attukal Bhagavathy, also known as Goddess Kannaki or Bhadrakali.
- It is celebrated every year and falls in the month of February or March.
- Pongala, which means 'to boil over', is the ritual in which women prepare sweet payasam (a pudding made from rice, jaggery, coconut and plantains cooked together) and offer it to the Goddess or 'Bhagavathy'.
- This ritual is performed on the 9th day.
- It is one of the largest congregation of women for a festival in the world.
- Attukal temple is located at the heart of Thiruvananthapuram city in Kerala. It has Goddess Bhadrakali (Kannaki) as the main deity.
- Bhadrakali, according to Hindu mythology, is the Goddess of prosperity and salvation.

Megalithic Rock-Cut Chambers

- A 2,000-year-old laterite rock-cut chamber from the Megalithic period was recently unearthed during construction work in Panayal, Kasaragod district of Kerala.
- These are subterranean burial structures carved directly into laterite rock.
- They represent a unique funerary architecture where the dead were interred with grave goods, reflecting the Megalithic culture's complex beliefs about the afterlife.

Various Names:

Locally, these structures are known by several evocative names in Kerala and surrounding regions:

- Muniyara (Hermit's cell)
- Pandava Cave (Linked to the mythological Pandavas)
- Peeranki Cave (Cannon cave)
- Nidhikuzhi (Treasure pit)
- Kalppathayam (Stone box/granary)

- These structures are generally linked to the Iron Age/Megalithic period in South India, dating back roughly 2,000 to 2,500 years.
- Region: Predominantly found in the laterite-rich belts of Kerala and parts of coastal Karnataka.
- Carved out of laterite rock with a circular inner chamber.
- Usually features a narrow shaft leading down to the chamber, with the opening sealed by a heavy stone slab.
- Associated Monuments: Frequently found near other Megalithic structures like Umbrella Stones (Kudakkallu) or Cap stones (Toppikallu).

Palm Sunday observed with devotion across Keralam, marks start of Holy Week

- Palm Sunday is a significant Christian feast that marks the beginning of Holy Week
- Palm Sunday marks the start of Easter observances, leading up to Good Friday and Easter Sunday.
- This practice symbolizes the palm branches that were laid down on the road as Jesus rode into Jerusalem.

Kerala's 'MLATrack.com'

- Kerala has launched 'MLATrack.com', India's first platform to track the legislative interventions of MLAs.
- MLATrack.com is a public digital database platform that aggregates and presents data on the performance and legislative activities of Members of the Kerala Legislative Assembly (2021–2026).

Aim:

- To increase transparency and accountability in legislative functioning
- To enable citizens, researchers, and media to track MLA performance objectively

Key Features:

- Comprehensive MLA Profiles: Includes biodata, attendance records, constituency maps, and participation details
- Legislative Activity Tracking: Tracks questions (68,000+), debates, motions, and interventions with date-wise details
- Data Visualization & Accessibility: Provides visual dashboards and hyperlinks to official Assembly responses for easy analysis

Akasha300 3D Printer

- The Kerala start-up delivers cutting-edge Akasha300 3D Printer to ISRO in a major step towards India's self-reliance in advanced manufacturing.
- It is a high-temperature multi-material extrusion 3D printer.
- It is backed by the Space Technology Innovation and Incubation Centre at IIST and the Kerala Startup Mission
- The printer features dual-extrusion technology capable of operating at temperatures up to 350Â°C, with future upgrades planned to extend this to 500Â°C.
- This enables stable and precise printing of high- performance materials that require strict thermal conditions.
- It is designed as an industrial-grade research platform, the system incorporates a robust motion system and integrated air filtration.

Tamil Nadu

V. O. C. Port becomes first port in India to launch Digital Twin initiative

- V.O. Chidambaranar Port (earlier Tuticorin Port), one of 13 major ports in India, is an artificial deep-sea harbour located in Thoothukudi (Tamil Nadu).
- Its history dates to as early as 123 AD when Ptolemy from Greece described Tuticorin as a flourishing trade centre engaged in Maritime Trade with Western and Eastern Countries.
- Tuticorin has been centre for Pearl Fishery for centuries.

Digital Twin Initiative

- Digital Twin is a virtual representation of a physical object or system that uses real-time data to accurately reflect its real-world counterpart's behavior, performance and conditions.

- Digital twins enable continuous monitoring, simulation and analysis of an object, product or system over the course of its lifecycle, from design and production to maintenance and decommissioning.
- Digital Twin for Port Management: It will create a real-time virtual replica of the port's infrastructure, operational assets, and maritime ecosystem, enabling enhanced operational visibility, predictive analytics, and data-driven decision-making across the port.
- Technologies: The platform will use IoT sensors, GPS tracking, LiDAR mapping, drone imaging, and CCTV networks etc.

Coimbatore District Police launch 'Kovai Digi Cop' WhatsApp chatbot

- The Coimbatore District Police, Tamil Nadu introduced 'Kovai Digi Cop,' a new WhatsApp- based chatbot designed to provide citizens with easy digital access to various police services and emergency assistance.
- 'Kovai Digi Cop' is a first-of-its-kind chatbot aimed at providing easy digital access for the public.

Tamil Nadu Launches First Dark Sky Park in Kolli Hills

- Tamil Nadu has inaugurated its first Dark Sky Park at the Ariyur Shola Reserve Forest in Kolli Hills, Namakkal district.
- Dark Sky Parks are designated areas with minimal light pollution to promote astronomical observation.
- Kolli Hills is located in Namakkal district of Tamil Nadu.

Union Cabinet approves international status for Madurai airport

- The Union Cabinet granted international airport status to the airport in the temple city of Madurai, Tamil Nadu.
- Until now, Madurai Airport was classified as a customs airport, meaning it had customs clearance facilities but did not have full authorisation for regular scheduled international operations, although it could handle limited international flights.

Masi Magam: an auspicious day for Irular community

- Masi Magam, an auspicious day in the Tamil calendar holds significance for the Irular community which is deeply tied to their culture and collective identity.
- They are a Dravidian ethnic group; they reside in the Nilgiri Mountains of the Western Ghats, spread across Tamil Nadu and Kerala.
- They are one of India's oldest indigenous communities.
- They are classified under the "Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups" category in Tamil Nadu.
- They also call themselves Erlar or Poosari, while their neighbours refer to them as Eralollu, Irulas, Shikari and Pujari
- Language: They speak Irula, which is related to Dravidian languages like Tamil and Kannada.
- Religious Beliefs: The Irula people don't have a definite god for them. They are pantheists who make provision for the presence of spirits in humans and objects.
- Their main deity is a virgin goddess called Kanniamma, who is deeply associated with the cobra.
- Settlements: Irula houses are built together in small settlements or villages called mottas.
- The Irula community is traditionally associated with healing, traditional medicine, and catching poisonous snakes.
- Economy: Cattle production is another source of income. In the forests they collect wild resources like honey, frankincense, firewood and the like.

Defence

Indian Armed Forces Contingent Arrives in Seychelles for Joint Exercise LAMITIYE-2026

- Indian Armed Forces contingent arrived at Seychelles to participate in the Eleventh edition of Joint Military Exercise "LAMITIYE-2026" with Seychelles Defence Forces (SDF).
- The Joint Exercise will be conducted at Seychelles Defence Academy from 09-20 March 2026.
- 'LAMITIYE' meaning 'Friendship' in the Creole language is a biennial training event
- It has been conducted in Seychelles since 2001.
- The contingent comprises of personnel from the ASSAM Regiment and participation from Indian Navy and Indian Air Force including INS Trikand and a C-130 aircraft.

Cold Response Drill

- NATO has begun the 2026 edition of the Cold Response military exercise in the Arctic.
- Cold Response is a large-scale biennial NATO military exercise conducted in the European Arctic, primarily in northern Norway and surrounding regions, designed to test the alliance's ability to defend NATO territory under extreme Arctic conditions.
- The exercise simulates collective defence scenarios under Article 5 of NATO, including amphibious operations, air support, logistics, and coordination between allied forces.
- Nations Involved: North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO)

U.S. and South Korea Kick Off Massive Joint Military Exercise 'Freedom Shield'

- The United States and South Korea officially launched the annual Freedom Shield 26 joint military exercise on March 9, 2026.
- The large-scale drills are scheduled to run for 11 days, concluding on March 19, 2026.
- All-Domain Operations: Focuses on land, sea, air, space, and cyber domains.

Indian Navy Joins Sea Dragon 2026 ASW Exercise

- The Indian Navy is participating in Exercise Sea Dragon 2026, a United States-led multinational anti-submarine warfare (ASW) drill being conducted at Andersen Air Force Base in Guam.
- The Indian Navy has deployed a P-8I maritime patrol aircraft to Guam to participate in the Exercise Sea Dragon.
- Exercise Sea Dragon is a US-led multinational anti-submarine warfare (ASW) exercise conducted in the Western Pacific Ocean near Guam.
- Initiated by the United States Navy as an annual multinational ASW training exercise to strengthen Indo-Pacific maritime security cooperation.

Member Nations:

Participants typically include maritime forces from key Indo-Pacific partners:

- Indian Navy
- United States Navy
- Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force
- Royal Australian Air Force
- Royal New Zealand Air Force
- Andersen Air Force Base is located on the US territory of Guam in the Pacific Ocean.

Indian Army's Central Command conducts its first-ever strategic communication conclave in Lucknow

- The Indian Army's Central Command conducted its first-ever Strategic Communication Conclave in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh.
- A special interactive session was organised on the theme 'Strategic Communication in Emerging Multi-Domain Operations: Strategies, Structures, Processes and Preparedness' which integrated policy and operational perspectives.

Mock drill 'Sagar Kavach' conducted along Mahe and Kerala coasts to strengthen national security

- A mock drill titled "Sagar Kavach" is being conducted along the Mahe and Kerala coasts as part of efforts to strengthen national security and safeguard India's coastline.
- The exercise is aimed at preventing destructive and other unlawful activities in coastal areas.
- The drill is being carried out jointly by the Indian Navy, Coast Guard, Coastal Police and Local Police in coordination with the Fisheries and Administrative Departments.

Indian Air Force demonstrates combat strength in Exercise Vayu Shakti in Rajasthan

- The President of India Smt Droupadi Murmu witnessed the 'Vayu Shakti–2026' exercise at the Pokhran Firing Range, Jaisalmer, Rajasthan.
- Conducted By : Indian Air Force
- This exercise was conducted with the primary objective of demonstrating the capability to carry out swift and precise strikes in simulated wartime scenarios.

Droupadi Murmu Flies LCH Prachand Helicopter

- President Droupadi Murmu recently undertook a 25-minute historic sortie in the indigenous LCH Prachand at Air Force Station Jaisalmer, marking her third major flight in a combat aircraft to witness India's defense prowess.
- Prachand is India's first indigenously designed and developed dedicated combat helicopter, built specifically for offensive roles in high-altitude and battlefield environments.
- It is a multi-role light attack helicopter capable of air-to-air and air-to-ground missions, including anti-armour and counter- insurgency operations.
- Designed and manufactured by Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) under the Light Combat Helicopter (LCH) programme.
- The primary objective of the Prachand project is to provide a high-altitude combat platform capable of operating in the unique terrain of the Himalayas (Siachen Glacier and Leh), where heavier attack helicopters often struggle due to thin air.
- Performance: It can operate at altitudes exceeding 5,000 meters (16,400 ft), the highest for any attack helicopter in the world.
- Speed & Range: Boasts a maximum speed of 268 kmph and a combat range of 550 km.
- Weaponry: Equipped with a 20mm turret gun, 70mm rockets, Air-to-Air missiles (ATAM), and Anti-Tank Guided Missiles (ATGM).

Indian Army launches major bridge project in Sri Lanka under Operation Sagar Bandhu

- Operation Sagar Bandhu demonstrates the Indian Army's ability to rapidly deploy specialised engineering capabilities in support of friendly nations.
- The operation reflects the country's strengthened regional resilience, vision of cooperative security and humanitarian partnership in the Indian Ocean region.

Operation Sankalp

Indian warships on standby for humanitarian operations

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India is closely monitoring the evolving security situation in parts of West Asia following the recent escalation of tensions, with Indian Navy ships deployed in the region under Operation Sankalp placed on standby for possible humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR) operations.

A senior defence official on Monday confirmed that developments are being tracked closely and updates are being shared with the concerned departments for further direction.

"Under Operation Sankalp, two Indian Navy ships [a frigate and a destroyer] are already deployed in the Gulf of Aden and the Gulf of Oman. They have been deployed for anti-piracy operations and the safety of merchant vessels since 2019. If required, these ships could be utilised for HADR operations. The Navy has prior experience in such missions," the official said.

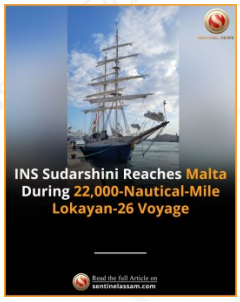
The deployment under Operation Sankalp was initiated to safeguard Indian-flagged vessels and ensure maritime security in the region amid rising threats to commercial shipping.

The official also stated that *INS Surat* is currently in Bahrain as part of a regional maritime security engagement.

Ready to assist: *INS Surat*, as part of a regional maritime security engagement, is currently in Bahrain. @INDIANNAVY X

- Against the backdrop of escalating tensions in West Asia, Indian Navy warships deployed under Operation Sankalp have been placed on standby for potential Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) operations.
- Operation Sankalp (Sanskrit for Commitment) is the Indian Navy's proactive maritime security initiative launched to ensure the safety of Indian-flagged merchant vessels and maintain regional stability in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).
- Launched in: The operation was officially launched on June 19, 2019, following escalating security concerns and attacks on commercial shipping in the Gulf of Oman and the Strait of Hormuz.

INS Sudarshini arrived at Valletta, Malta for expedition Lokayan-26



- The Indian Naval Sail Training Ship INS Sudarshini has arrived at the historic port of Valletta, Malta,
- The visit underscores the deep-rooted maritime ties between India and Malta and represents an important leg of the ship's ambitious 22 thousand- nautical-mile global voyage.
- INS Sudarshini was built by Goa Shipyard Limited.

DRDO and Indian Navy Conduct Successful trials of indigenous Air Droppable Container ADC-150

- Defence Research & Development Organisation (DRDO) and the Indian Navy jointly conducted four successful in-flight release trials of the indigenous Air Droppable Container 'ADC-150' from the P8I aircraft off the coast of Goa between February 21 to March 01, 2026
- Indigenously designed and developed to deliver 150 kg payload, the Air Droppable Container enhances the naval operational logistics capabilities for providing quick response to naval vessels under distress, needing critical stores/equipment, medical assistance etc. at blue sea deployed far from the coast.
- The Naval Science & Technological Laboratory, Visakhapatnam is the nodal laboratory for the activity.
- Aerial Delivery Research & Development Establishment, Agra has developed the parachute system and Centre for Military Airworthiness & Certification, Bengaluru provided the flight clearance & certification.
- Defence Research & Development Laboratory, Hyderabad provided the instrumentation support for the trials.

The Pinaka Multi-Barrel Rocket Launcher (MBRL) System

- The Indian Army has operationalized its seventh Pinaka regiment and is currently raising an eighth, with plans to reach ten regiments by next year.
- Pinaka is an indigenous, multi-barrel rocket launcher (MBRL) system capable of firing a salvo of 12 rockets in under 44 seconds.
- It is a high-volume, area-saturation weapon designed to neutralize enemy troop concentrations and infrastructure over large areas.
- Developed By: the Armament Research and Development Establishment (ARDE).
- The primary objective of the Pinaka system is to provide the Indian Army with deep-strike capability, allowing it to destroy enemy communication hubs, logistics depots, and artillery gun positions well behind the front lines.
- A single battery of six launchers can fire 72 rockets in just 44 seconds, covering an area of roughly 1,000 by 800 meters.
- The system is versatile, featuring Mk-I (38 km), Mk-II Extended Range (60 km), and Guided variants (75– 90 km).
- The launchers are mounted on high-mobility Tatra trucks, allowing for shoot-and-scoot tactics to avoid enemy counter-fire.

Sheshnaag-150

- India is developing the Sheshnaag-150, a long-range swarm attack drone that can fly over 1,000 km, carry powerful warheads and strike targets.
- It is a long-range collaborative attack swarm drone, with autonomous systems capable of deep strikes and saturation attacks.
- It is being developed by NewSpace Research and Technologies (NRT), a Bengaluru-based aerospace startup focusing on AI-driven unmanned systems and swarm robotics.
- Weighing about 150 kg, Sheshnag can carry 25-40 kg payload which is sufficient to damage infrastructure, military vehicles or personnel.
- What sets it apart is its AI-powered swarm tech — multiple drones can team up autonomously to evade defenses and hit targets together.
- It has an operational range of over 1,000 km.
- It can stay airborne for over five hours.

MoD inks Rs 5,083 crore contracts for ALH Mk-II (MR) & VL-Shtil missiles

MoD inks Rs 5,083 crore contracts for ALH Mk-II (MR) & VL-Shtil missiles

Posted On: 03 MAR 2026 3:22PM by PIB Delhi

Ministry of Defence, on March 03, 2026, signed contracts worth a total of Rs 5,083 crore for the acquisition of six Advanced Light Helicopters (ALH) Mk-II (Maritime Role) for the Indian Coast Guard and Surface-to-Air Vertical Launch - Shtil missiles for the Indian Navy. The contracts were inked in the presence of Defence Secretary Shri Rajesh Kumar Singh at South Block, New Delhi.

ALH Mk-III (MR)

The contract for ALH Mk-III (MR) along with operational role equipment, an engineering support package, and performance-based logistics support, valued at Rs 2,901 crore, has been inked with Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, Bengaluru under the Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed Developed and Manufactured) category.

These twin-engine helicopters incorporate state-of-the-art features superior to the currently operated airborne platforms and are capable of undertaking a wide spectrum of maritime security missions from shore-based airfields as well as from ships at sea. The induction will significantly enhance the Indian Coast Guard's capability for fulfilling the duties of safety and protection of artificial islands, offshore installations, and protection of fishermen & marine environment.

The project envisages supply of equipment from more than 200 MSMEs and is expected to generate approximately 65 lakh man-hours of employment. The contract reinforces the Government's commitment to *Aatmanirbhar Bharat* and the Make-in-India initiative, while further strengthening the nation's maritime security architecture.

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- The contract for the procurement of Surface-to-Air Vertical Launch - Shtil missiles and associated missile holding frames, has been signed with JSC Rosoboronexport, Russian Federation.

The Sejjil Ballistic Missile

- Iran officially deployed the Sejjil ballistic missile for the first time in active combat during Wave 54 of its military operations against US and Israeli positions.
- The missile, nicknamed the dancing missile for its evasive maneuvers, reportedly struck strategic infrastructure.
- The Sejjil (also known as Sajjil or Ashura) is an indigenous, two- stage, medium-range ballistic missile (MRBM).
- Developed By: The missile was indigenously developed by Iran's aerospace industries.
- It has an operational strike range of approximately 2,000 kilometers, putting the entire Levant region within reach.
- Capable of carrying a warhead weighing roughly 700 kilograms.

Minuteman III: 'doomsday' missile of U.S. amid escalating war tensions with Iran

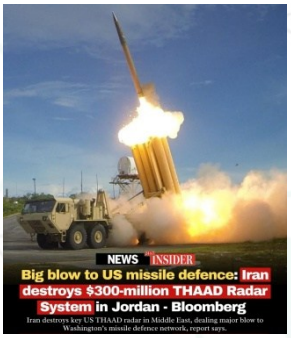
- The United States has carried out a test launch of the Minuteman III intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM), often referred to as the "doomsday missile", at a time when tensions with Iran remain high.
- The LGM-30G Minuteman III is an American-made intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM).
- "L" in LGM is the US Department of Defense designation for silo-launched; "G" means surface attack; and "M" stands for guided missile.
- Introduced in the early 1970s, the Minuteman III was the first missile in the US arsenal to feature multiple independently targetable reentry vehicles (MIRVs).
- It is the sole land-based component of the U.S. nuclear triad.
- It was developed for the United States by Douglas Aircraft Company, which later became part of McDonnell Douglas and then Boeing.

- Speed: Approximately 15,000 mph (Mach 23 or 24,000 kph) at burnout (Hypersonic).
- Range: It has a maximum range of approximately 13,000 kilometres.

Shahed Drones

- The United States recently raised serious concerns about the capabilities of Iran's Shahed attack drones.
- Shahed (meaning witness in Farsi) drones are low-cost, one- way-attack unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) developed by Iran.
- Often referred to as "kamikaze" or "suicide" drones, they function essentially as guided missiles that fly towards a pre- designated target and explode on impact.
- Most widely used variants: Shahed-131 and Shahed-136
- Russia refers to the Shahed-131 and Shahed-136 as "Geran-1" and "Geran-2," respectively.
- This low cost, along with a low-altitude flight profile and self-sacrificial nature, has seen Shaheds labelled "the poor man's cruise missile".
- The Shahed-131 has a range of 700–900 km, while the Shahed-136 has the longer range, i.e., between 2,000 and 2,500 kilometres.
- They are between 2.5 and three metres long and weigh around 200 kg at launch
- They can be launched from both static rail mounts as well as vehicles.

THAAD Missile System



- Recently, Iran has destroyed a key Terminal High Altitude Area Defence (THAAD) radar system used by the US to detect and intercept ballistic missiles in the Middle East.
- The Terminal High Altitude Area Defence (THAAD) system is one of the most advanced missile defence platforms.
- It is developed by the United States to counter ballistic missile threats.
- It is designed to intercept missiles during the final stage of their flight,
- THAAD can destroy incoming threats both inside and outside Earth's atmosphere, providing a critical defensive layer against short-medium-and limited intermediate-range ballistic missiles.
- THAAD uses "hit-to-kill" technology.
- THAAD can engage ballistic missile targets at ranges of roughly 150–200 kilometres.

Blue Sparrow Missile

- Israel reportedly used the Blue Sparrow missile to kill Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran recently.
- It is part of a family of three air-launched ballistic missiles, which also includes the Black Sparrow and the Silver Sparrow.
- They are developed by Rafael Advanced Defense Systems, an Israeli defense technology company.
- They were built as practice targets for Israel's Arrow missile defence system.
- Over time, however, the Blue Sparrow was adapted into an offensive air-to-surface weapon.
- It is typically launched from fighter aircraft, including Israeli F-15 jets, whose booster rockets propel the missile to high altitude before it begins its descent.
- It has a range of roughly 1,995 km.
- Unlike many conventional munitions, it follows a quasi- ballistic trajectory.
- After launch, the missile ascends rapidly, leaving the Earth's atmosphere before re-entering and descending toward its target.
- This ability to exit and re-enter the atmosphere complicates interception by air defence systems.

Precision Strike Missile (PrSM)

- The United States reportedly used the Precision Strike Missile (PrSM) for the first time in combat during strikes on Iran amid the ongoing West Asia conflict.
- The Precision Strike Missile (PrSM) is a long-range, surface-to- surface precision-guided missile designed for deep-strike operations against enemy targets such as air defenses, command centers, and logistics hubs.
- It is intended to replace the Army Tactical Missile System (ATACMS) used by the United States.
- Developed by: Lockheed Martin (USA) for the United States Army.
- Can be launched from M270 Multiple Launch Rocket System (MLRS) and M142 High Mobility Artillery Rocket System(HIMARS).
- Can strike targets from about 60 km to over 499 km, significantly farther than ATACMS (~300 km).

Gravity Bomb

- U.S. Defense Secretary announced a tactical shift to using 500, 1,000, and 2,000-pound precision gravity bombs against Iran, signaling that Iranian air defenses have been sufficiently degraded to allow direct aerial bombardment.
- A gravity bomb, often referred to as a free-fall or dumb bomb, is an unpowered munition that does not possess an internal propulsion system or engine.
- Unlike a missile, which flies under its own power, a gravity bomb relies entirely on the laws of physics and the momentum of the aircraft to reach its target.
- The pilot flies the aircraft to a specific release point. Once dropped, the bomb begins a free-fall trajectory.

Key Features:

- They are significantly cheaper than missiles.
- A gravity bomb with a JDAM kit costs roughly $25,000 to $30,000, compared to millions for a Tomahawk missile.

Versatility: They come in various weights for different targets:

- 500-lb (Mk 82): For soft targets like radar or light vehicles.
- 1,000-lb (Mk 83): For reinforced structures and bridges.
- 2,000-lb (Mk 84): Bunker-busters for deeply buried military complexes.
- Platform Compatibility: Can be deployed by a wide range of aircraft, from tactical stealth fighters (F-35) to heavy strategic bombers (B-52).

NCB busts pan-India darknet drug network called 'Team Kalki'

- Recently, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has dismantled a pan-India drug distribution network operating under the name Team Kalki.
- Narcotics Control Bureau is the nodal drug law enforcement and intelligence agency under the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India.
- It was constituted on 14th November, 1985, under the provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985 (NDPS Act).
- Headquarters: New Delhi

Functions of Narcotics Control Bureau

- Coordination among various Central and State Agencies engaged in drug law enforcement
- Assisting States in enhancing their drug law enforcement effort
- Collection and dissemination of intelligence
- Preparation of National Drug Enforcement Statistics
- Liaison with International agencies such as UNDCP, INCB, INTERPOL, Customs Cooperation Council, RILO etc
- It also functions as an enforcement agency through its zonal offices

VP Radhakrishnan Witnesses Sargam 2026 by Indian Naval Orchestra

- Sargam 2026, a performance by the Indian Naval Symphonic Orchestra that celebrates the Indian Navy's rich traditions through a blend of military, classical, and contemporary music, at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi
- The band presented a vibrant musical repertoire featuring Hindustani fusion to Brazilian samba-inspired compositions.
- The performance also included pieces ranging from legendary Tamil music composer Shri M. S. Viswanathan's 'Rajavin Parvai' to traditional folk tunes from western India.
- The band also performed a special patriotic musical presentation on Operation Sindoor named 'Kasam Sindoor Ki'.

Vajra Corps Marks 76th Raising Day, Celebrates Legacy as 'Defenders of Punjab'

- The Indian Army's Vajra Corps marked its 76th Raising Day on 2nd march , commemorating over seven decades of distinguished service to the Nation.
- Raised in 1950, it was the first Indian Army Corps to be raised post-Independence.
- Over the years, the Corps has played a pivotal role along the Western Front, earning distinction in the 1965 and 1971 Wars, including the historic Victories of Dograi, Barki and Khem Karan.
- Awarded 25 Battle Honours, 04 Honour Titles and 38 Theatre Honours, upholds the legacy as the 'Defenders of Punjab' as it enters its 76th year of dedicated service to the Nation.

Indian Army Organises 'Veterans Samman Sampark Rally' in Nagpur

- The Indian Army organised a "Veterans Samman Sampark Rally" at the Kavi Suresh Bhat Auditorium in Nagpur, under the guidance of Headquarters Uttar Maharashtra and Gujarat Sub-Area.
- The initiative aimed to understand the grievances of veterans and provide them with information about various welfare schemes offered by the Armed Forces as well as the Central and State governments.

Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation, Shri Amit Shah address 57th Raising Day ceremony of CISF as the Chief Guest in Odisha

- Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Shri Amit Shah will address the 57th Raising Day ceremony of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) as the Chief Guest on, 06 March 2026, in Mundali, Odisha.
- India celebrates CISF Raising Day on March 10 every year to honour the Central Industrial Security Forces of India (CISF)
- The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) is the Union's military force, founded by an Act of Parliament in 1968 (50 of 1968), and was established in 1969.

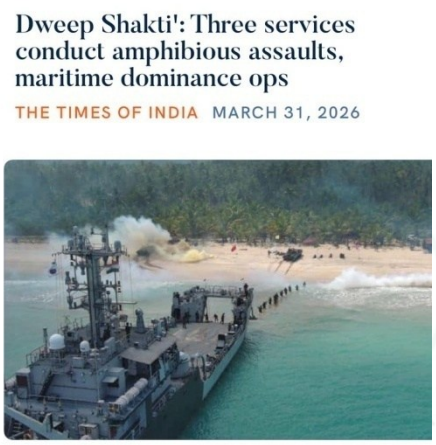
ASRAAM Induction to Enhance MiG-29 Air Combat Power

- The Indian Air Force is set to equip its fleet of MiG- 29 fighter jets with the Advanced Short Range Air- to-Air Missile, or ASRAAM.

About Advanced Short Range Air-to-Air Missile

- It is a European-designed short-range air-to-air missile built by the multinational company MBDA.
- The missile measures 2.9 metres in length, weighs 88 kilograms and carries a high-explosive warhead.
- The ASRAAM uses heat-seeking technology and is optimised for close-in dogfights.
- It operates on a fire-and-forget principle, which means once launched; the missile guides itself to the target without further input from the pilot.
- It reaches speeds in excess of Mach 3, can engage fast- moving fighter aircraft at ranges greater than 25 kilometres and delivers pinpoint accuracy.
- The technology features a Lock-On After Launch (LOAL) capability, allowing the pilot to fire the weapon before the seeker even sees the target.
- It has already been integrated on the indigenous LCA Tejas and Jaguar aircraft.

India recently conducted Exercise Dweep Shakti



- The Indian Armed Forces successfully concluded Dweep Shakti, a high-intensity tri-service exercise.
- The exercise was conducted under the aegis of the Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC)—India's only theater command
- Organizations Involved: Indian Army, Indian Navy and Indian Air Force.
- Dweep Shakti is a large-scale Tri-Service joint military exercise designed to test and validate India's integrated combat capabilities in coastal and island environments.
- It focuses on the rapid deployment of forces to protect remote island territories from maritime threats.

FOURTH SURVEY VESSEL (LARGE) 'SANSHODHAK' DELIVERED TO INDIAN NAVY AT GRSE KOLKATA

- Sanshodhak (Yard 3028), the last Survey Vessel (Large) ship steered by the Indian Navy's Warship Design Bureau, being built at Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers Ltd (GRSE), Kolkata was delivered to the Indian Navy .
- The contract for four Survey Vessel (Large) ships was signed on 30 Oct 2018.
- The previous ships of the same class, INS Sandhayak, INS Nirdeshak and INS Ikshak were commissioned on 03 Feb 2024, 18 Dec 2024 and 06 Nov 2025, respectively.
- The SVL ships are designed and built by M/s Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers Ltd (GRSE), Kolkata.
- With a displacement of about 3400 tons and an overall length 110 meters
- The ship is capable of full-scale coastal and deep-water Hydrographic survey of port/Harbour approaches and determination of navigational channels/ routes.

DELIVERY OF AGRAY – THE FOURTH ANTI-SUBMARINE WARFARE SHALLOW WATER CRAFT BUILT BY GRSE, KOLKATA

- 'Agray', the fourth of eight ASW SWC (Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft), indigenously designed and built by Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata, has been delivered to the Indian Navy.
- These ships, approximately 77 metres in length, are the largest Indian Naval warships propelled by waterjets
- The ship is a reincarnation of the erstwhile INS Agray, the fourth of the 1241 PE Class of Patrol Vessels, decommissioned in 2017.

INS Dunagiri was delivered to the Indian Navy.

- It is the fifth ship of Nilgiri Class (Project 17A).
- It was designed by Warship Design Bureau (WDB).
- It was built at Garden Reach Shipbuilding and Engineers Ltd (GRSE).
- It is the fifth P17A ship getting delivered to the Indian Navy.
- It is a reincarnation of the erstwhile INS Dunagiri, a Leander-class frigate, that was part of the Indian Navy
- Propulsion: These ships are configured with Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion plants.
- Armaments: It comprises BrahMos SSM, MFSTAR and MRSAM complex, 76mm SRGM, and a combination of 30 mm and 12.7 mm close-in weapon system.

Exercise Amogh Jwala

- The Pune-based Southern Command of the Indian Army conducted Exercise Amogh Jwala at the Babina field firing ranges in Uttar Pradesh
- The 13-day exercise from March 6 to 18 validated the deployment of mechanised forces with newly inducted Apache attack helicopters, fighter aircraft, drone and counter-drone systems and network-enabled battlefield platforms.
- The Exercise Amogh Jwala validated new operational concepts, force structures, procedures and protocols relevant to modern warfare.

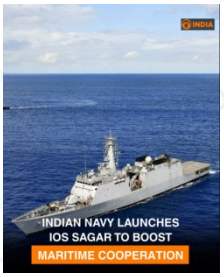
Operation Urja Suraksha

- India has launched Operation Urja Suraksha amid escalating tensions in West Asia to safeguard energy supply routes through the Strait of Hormuz
- Operation Urja Suraksha is a strategic maritime security mission launched by the Indian Navy to ensure the safe transit of India-bound energy cargo vessels from the Persian Gulf region.
- It focuses on protecting shipping routes in and beyond the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical energy chokepoints
- Naval Escort Mechanism: Indian warships escort vessels after they exit Hormuz, ensuring safe passage through the Gulf of Oman into the Arabian Sea

Vayu Baan Project

- The Indian Air Force (IAF) has initiated Vayu Baan, a pioneering project to develop India's first helicopter-launched drone system.
- It is a small, autonomous drone designed to be dropped from a moving helicopter mid-flight.
- Once released, the drone unfolds its wings, activates its propulsion, and operates as either a surveillance asset or a precision-guided munition (kamikaze drone).
- The Vayu Baan (meaning Air Arrow) is an indigenous Air- Launched Effects (ALE) program designed to integrate unmanned aerial systems directly with manned rotary-wing platforms.
- Launched By: The project is being led by the IAF's Directorate of Aerospace Design (DAD).
- The primary goal is to provide stand-off capability, allowing helicopters to identify and destroy enemy targets from a safe distance (over 50 km) without entering the kill zone of enemy man-portable air- defense systems (MANPADS).
- Capable of flying over 50 km after being dropped.

Indian Navy Launches IOS SAGAR Initiative 2026



- Recently, the second edition of Indian Ocean Ship (IOS) SAGAR commenced.
- Indian Ocean Ship (IOS) Sagar is a maritime security cooperation initiative in the Southwest Indian Ocean Region (IOR).
- It is designed as a unique operational engagement programme that enables naval personnel from Friendly Foreign Countries to train and sail together onboard an Indian Naval Ship.
- Participating members: This Edition includes participation from 16 nations of the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS) of the Indian Ocean Region(IOR).
- The initiative reflects the Government of India's vision of Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR) and framework of MAHASAGAR – Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security Across the Regions.

IONS MARITIME EXERCISE (IMEX) TTX 2026 HELD AT SOUTHERN NAVAL COMMAND, KOCHI

- The Indian Navy hosted IONS Maritime Exercise (IMEX) TTX 2026 at the Maritime Warfare Centre, Southern Naval Command, Kochi on 27 March 2026.
- The high-level engagement brought together distinguished delegates from Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS) member navies, international officers of IOS SAGAR, and officers from the Indian Navy to deliberate on evolving non- traditional maritime security challenges in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).

- The exercise witnessed participation from Bangladesh, France, Indonesia, Kenya, Maldives, Mauritius, Myanmar, Seychelles, Singapore, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Timor-Leste.
- As India assumes the IONS Chairmanship for the 2026– 2028 cycle after a gap of sixteen years, IMEX TTX 2026 .

Navy set to commission frontline stealth frigate 'Taragiri' on April 3

- The Indian Navy is preparing to commission its latest stealth Frigate, Taragiri (F41), on 03 Apr 2026.
- It is the fourth ship of Nilgiri Class (Project 17A) built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilding Ltd (MDL).
- It is a reincarnation of the erstwhile INS Taragiri, a Leander-class frigate that was part of the Indian Naval fleet.
- It is designed by the Warship Design Bureau (WDB).

Features of INS Taragiri

- It is fitted with an advanced weapon and sensor suite compared to the P17 (Shivalik) class.
- It is designed for 'High-Speed – High Endurance' versatility and multi-dimensional maritime operations.
- The ship's weapon suite is featuring supersonic Surface-to- Surface Missiles, Medium Range Surface-to-Air Missiles, and a specialised Anti-Submarine Warfare suite.
- Propulsion: It is configured with Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion plants, comprising a diesel engine and a gas turbine that drive a Controllable Pitch Propeller (CPP) on each shaft, and state-of-the-art Integrated Platform Management System (IPMS).

Tunguska Air Defence Missile System

- The Ministry of Defence signed a Rs 445 crore contract with Russia's JSC Rosoboronexport, to procure the Tunguska Air Defence Missile System for the Indian Army.
- The Tunguska (NATO reporting name: SA-19 Grison) is a Soviet-origin, tracked, self-propelled anti-aircraft weapon system.
- It is a unique hybrid platform that combines both surface- to-air missiles and high-speed anti-aircraft guns on a single chassis to provide comprehensive protection to ground forces.
- Originally developed by the KBP Instrument Design Bureau in the Soviet Union, the system is currently managed and exported by JSC Rosoboronexport, Russia.

  The system is designed to provide low-altitude air defense for infantry and armored regiments. Its main objective is to protect ground troops on the move against low-flying targets, including:
- It integrates 9M311 missiles for long-range engagement (up to 8–10 km) and twin 30 mm autocannons for close-in defense, firing up to 5,000 rounds per minute.
- Equipped with a 360-degree radar capable of detecting threats up to 18 km away, along with a digital fire control system for high precision.

Shaurya Squadrons

- The Indian Army recently began fielding Shaurya Squadrons, dedicated drone sub-units embedded within armoured regiments.
- Shaurya Squadrons are dedicated drone sub-units being inducted into the Indian Army's armoured regiments.
- They give tank commanders real-time surveillance and precision-strike capability at the unit level.
- Each squadron comprises 20 to 30 personnel trained in drone and counter-drone operations.
- They operate a mix of surveillance drones, attack drones, swarm drones, first-person view (FPV) drones, and loitering munitions.
- The aim is to compress the sensor-to-shooter cycle and push drone capability down to the unit level for faster targeting and engagement.
- The sensor-to-shooter cycle refers to the time between detecting a target and destroying it, which is the problem Shaurya Squadrons directly address.

- The Shaurya Squadron draws from the Army's prior deployment of Ashni Platoons within infantry battalions.
- Ashni units are also 25 to 30 personnel strong and carry the same blend of surveillance drones, attack drones, and loitering munitions, and are now an integral part of all infantry battalions.

India Eyes 6th-Gen Fighter Future: GCAP vs FCAS

- The Ministry of Defence informed the Parliamentary Standing Committee that the Indian Air Force is exploring membership in either the Global Combat Air Programme (GCAP) or the Future Combat Air System (FCAS).
- A collaborative effort to produce a System of Systems featuring a manned supersonic stealth jet accompanied by autonomous loyal wingman drones and advanced data integration.
- The GCAP is a high-tech initiative aimed at developing a sixth-generation stealth fighter to replace existing platforms like the Eurofighter Typhoon and Mitsubishi F-2.
- Established By: A merger of the UK-led Tempest programme and the Japanese F-X programme, formally announced in late 2022.
- Members: The United Kingdom, Italy, and Japan.

About Future Combat Air System (FCAS):

- A Next Generation Weapon System (NGWS) that includes a Next- Generation Fighter (NGF), unmanned Remote Carriers, and an Air Combat Cloud.
- The FCAS is Europe's other major 6th-generation project, designed to create a networked combat environment for the mid-21st century.
- Established By: France and Germany, later joined by Spain.
- Members: France, Germany, and Spain.

Qader Cruise Missile

- Recently, Iran fired Qader cruise missiles at the USS Abraham Lincoln aircraft carrier.
- It is a medium-range shore-based anti-ship cruise missile developed by Iran and deployed by its naval forces.

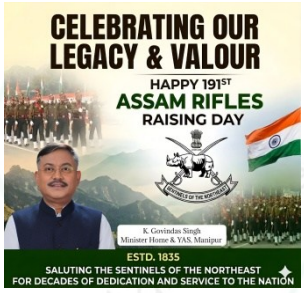
Features

- It is used by naval forces to target ships.
- It is an upgraded version of the Noor missile, which is based on Chinese missile design.
- Range: The missile has a reported range between 120 and 300 kilometres.
- It carries a warhead of about 200 kilograms of high explosive.

What are Cruise Missiles?

- A cruise missile is a guided missile that flies at low altitudes, often following the contours of the terrain to avoid radar detection.
- It flies at low altitude, powered by jet engines, can maneuver around obstacles
- Guidance System: GPS, terrain contour matching, inertial navigation
- Speed: Subsonic to supersonic (Mach 0.8-3);
- Range Short to medium (50-2,500 km)
- Launch Platforms: Air, sea, and land platforms.
- Examples: BrahMos, Nirbhay, Tomahawk

Assam Rifles celebrates 191st Raising Day



- The Assam Rifles, one of the oldest paramilitary forces in India, celebrated its 191st Raising Day on 24th march .
- Assam Rifles is a Central Paramilitary Force under the Central Armed Police Forces.
- Director General Lt General Vikas Lakhera
- Assam Rifles was raised on March 24, 1835
- Four battalions of the force also received the General Officer Commanding-in-Chief Unit Citation, while the '8 Assam Rifles' battalion was conferred the prestigious title of 'Bravest of the Brave' on Army Day 2026.

Science and Technology

NASA clears its Artemis 2 moon rocket for April launch with four astronauts

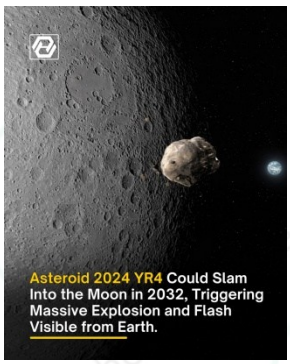
- The rocket will be crewed by three American astronauts — mission commander Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover and Christina Koch — and Canadian astronaut Jeremy Hansen
- NASA is set to launch its first crewed mission to the lunar vicinity since 1972. The mission, known as Artemis II, involves the Space Launch System (SLS) rocket and the Orion spacecraft.
- It is the second scheduled flight of the Artemis program and the first crewed Artemis mission.
- Artemis II is a 10-day mission aiming to validate critical life support and re-entry systems in deep space.
- The mission will involve more than 2,700 suppliers from 47 states contributing to the lunar spaceport at NASA's Kennedy Space Center.
- The SLS is the only rocket capable of sending the Orion spacecraft, four astronauts, and large cargo directly to the Moon in a single launch.

NASA DART Mission Alters Orbit of Entire Asteroid System

- A recent scientific study has revealed that NASA's Double Asteroid Redirection Test (DART) mission produced a greater impact than initially expected.
- The experiment not only changed the motion of a small asteroid within its binary system but also slightly altered the entire system's orbit around the Sun.
- The DART mission targeted Dimorphos, a small asteroid that orbits a larger asteroid called Didymos.
- DART (Double Asteroid Redirection Test) was a NASA space probe dedicated to investigating and demonstrating one method of asteroid deflection by changing an asteroid's motion in space through kinetic impact.
- It was launched on November 24, 2021.
- It was the first-ever space mission to demonstrate asteroid deflection by a kinetic impactor.
- The target of DART was a binary asteroid system consisting of a smaller moonlet, Dimorphos, orbiting around a larger asteroid, Didymos.

After 14 Years, NASA says a 600 kg satellite will crash back into Earth

- The Van Allen spacecraft, which is more than 600 kilogrammes, is expected to re-enter Earth's atmosphere almost 14 years after its launch.
- According to Nasa, the Van Allen Probe A and its twin, Van Allen Probe B, were launched on August 30, 2012, to study the radiation belts around Earth after which they are named.
- The pair was designed to fly through and study rings of high-energy radiation particles that are trapped by Earth's magnetic field.
- After the mission ended in 2019, NASA analysts predicted that it would re-enter Earth sometime in 2034, but those calculations changed after the current solar cycle started.



Asteroid 2024 YR4

- NASA has officially ruled out the possibility of asteroid 2024 YR4 colliding with the Moon on December 22, 2032.
- Refined calculations using the James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) have confirmed the object will pass at a safe distance of 21,200 km.
- 2024 YR4 is a Near-Earth Object (NEO) classified as an Apollo-type asteroid (Earth-crossing).
- Discovered in December 2024 by the ATLAS survey in Chile, it briefly gained international attention as one of the most hazardous objects found in recent decades.
- The Yarkovsky Effect: Scientists believe it was nudged toward Earth by the Yarkovsky effect, where uneven heating from the Sun acts as a mini-thruster, gradually shifting its orbit over millions of years.

Proba-3 Mission

- Recently, the European Space Agency (Esa) has lost contact with one of the two spacecraft powering its Proba-3 mission.
- It is the European Space Agency's (ESA) first mission dedicated to precision formation flying.
- It is the innovative mission which will demonstrate precision formation flying between two satellites to create an artificial eclipse, revealing new views of the Sun's faint corona.
- Objective is to create an artificial eclipse by precisely coordinating two independent satellites.
- This capability will enable scientists to observe the Sun's corona, a region typically obscured by the intense brightness of the Sun.
- It consists of two small satellites — a Coronagraph spacecraft and a solar-disc-shaped Occulter spacecraft.

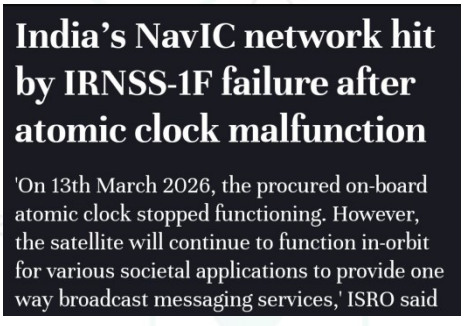
Silverpit Crater Confirmed as Ancient Asteroid Impact Site

- New research has confirmed that the Silverpit Crater was formed by a massive asteroid impact millions of years ago.
- Location: It lies about 700 meters beneath the seabed in the North Sea, roughly 80 miles off the coast of Yorkshire, United Kingdom.
- Silverpit is buried under a huge layer of sediment and was only discovered in 2002.
- It was formed by a high-velocity space rock striking the seabed roughly 43 to 46 million years ago.
- Researchers identified "shocked" quartz and feldspar crystals in rock samples from a nearby oil well that only form under the extreme shock pressures of a high- velocity space impact.

Lunar Eclipse 2026: When, where, and how to watch in India?

- The first total lunar eclipse of the year will take place on March 3, 2026.
- In India, the phenomenon is known as Chandra Grahan, and can be viewed with the naked eye.
- A lunar eclipse occurs when the Earth moves between the Sun and the Moon, causing the Earth's shadow to fall on the Moon's surface.
- During this time, the Moon may appear dimmer or take on a reddish hue. This reddish appearance is often called a "Blood Moon."

NavIC satellite loses its atomic clock



- ISRO recently reported that the atomic clock on the IRNSS-1F satellite has failed, reducing the number of functional positioning satellites in the NavIC constellation.
- An atomic clock is an ultra-precise timekeeping device that uses the vibrations of atoms (usually Rubidium or Cesium) to measure time.
- In navigation satellites, these clocks are essential because even a billionth of a second of error can lead to a location inaccuracy of several meters on the ground.

How it Works?

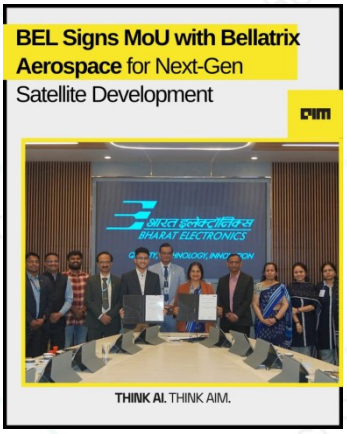
- Atomic Resonance: The clock measures the precise frequency of electromagnetic radiation emitted or absorbed by electrons when they change energy levels within an atom.

- Ultra-Stability: Unlike mechanical or quartz clocks, atoms vibrate at a perfectly constant rate, providing a stable frequency that does not drift over time.
- Time-of-Flight Measurement: The satellite sends a signal with a timestamp. By comparing when the signal was sent to when it was received, the receiver calculates the distance.
- Trilateration: By calculating distances from at least four different satellites simultaneously, a receiver can pin-point a user's exact latitude, longitude, and altitude.

Features:

- They are accurate to within one second every few million years.
- Satellites usually carry multiple clocks (often three or four) in case one fails.
- While earlier NavIC clocks were imported, the new generation (NVS series) features India-developed Rubidium atomic clocks.

Very Low Earth Orbit (VLEO) Satellite Systems



- State-run defense major Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL) and space-tech startup Bellatrix Aerospace have signed an MoU to jointly develop Very Low Earth Orbit (VLEO) satellite systems.
- The collaboration is a strategic partnership to design, develop, and manufacture next-generation satellite platforms and payloads specifically for the Very Low Earth Orbit (VLEO) It combines high- end defense electronics manufacturing with innovative satellite propulsion technologies.

Aim:

- To build indigenous capabilities in VLEO satellite platforms.
- To develop integrated satellite solutions for both strategic (defense) and civilian applications.
- To combine PSU manufacturing depth with the agility of a deep-tech startup to accelerate space innovation.
- VLEO refers to altitudes between 150 km and 450 km, which is significantly lower than traditional Low Earth Orbit (LEO) (500 km – 2,000 km).
- To prevent the satellite from falling back to Earth, Bellatrix's specialized electric/green propulsion systems provide constant station-keeping thrust to counter the drag.

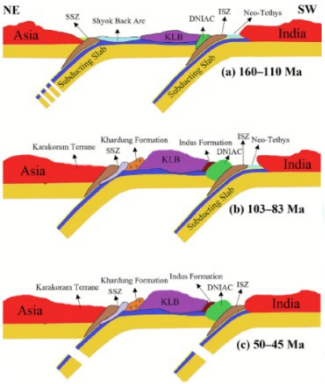
Moonshot Project

- The Indian Institute of Science has launched a Moonshot project on brain co-processors in partnership with the Pratiksha Trust.
- The project is led by the Indian Institute of Science.
- It is funded by the Pratiksha Trust, founded by Kris Gopalakrishnan and Sudha Gopalakrishnan.
- The Moonshot Project is an advanced research initiative to develop brain co-processors—devices that interface with the human brain to decode neural signals, process them using AI, and stimulate the brain to restore lost functions.
- It combines neuromorphic computing, artificial intelligence, neuroscience, and bioelectronics to create closed-loop brain– machine systems.

'Dark Oxygen' Discovered In Pacific Ocean's Deep Seafloor

- Scientists exploring the deep Pacific Ocean have reported the discovery of what they describe as "dark oxygen", detected about 4,000 metres below the ocean surface where sunlight never reaches.
- "Dark oxygen" refers to oxygen detected in deep-sea environments where sunlight is completely absent.
- Traditionally, oxygen production has been linked to photosynthesis, carried out by plants, algae, and certain bacteria that use light energy to convert water and carbon dioxide into oxygen.
- However, researchers observed measurable oxygen levels in deep ocean regions where photosynthesis is impossible.
- The study, published in the journal "Nature Geoscience", found that oxygen concentrations near polymetallic nodules increased over time during experiments conducted in sealed conditions on the seafloor.
- The Clarion–Clipperton Zone in the Pacific Ocean is rich in polymetallic nodules containing manganese, nickel, and cobalt.

Recently, scientists have traced the evolution of the Ladakh Magmatic Arc (LMA) in North West Himalaya.



- It is a belt of igneous rocks in the Trans-Himalaya formed in the period Jurassic to Eocene– 201.3 million years ago to 33.9 Million Year (Ma).
- The LMA is a long-extinct volcanic system evolved through three major phases of geological activity over tens of millions of years.
- 160–110 million years ago: Early island arc formation
- 103–45 million years ago: Intensified magmatism during plate convergence
- Less than 45 million years ago: Post-collisional magmatic activity.
- Millions of years before the region that is now called Ladakh lay above an ocean called the Neo- Tethys Ocean.
- Below that ancient sea, giant slabs of Earth's crust slowly plunged into the mantle in a process known as subduction leading to the formation of the Ladakh Magmatic Arc (LMA).

Devon Island

- NASA uses Devon Island to study Mars, primarily because it's barren and its freezing, polar desert conditions allow researchers to test next-generation rovers.
- It is located in the Canadian arctic archipelago, within the zone classified as the High Arctic.
- It is the world's largest uninhabited island.
- Ellesmere Island lies to the north of Devon Island and Baffin Bay lies to its east.
- Winters are extremely harsh with temperatures being as low as −50 °C.
- The limited solar energy input is also one of the factors influencing the existence of life on this island.
- Little precipitation is also received on Devon Island.
- NASA uses Devon Island to study Mars, primarily because it's barren, and its freezing, polar desert conditions allow researchers to test next-generation rovers.

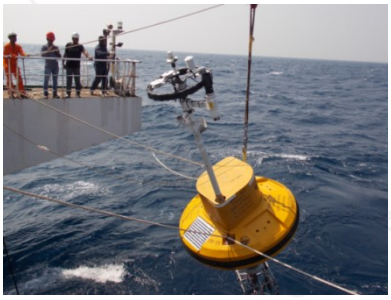
IIT Guwahati Develops Dual-Use MXene Catalyst

- Recently, the IIT Guwahati research team developed a MXene- based catalyst that can both produce hydrogen efficiently from water and act as a photocatalyst for desalination.
- MXenes are a group of two-dimensional materials first discovered in 2011.
- They are made from a bulk crystal called MAX.
- They have the general formula of $M_{n+1}X_nT_x$, where M is an early transition metal, X is carbon and/or nitrogen, and T is a functional group on the surface of an MXene (typically O, OH, and F).
- Among various types of MXenes, titanium carbide ($Ti_3C_2T_x$) is the most widely used.
- Properties of MXenes: They show high electrical conductivity, excellent mechanical strength, good chemical stability, remarkable hydrophilicity, and tunable surface chemistry.

Applications of MXenes

- MXene could be used in energy storage devices such as electrodes of Li-ion batteries, pseudo capacitors, etc.
- These can be used in in water desalination and wastewater treatment.

Floating LiDAR Buoy System



- Recently, the National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT) has successfully tested an indigenously developed Floating LiDAR Buoy System off the coast of Muttom in Tamil Nadu.
- It is a high-tech ocean-based instrument used to measure wind conditions over the sea.
- It combines a floating platform (buoy) with LiDAR technology, short for Light Detection and Ranging.
- It uses laser pulses to measure atmospheric conditions with high precision.
- Purpose: It is designed to measure wind profiles and atmospheric conditions over the ocean. It can track wind speed and direction and changes in wind at different heights

Hutchinson-Gilford Progeria Syndrome (HGPS)

- U.S.-based Sentynl Therapeutics (part of Zydus Lifesciences) recently signed a deal with South Korea's PRG S&T to develop Progerinin, a pill aimed at treating Hutchinson-Gilford progeria syndrome (HGPS).

Hutchinson-Gilford Progeria Syndrome (HGPS)

- Progeria, also known as HGPS, is an extremely rare genetic disease that causes rapid aging in children.
- Progeria is extremely rare. It occurs in 1 in every 4 million live births worldwide.
- A genetic mutation in the LMNA gene causes progeria. The LMNA gene is responsible for making a protein called lamin A.
- Lamin A is an important part of the structural scaffolding that holds the nucleus of each cell in your body together.
- A tiny mutation in the LMNA gene causes it to create an irregular form of the lamin A protein called progerin.

However, their rapid aging causes distinct physical characteristics, including:

- Hair loss (baldness).
- Prominent eyes.
- Aged, wrinkled skin.
- A thin, beaked nose.

  Progeria is always fatal. The average age of death is 14.5 years, although some adults with progeria will live into their early 20s.

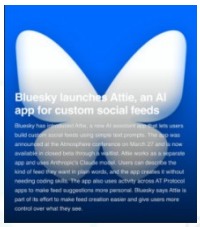
Cassava Brown Streak Disease

- Recently, a study warns that more than a third of Africa is at risk of Cassava Brown Streak Disease
- It is a devastating disease that causes loss of cassava root (tuber) production and quality.
- Cause: It is caused by two types of virus, Cassava Brown Streak Virus (CBSV) and Ugandan Cassava Brown Streak Virus (UCBSV).
- It was first identified in Africa in the coastal region of East Africa close to the mid-20th century.
- It is primarily spread by the whitefly Bemisia tabaci, a pest that exists as a complex of genetically distinct groups.
- It spreads through particular whitefly populations in sub- Saharan Africa, known as Sub-Saharan Africa 1 and 2, which are highly efficient at transmitting the virus.
- Typical CBSD symptoms are leaf chlorosis, brown streaks on stems and dry hard rot in roots which affects both the quality and quantity of edible storage roots.
- The disease causes necrosis in the roots of infected plants, often leading to total crop loss.

News in short

- Microsoft has unveiled 'Project Helix,' its next- generation Xbox console, hinting at a fusion of console and PC gaming.
- Uber co-founder Travis Kalanick launched a startup called Atoms that is focused on specialised industrial robotics designed to automate tasks in the mining, transport, and food sectors.

Bluesky introduces Attie, a new app that lets users vibe-code their own social feed



- Bluesky, a decentralised social networking app, has unveiled a new AI-powered app that lets users design their algorithm, create custom feeds, and essentially 'vibe-code' their own social media experience.
- The new agentic AI social app, called Attie.

BA.3.2 Cicada COVID Variant Shows Rising Global Presence

- A new variant of SARS-CoV-2 (Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome Coronavirus 2) called BA.3.2 is being tracked around the world
- It is nicknamed "Cicada" because, much like the insect that remains hidden for long periods before emerging, this variant went largely unnoticed before beginning to spread more widely.
- BA.3.2 is a sub-lineage of the Omicron family of SARS-CoV-2 that caused the Covid-19 global pandemic.
- The biggest concern around BA.3.2 is its unusually high number of mutations, particularly in the spike protein,

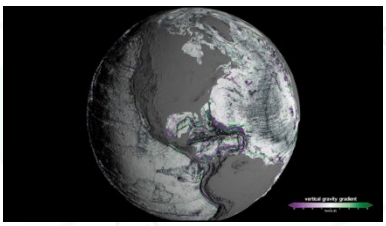
Symptoms

- Sore throat
- Fatigue
- Body aches
- Runny nose
- Fever and chills
- Cough

Some patients may also experience:

- Headache
- Nausea or mild gastrointestinal issues
- Shortness of breath (in fewer cases)
- Vaccines are likely to be less effective at preventing infection
- But still protect strongly against severe illness, hospitalisation, and death

Recently, NASA has developed a new map of the ocean floor by using satellite data from SWOT Satellite



- The Surface Water and Ocean Topography (SWOT) satellite was launched in 2022.
- It is a joint mission of NASA and CNES (French Space Agency).
- Objective: Satellite will collect detailed measurements of how water bodies on Earth change over time
- It uses a specialised instrument called the Ka-band Radar Interferometer (KaRIn) to measure the height, width, and elevation of surface water bodies such as rivers, lakes, reservoirs, and oceans.
- SWOT offers high spatial resolution by bouncing microwaves off water surfaces and calculating return time, allowing dynamic water movement tracking.
- The satellite circles Earth and can scan about 90 per cent of the planet every 21 days.
- It is equipped to observe the entire length of nearly all rivers wider than 330 feet and more than 1 million lakes and reservoirs larger than 5 acres.

The moon's titanium-rich rocks

- A new study by researchers from IIT-Kharagpur and the Physical Research Laboratory (PRL), Ahmedabad decoded the moon's titanium-rich rocks.
- It is the fourth most abundant metal and the ninth most abundant element in the Earth's crust.
- It often occurs in ore deposits in the form of chemical compounds with iron or oxygen.
- It is present in meteorites and the sun.
- Ores of Titanium: The two prime commercial minerals are Ilmenite ($FeTiO3$) and Rutile ($TiO2$).
- Titanium is obtained by the Kroll process.

Properties of Titanium

- It is very corrosion resistant and generally not affected by air, water, acids or bases.
- It has a low density, good strength, is easily fabricated, and has excellent corrosion resistance.
- The metal burns in air and is the only element that burns in nitrogen.

Applications of Titanium

- It is useful in aircraft, spacecraft, ships, and other high-stress applications.
- It also is used in prosthetic devices, because it does not react with fleshy tissue and bone.
- Titanium oxide spectra are used by astronomers to identify cool red dwarf stars.

The Minor Planet Centre (MPC) announced 15 new moons had been found, four around Jupiter and 11 around Saturn

- It is the world's primary repository for all observations of small bodies in the solar system.
- It is Located in Cambridge, Massachusetts
- It operates at the Smithsonian Astrophysical Observatory under the International Astronomical Union
- When astronomers discover a new object, they send their data to the MPC, where experts verify the observations and calculate the object's orbit.
- If the discovery is new, the MPC assigns it an official designation.

Elon Musk launches 'Terafab' project to make own AI chips

- Elon Musk officially launched the "Terafab" project
- The project is a joint venture between Tesla and SpaceX, with significant integration for xAI,
- Aim to produce one terawatt of computing power per year
- Facility Location: Near Austin, Texas

Biologics

- The Union Budget 2026 announced the Biopharma SHAKTI strategy to boost domestic production of biologics and biosimilars, alongside a shift toward non-animal testing models.
- Biologicals are a class of advanced medicines produced using living organisms. Unlike traditional small molecule drugs (like aspirin) which are synthesized through chemical processes, biologics are large, complex proteins derived from biological sources.
- The primary goal of biologics is to provide highly targeted therapy for chronic and life-threatening diseases—such as cancer, rheumatoid arthritis, and diabetes—by interacting specifically with human receptors and immune pathways that traditional chemicals cannot reach.

Key Features:

- They are significantly larger and more structurally complex than chemically synthesized drugs.
- Derived from living systems such as microorganisms, plant cells, or animal/human cells and plasma.
- They bind to specific cell receptors, which allows for precision medicine with fewer off-target effects.
- Extremely sensitive to environmental factors like temperature and light; they usually require a cold chain for storage.
- Because they are proteins, they have the potential to trigger an immune response in the human body, requiring rigorous safety monitoring.

Waste Foundry Sand

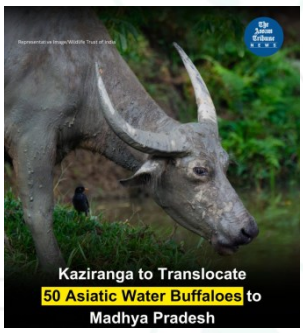
- Recently, the Institute of Indian Foundrymen (IIF) and CSIR-Central Road Research Institute (CSIR-CRRI) entered into an agreement to develop and facilitate solutions for the utilisation of waste foundry sand in road construction.
- It is a byproduct from the production of both ferrous and nonferrous metal castings.
- It is high quality silica sand.
- The physical and chemical characteristics of foundry sand depend upon the type of casting process and the type of industries.
- Classification of foundry sands depends upon the type of binder systems used in metal casting.
- Two types of binder systems are generally used, and on the basis of that foundry sands are categorized as: clay-bonded sands (green sand) and chemically bonded sands.
- Clay-bonded (Green) sand is composed of naturally occurring materials which are blended together; high quality silica sand (85–95%), bentonite clay (4–10%) as a binder
- Chemically bonded sands are used both in core making where high strengths are necessary to withstand the heat of molten metal, and in mold making.

Environment

The Debrigarh Wildlife Sanctuary is set to host the second edition of the two-day 'Indian Bison Fest'.

- Debrigarh Wildlife Sanctuary is situated in the Bargarh district of Odisha.
- It is located near Hirakud Dam (the longest dam in India and the longest earthen dam in the world) on the Mahanadi River.
- It finds a special mention because of noted freedom fighter Veer Surendra Sai.
- During his rebellion against the British, his base at Barapathara was located within the sanctuary.

Kanha Tiger Reserve



- Recently, the Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve has cleared all formalities to translocate about 50 wild Asiatic water buffaloes from the park to the Kanha Tiger Reserve in Madhya Pradesh in a phase-wise manner.
- Kanha Tiger Reserve is located in the "Maikal" ranges of the Satpuras in the state of Madhya Pradesh.
- Corridor: It has an active corridor between Kanha and Pench Tiger Reserves.
- Kanha is also connected with the Achanakmar Tiger Reserve of Chhattisgarh State.
- Tribal Communities: The region is known for some of the ancient tribal communities, like the Gond and Baiga still inhabit the region.
- It is also the first tiger reserve in India to officially introduce a mascot, "Bhoorsingh the Barasingha".

India submits seventh national report on biodiversity to CBD

- The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change has submitted India's First National Report on the implementation of the Nagoya Protocol on Access Benefit Sharing to the Secretariat of the Convention on Biological Diversity.
- The Nagoya Protocol on Access to Genetic Resources and the Fair and Equitable Sharing of Benefits Arising from their Utilization (ABS) to the Convention on Biological Diversity is a supplementary agreement to the Convention on Biological Diversity.
- It was adopted on 29 October 2010 in Nagoya, Japan and entered into force on 12 October 2014, 90 days after the deposit of the fiftieth instrument of ratification.
- It provides a transparent legal framework for the effective implementation of the fair and equitable sharing of benefits arising out of the utilization of genetic resources.
- India ratified it in 2012.
- It applies to genetic resources that are covered by the CBD, and to the benefits arising from their utilization.
- It covers traditional knowledge (TK) associated with genetic resources that are covered by the CBD and the benefits arising from its utilization.

India has submitted its 7th National Report to the Convention on Biological Diversity

- India has officially submitted its 7th National Report (NR7) to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD), marking the first comprehensive assessment since the 2022 Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework.
- The NR7 is a mandatory periodic submission by member nations of the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD).
- It serves as a national report card to track progress toward the 23 global biodiversity targets set for 2030.
- In India, this report was coordinated by the MoEFCC and the National Biodiversity Authority, utilizing 142 national indicators to assess ecosystem health, species recovery, and policy alignment.

Key Achievements:

- India has successfully updated its National Biodiversity Strategy and Action Plan (NBSAP) to fully align with global 2030 goals.
- Land-Use Planning (NBT1): This target is officially on track, with forest and tree cover reaching 25.17% of India's total geographical area.
- Ecosystem Restoration (NBT2): Also on track, India has restored or put under restoration 24.1 million hectares of land, nearing its 26- million-hectare Bonn Challenge pledge.
- Flagship Species Recovery: The tiger population has reached 3,167, alongside increases in Asiatic lions and stable one-horned rhino populations.

- Carbon Sequestration: Forest carbon stock increased by 81.5 million tonnes, showcasing the role of biodiversity in climate mitigation.
- Digital Governance: The launch of PARIVESH 2.0 has streamlined environmental clearances, integrating biodiversity data into infrastructure planning.

About CBD (Secretariat: Montreal, Canada)

- Legally binding treaty adopted at the UN's Conference on Environment and Development, Earth Summit, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil in 1992.
- It entered into force in 1993 and operates under United Nations Environment Programme.
- Governing Body: Conference of Parties (CoP).
- Objectives: Conservation of biological diversity; sustainable use of its components; and fair and equitable sharing of the benefits
- Protocols: Cartagena protocol on biosafety and Nagoya protocol on access and benefit sharing.

Anavaran Portal

- Recently, the Forest Survey of India stopped its Anavaran-Deforestation Alert System on deforestation.
- Anavaran Portal has been operational since January 2024.
- It has been using satellite data and machine learning to enable Forest Survey of India to issue location alerts on the loss of forest cover to states every 15 days so that targeted field inspections can be carried out.
- The Anavaran alert system is based on the Google Earth Engine (GEE) platform.
- It uses Sentinel-2 satellite images as input data.
- For continuous monitoring during cloudy and monsoon seasons, this is further integrated with Sentinel-1 Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) data.

Forest Survey of India (FSI)

- It is a premier national organization under the union Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change.
- It was established on June 1,1981 by succeeding the “Preinvestment Survey of Forest Resources” (PISFR)”
- It is responsible for assessment and monitoring of the forest resources of the country regularly.
- It has been publishing the State of Forest Report on a biennial basis since 1987.

LaBL 2.0 (Lighting a Billion Lives 2.0)

- The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) launched LaBL 2.0 (Lighting a Billion Lives 2.0) in New Delhi to expand decentralized renewable energy solutions across India.
- LaBL 2.0 is a next-generation decentralised renewable energy (DRE) programme aimed at expanding clean energy access while enabling productive rural livelihoods and climate action.
- It builds upon the earlier Lighting a Billion Lives initiative (launched in 2008) that focused on providing solar lighting solutions to off-grid communities.

The Dual-Sex Crab (Vela carli)

- Researchers have discovered a rare dual-sex condition in a freshwater crab species within the Silent Valley National Park of the Western Ghats.
- This finding marks the first recorded instance of gynandromorphy in the crab family Gecarcinucidae.
- Gynandromorphy happens due to genetic errors during early embryonic development.
- In this condition, a single organism shows both male and female physical traits on the same body.

Chelonus (Carinichelonus) Mahadeb

- A rare parasitic wasp Chelonus (Carinichelonus) mahadeb named has been recently recorded from a tea estate in Assam.

About Chelonus (Carinichelonus) mahadeb

- It is a new species of parasitic wasp.
- It was discovered from Nahortoli Tea Estate in Assam.
- Parasitic wasps of the genus Chelonus are tiny insects but play an important ecological role.
- They are known as egg–larval parasitoids, meaning they lay their eggs inside the eggs of other insects, usually moths and butterflies.
- The discovery is notable because the subgenus Carinichelonus is extremely rare and poorly documented worldwide.
- It is only the second new species of this subgenus described from India in recent times.

The Striped Hyena

- Tajikistan and Uzbekistan have formally proposed including the striped hyena in Appendix I and II of the Convention on Migratory Species (CMS) at the upcoming CMS COP15 in Brazil.
- The striped hyena is a medium-sized, nocturnal carnivore and the only hyena species found in the Indian subcontinent.
- While often misunderstood as a pure scavenger, it is a vital sanitary worker of the ecosystem, primarily feeding on carrion but also capable of hunting small prey.
- Found across North and Sub-Saharan Africa, the Middle East, Caucasus, Central Asia, and the Indian Subcontinent.
- They thrive in arid and semi-arid regions, including savannas, grasslands, semi-deserts, open woodlands, and rocky mountainous terrain.
- IUCN Red List: Near Threatened (Global); Vulnerable (Mediterranean region).
- CMS Proposal: Proposed for Appendix I (Endangered migratory species) and Appendix II (Species requiring international cooperation).
- Indian Law: Protected under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, providing it the highest level of legal protection in India.

Convention on the Conservation of Migratory Species (CMS)

- Also called Bonn Convention, under United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP).
- Signed: 23 June 1979, Bonn, Germany.
- Global treaty for conservation of migratory animals and their habitats.
- COP (Conference of Parties) is the decision-making body.

Appendices:

- Appendix I: Endangered migratory species (strict protection).
- Appendix II: Species with unfavourable conservation status (international cooperation needed).

Gitchak nakana

- A new groundwater fish species, 'Gitchak Nakana', has been recently discovered in Assam
- This miniature, blind loach was discovered from a dug-out well in Assam, marking the first aquifer-dwelling (phreatobitic) fish recorded from Northeast India.
- Named Gitchak nakana, the species draws from the Garo language, "Gitchak" meaning red, referencing its striking blood- red live colour, and "na-tok" and "kana" referring to a blind fish.

The Ruddy Shelduck

- Residents of Mudh village in Ladakh have been protecting the Ruddy Shelduck for over two decades, escorting fledglings safely to the Indus River during breeding season.
- The Ruddy Shelduck (Tadorna ferruginea), also known as the Brahminy duck, is a large migratory waterfowl species found across Europe, Central Asia, and parts of Africa, wintering in South Asia.
- In India, Ladakh is its only breeding site, where it nests in high-altitude wetlands between June and August.
- Occupies diverse ecosystems: rivers, lakes, marshes, ponds, deltas, and even man-made reservoirs.
- IUCN Status: Classified as Least Concern by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN).

New Plant Species Discovered in Manas Named After Zubeen Garg

- "Osbeckia zubeengargiana" is a newly discovered plant species from Manas National Park in Assam.
- It belongs to the Melastomataceae family and the genus "Osbeckia".
- The plant is a perennial shrub
- named it after renowned Assamese singer Zubeen Garg.

Nyctibatrachus Kali Frog Discovered in Karnataka

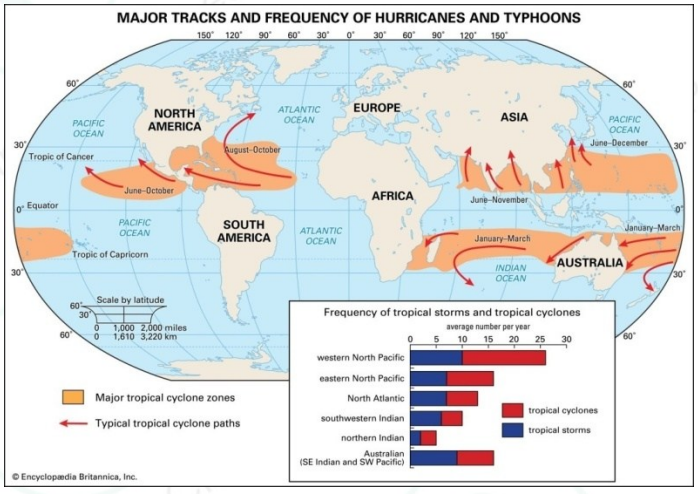
- Recently, the new frog species was discovered and named it as Nyctibatrachus kali.
- It is more commonly called 'Kali Night Frog.
- It was found in the Kali Tiger Reserve in Uttara Kannada district of Karnataka.
- It was named after the nearby Kali River (the reserve is also named after the river which flows through it).

Key Facts about Kali Tiger Reserve

- It is situated in the Uttara Kannada district of Karnataka.
- It is composed of Dandeli Wildlife Sanctuary and Anshi National Park.
- River: The Kali River, which forms the major source of water for Uttara Kannada, flows through the tiger reserve.

Red Skies in Australia as Cyclone Narelle Triggers Dust Storm

- Tropical Cyclone Narelle triggered a powerful dust storm, turning the skies over parts of Western Australia a blood red.
- A tropical cyclone is formed only over warm ocean waters near the equator.
- Warm, moist air rises up and away from the ocean surface, creating an area of low pressure.
- It causes the air from surrounding areas with higher pressure to move towards the low-pressure area.
- This leads to warming up of air and causes it to rise above.



- As the air rises & cools, the water in the air forms clouds.
- This complete system of clouds and wind spins & grows, along with the ocean's heat.
- As the wind rotation speed increases, an eye gets formed in the middle.

Bhavasagara Referral Centre

- Recently, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) has officially designated the Center for Marine Living Resources & Ecology's "Bhavasagara" Referral Centre as a National Repository for Deep-Sea Fauna.
- It is designated as a National Repository for Deep-Sea Fauna.
- It was conferred under the provisions of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.
- It establishes the Centre as a critical national facility for the preservation, study, and documentation of India's vast deep-sea biological heritage.

Under the Biological Diversity Act, the Repository is authorized to:

- Preserve representative biological samples as voucher specimens along with critical associated data, such as DNA sequences, for future scientific reference.
- Act as the official custodian for any new deep-sea species discovered within Indian waters.
- Foster expertise in deep-sea taxonomy, aligning with the goals of the UN Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development (2021–2030).

The 15th meeting of the Conference of the Parties (COP 15)

- The 15th meeting of the Conference of the Parties (COP 15) to the Convention on Conservation of Migratory Species (CMS) of Wild Animals in Campo Grande, Brazil, is underway.
- It started on March 23 and end on March 29, 2026.
- The theme for this year is "Connecting Nature to sustain life."

Key takeaways:

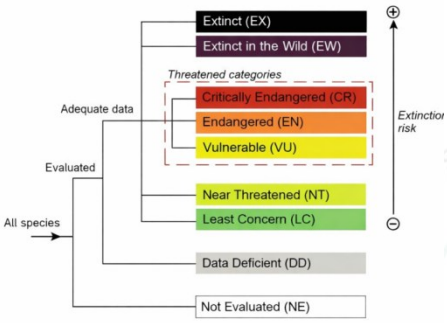
- The CMS is a legally binding global treaty, signed in 1979 under the United Nations Environment Programme, which aims to conserve migratory animals and their habitats across national habitats and across borders.
- As of today, 133 nations are parties to the Convention, engaging in international cooperation and coordinated action to conserve migratory species.
- According to the International Union for Conservation of Nature's (IUCN), a migratory species is defined as: 'the entire population or any geographically separate part of the population of any species or lower taxon of wild animals.
- Conference of the Parties is the principal decision-making body of the Convention, which meets once every three years and sets the budget and decides priorities for the following three years.

The CMS has two appendices.

- In the context of CMS, endangered refers to a species or regional population that has been assessed as Extinct in the Wild, Critically Endangered, or Endangered using the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species categories and criteria.
- If listed on Appendix-I, it would facilitate transboundary conservation efforts of these species.
- An Appendix II listing is for migratory species that have an unfavourable conservation status and which require international agreements for their conservation and management.

India and CMS COP

- India hosted the 13th CMS COP for the first time in 2020 and, with that, also formally assumed the role of CMS Presidency for the next three years.
- The theme of the COP13 was, "Migratory species connect the planet, and together we welcome them home!"
  Species in India, such as the Great Indian Bustard, the Asian Elephant, the Bengal Florican, the Siberian Crane, the Hawksbill Sea Turtle, the Olive Ridley turtle and the Leatherback Sea Turtle are included in Appendix I of CMS.



Interim Report on Migratory Species

- Ahead of the conference, CMS has published an interim report that highlights emerging trends and recent progress in identifying and protecting critical habitats and migratory pathways.
- The report provides an update to the first-ever comprehensive assessment of the state of the world's migratory species, published at CMS COP14 in Samarkand, Uzbekistan, in March 2024.
- The Report warned that 49 per cent of the migratory species population protected by the UN's Convention on the Conservation of Migratory Species of Wild Animals (CMS) are declining, and 24 per cent of species are now facing extinction.'
- The report noted that H5N1, the highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI), has been detected in an unusually broad host range of birds and mammals, and caused substantial mortality in many populations across multiple continents.

India marks 20th Earth Hour

- Earth Hour is a global movement encouraging individuals, communities, and businesses to turn off non-essential lights for one hour.
- It aims to raise awareness about climate change and biodiversity loss, while inspiring people to adopt sustainable lifestyles and take meaningful actions for environmental protection.
- Earth Hour began in 2007 in Sydney, initiated by the WWF (World Wide Fund for Nature)
- From 8:30 PM to 9:30 PM on March 28, 2026, iconic monuments, heritage sites, and government buildings across the nation turned off their lights in a powerful collective statement for climate action and sustainability.

Sahiwal Cattle

- Recently, the Indian Council of Agricultural Research– Indian Veterinary Research Institute, Izatnagar, Bareilly successfully produced indigenous Sahiwal cattle calves by using ultrasound- guided ovum pick-up, in vitro fertilization, and embryo transfer (OPU–IVF–ET).
- It is considered to be one of the best milch cattle breeds of India.
- The breed derives its name from Sahiwal area in Montgomery district of Punjab in Pakistan.
- Other Names: These animals are also known as "Lambi Bar", "Lola", "Montgomery", "Multani" and "Teli".
- The cows are brownish red in colour; shades may vary from a mahogany red brown to more greyish red.
- Extremities in bulls are darker than the rest of body colour. Occasionally there are white patches.
- Characteristics: Its unique traits are, tick-resistant, heat tolerant, high milk production and noted for its high resistance to parasites, both internal and external

What is Ovum Pick-Up-In Vitro Fertilization (OPU- IVF) Technology?

- Ovum Pick-Up (OPU) is one of the recent and remarkable technologies in the field of reproductive biotechnology.
- It allows the collection of oocytes from the ovaries of live animals of known pedigree and additionally decreases the interval between generations.
- This procedure can be performed on pregnant animals less than 100 days in gestation.
- In OPU, ovarian follicles are punctured in a live animal with the help of a needle attached to a vacuum pump after visualizing them through ultrasonography.
- The oocytes obtained are then subjected to in vitro maturation (IVM), in vitro fertilization (IVF) and culture (IVC) for embryo production.
- The embryos thus produced can then be transferred to suitably synchronized recipients for producing offspring of known pedigree

Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve

- Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister has laid the foundation for a new soft release Boma (enclosure) at the Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve (VDTR), marking the start of India's third home for cheetahs.
- It is a massive protected area formed by the notification of the erstwhile Nauradehi Wildlife Sanctuary and Durgavati Wildlife Sanctuary.
- It is unique for being a Land of Wolves and is now slated to become the first reserve in India where cheetahs will co- exist with a significant population of tigers and leopards.

- Located In: Bundelkhand region of Madhya Pradesh
- Established In: It was officially notified as a Tiger Reserve in September 2023, following the approval of the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA).

About Project Cheetah:

- Project Cheetah is the world's first intercontinental large wild carnivore translocation project, aimed at restoring the only large mammal species that went extinct in independent India.
- The project involves the phased introduction of African Cheetahs (Acinonyx jubatus jubatus) into Indian deciduous forests and grasslands.
- Launched In: The project was officially launched by Prime Minister of India on September 17, 2022.

Chokramudi Hills

- The Chokramudi hills in Kerala, previously a hub for illegal encroachment and construction, have been reclaimed by the government .
- This restoration has led to the return of the endangered Nilgiri tahr and the revival of the rare Neelakurinji
- Located In: Bison Valley Panchayat, near Munnar in the Idukki district of Kerala.

About Nilgiri Tahr: (Nilgiritragus hylocrius)

- The Nilgiri tahr is a sturdy, mountain goat-like ungulate.
- It is the State Animal of Tamil Nadu and is the only species of caprine (goat-antelope) found in tropical India.
- IUCN Status: Endangered (EN).

Neelakurinji

- 12-year blooming shrub, endemic to shola grasslands (Western Ghats)
- Nilgiri Hills = "Blue Mountains" (due to bloom)
- Paliyan tribes use it to calculate age

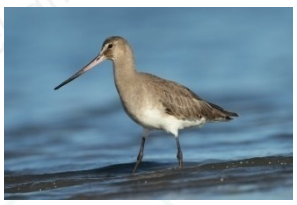
Great Indian Bustard chick born in Kutch, marks breakthrough in conservation efforts

- For the first time in a decade, Gujarat saw the birth of a Great Indian Bustard (GIB) chick— after a "trans-state conservation effort" that involved an "arduous 770-km road journey" across a "halt-free corridor" to transport a 15-day old fertile egg from Sam in Rajasthan's Jaisalmer district to Naliya in Gujarat's Kutch district.
- Habitat: Ground-dwelling bird of grasslands and semi- arid regions.
- Distribution: Endemic to Indian Subcontinent, mainly Rajasthan and Gujarat, with small populations in Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Andhra Pradesh.
- Characteristics: Feeds on grass seeds, insects like grasshoppers and beetles, and sometimes small rodents and reptiles.
- Threats: Habitat loss due to infrastructure development like electricity lines.

Protection Status:

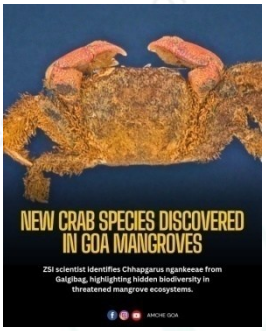
- IUCN: Critically Endangered
- Wildlife (Protection)Act, 1972: Schedule I
- CITES: Appendix I

Hudsonian Godwit



- The Hudsonian godwit population has plunged 95% in four decades due to a complex mix of environmental changes across multiple countries.
- It is a large shorebird in the sandpiper family, Scolopacidae.
- The Hudsonian godwit (Limosa haemastica) is one of the world's most remarkable travellers.
- Habitat: It breeds in wetland habitats (sedge meadows and muskeg) in sub-Arctic and Boreal regions.
- Distribution: It is mainly found in North America and South American countries.
- It can fly up to 11,000 km in one stretch without stopping to eat, drink or sleep.
- It travels every year from their breeding grounds in the Arctic to Patagonia where they spend the southern summer.
- IUCN Red List: Vulnerable.

Chhapgarus ngankeeae

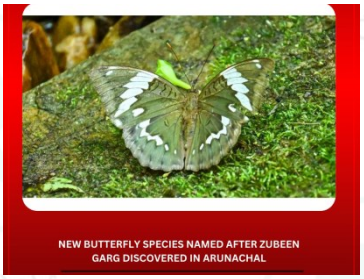


- Recently, researchers from the Zoological Survey of India discovered a new crab species from the Goan mangroves and named it as Chhapgarus ngankeeae.
- It is a new species of marine crab.
- The species has been named in honour of the late Dr Ngan Kee Ng, a noted marine biologist from the National University of Singapore.
- Habitat: It is found in the muddy intertidal mangrove forests along the west coast of India.
- It is a small crab measuring only about 1.6 centimetres across its squarish, brown, hairy shell.

The western part of Rajasthan has been recognised as a stronghold of the Steppe Eagle.

- It is a member of the subfamily Aquilinae, also known as the "booted eagles".
- Habitat: It is found in a number of habitats including steppe, desert, semi-desert, open savanna, pastures, agricultural fields, paddy fields, grassland, and open woodland.
- Distribution: It is mainly found in Europe, Asia, and Africa
- It is the only eagle to nest primarily on the ground.
- It mainly breeds in central Asian countries, including Kazakhstan, Russia, and Mongolia.
- Threats: The major threats to the Steppe eagle include habitat loss, persecution, wildfires, predation (and trampling by cattle) of chicks.
- IUCN Red List: Endangered

Euthalia Zubeengargi Butterfly Discovered in Arunachal Pradesh



- Recently, a new butterfly species was recorded in Arunachal Pradesh and named it as Euthalia zubeengargi, named after Zubeen Garg
- Habitat: It is found in semi-evergreen forests at elevations of 600-750 metres
- It belongs to the genus Euthalia, a group commonly found across South and Southeast Asia.
- It prefers cool, shaded forest interiors.

Keelback Snake

- Scientists from the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun documented the Rakhine Keelback (Herpetoreas davidi) in Ngengpui Wildlife Sanctuary, and the Kachin Hills Keelback (Hebius gilhodesi) in Namdapha National Park and Kamlang Tiger Reserve.
- Keelback snakes are typically non-venomous.
- Habitat: These are often found near water bodies such as streams and wetlands.
- Diet: Frogs, lizards and occasionally fish and tadpoles
- One of the most distinctive features of keelback snakes is their "keeled" scales.
- The keeled surface not only gives keelbacks a more rugged appearance but also helps with camouflage,

Prosopis Juliflora

- Recently, the Madras High Court issued a set of 34 directions for the eradication of the exotic and invasive species prosopis juliflora from Tamil Nadu.
- It is a shrub or small tree in the family Fabaceae, a kind of mesquite.
- It is native to Mexico, South America and the Caribbean.
- It is one of the most invasive species in arid and semi-arid areas.
- It was brought to Delhi by the British in the 1920s, when the national capital was being built.
- Other names: In India it is known locally by many names such as Bellary jaali, seemai karuvelam, seemai jaali, gando baval, vilayati kikar
- This tree absorbs more than four litres of water to obtain one kilogram of biomass.
- It cannot even shelter birds as it produces less oxygen and more carbon dioxide.
- It can also turn the groundwater poisonous.
- It causes land erosion due to the loss of the grasslands that are habitats for native plants and animals.

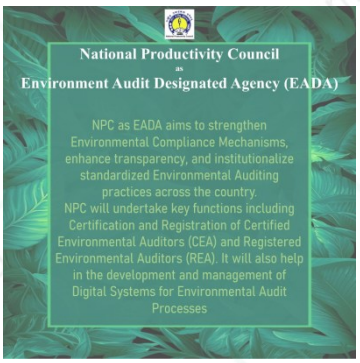
Hypercapnic Hypoxia in Mangroves

- A new study revealed that most mangrove sites are already experiencing mild or severe hypercapnic hypoxia.
- Hypercapnic Hypoxia is a high CO_2 and low oxygen state.
- It pushes estuaries into a stressful chemical state.
- It mostly occurs during low tide, at low-salinity sites and in warm tropical regions.
- Causes: Rising Co2 level due to climate change and Temperature

Increase

- Impact Hypercapnic Hypoxia on Biodiversity
- It threatens fish nurseries in mangrove ecosystems
- It reduces biodiversity and habitat quality for fish

National Productivity Council



- Recently, the National Productivity Council (NPC) has signed an agreement with the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF&CC) to function as the Environment Audit Designated Agency (EADA).
- It was established in 1958 as an autonomous organization.
- It works under the Department for Promotion of Industry & Internal Trade, Ministry of Commerce and Industry.
- It is a multipartite, non-profit organization with equal representation from employers' & workers' organizations and the Government, apart from technical & professional institutions and other interests.
- Headquarters: New Delhi
- It is a constituent of the Tokyo-based Asian Productivity Organisation (APO), an Inter- Governmental Body of which the Government of India is a founding member.
- NPC has professionals from diverse fields to provide Consultancy, Capacity Building, and Project Monitoring Unit (PMU) services to various organisations, including Central Government Ministries and State Governments.

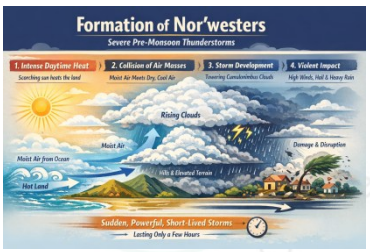
National Biodiversity Authority Launches 3-Month Internship Programme for Graduates and Postgraduates

- It is a statutory body established under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.
- It was formally set up in 2003.
- Headquarters: It is located in Chennai, Tamil Nadu.
- Functions: The NBA performs facilitative, regulatory, and advisory functions for the Government of India, particularly on matters related to the conservation of biodiversity, sustainable use of biological resources, and the fair and equitable sharing of benefits derived from them.

National Biodiversity Authority Composition

- Chairperson: An eminent person with proven knowledge and experience in biodiversity conservation, sustainable use of biological resources, and equitable sharing of benefits.
- 10 Ex-officio Members: Senior representatives from the Government of India, nominated to provide policy insights and ensure inter-ministerial coordination.
- 5 Non-Official Members: Experts and professionals from diverse fields related to biodiversity management, nominated to contribute independent perspectives and specialized expertise.

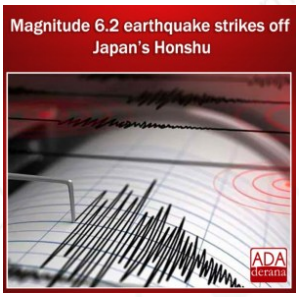
Nor'westers



- Nor'westers: They are extremely severe thunderstorms that occur in eastern and northeastern India and Bangladesh. They form during the pre-monsoon season (March–May).
- Nor'westers are locally called Kalbaisakhi in Bengal, meaning "the calamity of the month of Baisakh," and Bardoli Cheerha or Bordoisila in Assam.
- Since both are pre-monsoon local winds, there is a possibility of confusing them with each other. Here's the difference between the two:
- Loo → Hot, dry, dusty, no rainfall
- Nor'westers → Moist, stormy, with rainfall

- The movement of air from high pressure areas to low pressure areas is called wind. Winds can be broadly divided into three types.
- Permanent winds: These winds blow constantly throughout the year in a particular direction. The trade winds, westerlies and easterlies are the permanent winds.
- Seasonal winds: These winds change their direction in different seasons due to the shifting of regions of maximum heating, pressure and wind belts. The most pronounced effect of such a shift is noticed in the monsoons, especially over southeast Asia.
- Local winds: These winds blow only during a particular period of the day or year in a small area. Differences in the heating and cooling of earth surfaces and the cycles they develop daily or annually can create several common, local winds. Examples of these winds include the Loo in India and the Chinook in North America.

Honshu Island



- An earthquake measuring magnitude 6.2 struck off the east coast of Japan's largest island, Honshu, recently.
- Honshu, historically known as Akitsushima, is the largest of the four main islands of Japan.
- It lies between the Pacific Ocean (east) and the Sea of Japan (west).
- It is the second-most populous island in the world after the Indonesian island of Java.
- It contains the main cities of Japan, including the capital Tokyo, Osaka, Hiroshima, Nagoya, Kyoto, and Yokohama.
- It contains Japan's highest mountain, Mount Fuji (an active stratovolcano), and its largest lake, Lake Biwa.

Index

National Highways Green Cover Index

- The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) released the first National Highways Green Cover Index (NH-GCI).

National Highways Green Cover Index

- It is an initiative of National Highways Authority of India.
- It has been prepared in coordination with the National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC) of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).
- The initiative aims to provide a scientific and quantitative assessment of green cover within the Right of Way (RoW) along the National Highways network by leveraging advanced space-based technologies.

Methodology Used

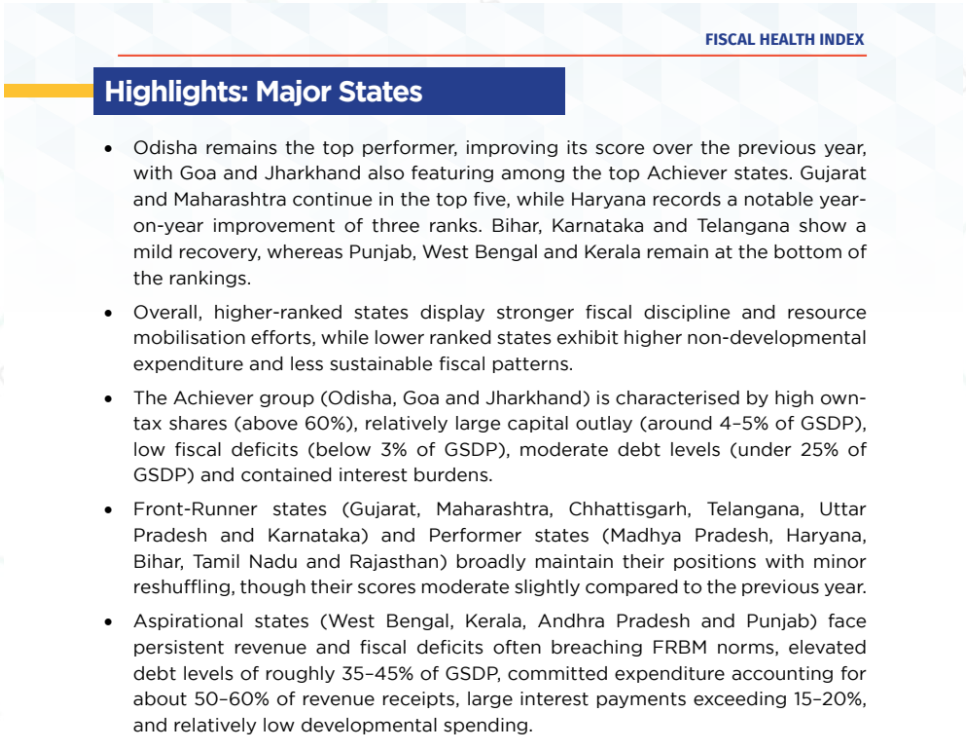
- The assessment is derived from chlorophyll content detected through high-resolution satellite sensors.
- It measures the percentage of land covered with vegetation along highway corridors, including plantations on the left and right sides of the road, as well as in the median wherever feasible.
- The analysis is conducted for every one-kilometre highway segment using the Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI) derived from satellite imagery.
- Coverage: Approximately 30,000 km of National Highways spanning 24 States have been covered for the period July– December 2024.

NITI Aayog Releases Fiscal Health Index 2026 for Indian States

- The NITI Aayog released the second annual edition of the “Fiscal Health Index 2026” in New Delhi.

Key Highlights of Fiscal Health Index (FHI) 2026

For 18 Large Indian States



FISCAL HEALTH INDEX

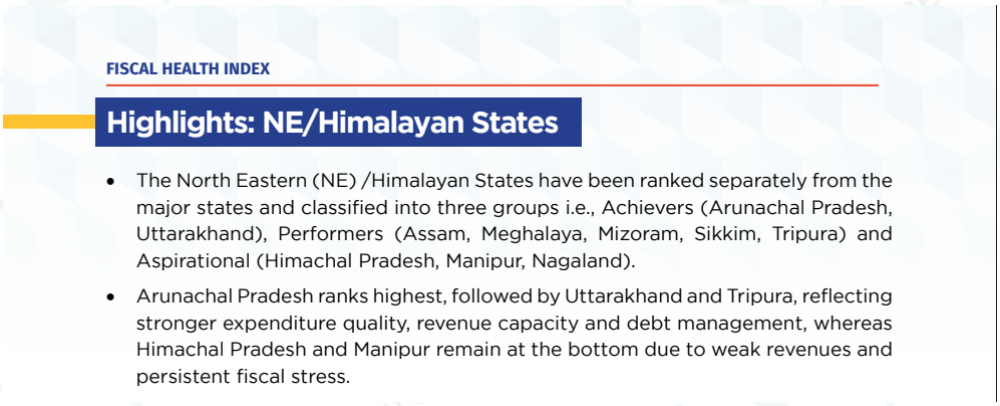
Highlights: Major States

- Odisha remains the top performer, improving its score over the previous year, with Goa and Jharkhand also featuring among the top Achiever states. Gujarat and Maharashtra continue in the top five, while Haryana records a notable year-on-year improvement of three ranks. Bihar, Karnataka and Telangana show a mild recovery, whereas Punjab, West Bengal and Kerala remain at the bottom of the rankings.
- Overall, higher-ranked states display stronger fiscal discipline and resource mobilisation efforts, while lower ranked states exhibit higher non-developmental expenditure and less sustainable fiscal patterns.
- The Achiever group (Odisha, Goa and Jharkhand) is characterised by high own-tax shares (above 60%), relatively large capital outlay (around 4–5% of GSDP), low fiscal deficits (below 3% of GSDP), moderate debt levels (under 25% of GSDP) and contained interest burdens.
- Front-Runner states (Gujarat, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh and Karnataka) and Performer states (Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, Bihar, Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan) broadly maintain their positions with minor reshuffling, though their scores moderate slightly compared to the previous year.
- Aspirational states (West Bengal, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Punjab) face persistent revenue and fiscal deficits often breaching FRBM norms, elevated debt levels of roughly 35–45% of GSDP, committed expenditure accounting for about 50–60% of revenue receipts, large interest payments exceeding 15–20%, and relatively low developmental spending.

- Achiever: Odisha (1); Goa (2); Jharkhand (3)
- Front Runner: Gujarat, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka
- Performer: Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, Bihar, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan
- Aspirational: Kerala, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh, Punjab.

For North-Eastern & Himalayan States

- Achiever States: Arunachal Pradesh (First); Uttarakhand (Second)
- Performer States: Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Sikkim, Tripura
- Aspirational States: Himachal Pradesh, Manipur, Nagaland



About Fiscal Health Index

- It was introduced by NITI Aayog, provides a systematic framework to evaluate the fiscal performance of 18 major Indian states, 10 North-Eastern and Himalayan states.
- It provides a comprehensive and comparable assessment of the fiscal performance of Indian states.
- It is built on five key pillars of fiscal health: Quality of Expenditure, Revenue Mobilisation, Fiscal Prudence, Debt Index, and Debt Sustainability.

The index classifies states into four tiers.

- Achievers: These are states with strong fiscal discipline, high own-tax revenues, low deficits, and manageable debt;
- Front Runners: These states maintain broadly sound finances but fall short of the top tier on one or more indicators;
- Performers: They occupy the middle ground, with mixed results across the five pillars.
- Aspirational: These states are those facing the most significant fiscal stress, characterised by persistent deficits, high debt, and limited revenue capacity.

World Obesity Atlas 2026

- On World Obesity Day (4th March), the World Obesity Federation released the second edition of the World Obesity Atlas 2026.
- According to the Atlas, India now ranks second globally for children who are overweight and living with obesity after China, beating the US and other Western nations.
- India could have 41 million children with high body mass index (BMI) and 14 million living with obesity.

Key takeaways:

- The Atlas presents a series of childhood obesity prevalence projections for the period 2025 to 2040.
- Estimates suggest that in this period, 20 million children in India will be living with obesity and 56 million will be either overweight or living with obesity.
- In the same period, children aged 5-19 years are projected to develop risk factors associated with high BMI.
- Worldwide, the atlas found that more than one in five (20.7 per cent) in the 5-19 age group are living with obesity or are overweight, an increase of 14.6 per cent since 2010.

Countries	Number of children 5-19 years living with obesity (millions)
China	33m
India	14m
United States of America	13m
Indonesia	8m
Pakistan	8m

Index/rankings/reports

QS World University Rankings by Subject 2026

- The Indian Institute of Management-Kozhikode (IIM-K) has achieved a global milestone by breaking into the Top 100 of the prestigious QS World University Rankings by Subject 2026 for the first time.
- It is published annually by global higher education consultancy Quacquarelli Symonds.

Key Highlights of QS World University Rankings

- India recorded 120 new entries this year, placing it fourth globally for fresh appearances, behind only the US (287), China (181), and the UK (159).
- Six Indian institutions now feature in the global top 100 for computer science, all improving from last year.
- The Indian Institute of Technology (ISM) Dhanbad and the Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad, both securing the country's highest global rank of 21.
- IIT Delhi delivered the edition's most complete single- institution performance, recording six top-50 entries.
- The institute leads India in four subjects: Chemical Engineering (48th, its first top-50 appearance), Electrical and Electronic Engineering (36th), Mechanical, Aeronautical and Manufacturing Engineering (44th, best in over a decade), and the Engineering and Technology broad area (36th).

Arts and Humanities

Rank	Institution	Country	Movement
1	University of Oxford	UK	+1
2	Harvard University	US	-1
3	University of Cambridge	UK	=

Engineering and Technology

Rank	Institution	Country	Movement
1	Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)	US	=
2	Stanford University	US	-1
3	ETH Zurich	Switzerland	+2

Life Sciences and Medicine

Rank	Institution	Country	Movement
1	Harvard University	US	=
2	University of Oxford	UK	=
3	Johns Hopkins University	US	=

Natural Sciences

Rank	Institution	Country	Movement
1	Harvard University	US	=
2	Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)	US	=
3	University of Oxford	UK	=

Social Sciences and Management

Rank	Institution	Country	Movement
1	Harvard University	US	=
2	University of Oxford	UK	=
3	Stanford University	US	=

World Happiness Report 2026

TH

Finland leads happiness report for ninth time

How has India fared over the past five years?

Year	Rank	Score
2026	116	4.536
2025	118	4.389
2024	126	4.054
2023	126	4.036
2022	136	3.777

What are the six factors used to evaluate happiness rankings?

GDP per capita
Life expectancy
Social support
Freedom to make life choices
Generosity
Perceptions of corruptions

World Happiness Report 2026: Finland happiest country for ninth time, India ranks 116th

- World Happiness Report 2026 - by the Wellbeing Research Centre at the University of Oxford, in partnership with Gallup, the UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network
- Finland remains the happiest country in the world in 2026, holding the top spot for the ninth consecutive year.
- Among the 147 countries featured in the report, India ranks 116th
- The United States is at 23rd place, Canada is at 25th and Britain at 29th.
- The Nordic countries, Iceland (2nd), Denmark (3rd), Sweden (5th), and Norway (6th), also rank among the top 10 happiest countries in 2026.

Six factors for evaluation of happiness ranking

- GDP per capita
- Life expectancy
- Social support
- Freedom to make life choices
- Generosity
- Perceptions of corruption

Top 5 countries in the World Happiness Report 2026

- Finland
- Iceland
- Denmark
- Costa Rica
- Sweden

Top 5 unhappiest countries include (rankings from 138 to 147):

- Afghanistan
- Malawi
- Botswana
- Lebanon
- Egypt

Global Terrorism Index

- Recently, the Global Terrorism Index, 2026 was published by the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP).
- It is published by the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP), a Sydney-based independent, non-profit think tank.
- It is a comprehensive study analysing the impact of terrorism for 163 countries covering 99.7 per cent of the world's population.

Methodology

- The GTI scores each country on a scale from 0 to 10; where 0 represents no impact from terrorism and 10 represents the highest measurable impact of terrorism.
- This produces a composite score so as to provide an ordinal ranking of countries on the impact of terrorism.

Key Highlights of Global Terrorism Index 2026

- Deaths from terrorism fell by 28 per cent and incidents decreased by 22 per cent
- Six of the ten countries most impacted by terrorism are in sub- Saharan Africa, maintaining its position as the epicenter.
- For the first time, Pakistan leads the Index as the country most impacted by terrorism.
- India is placed 13th on the list.
- Deadliest terror outfits (2025): IS, Jamaat Nusrat Al-Islam wal Muslimeen (JNIM), Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), and alShabaab.

PM Modi Becomes Longest-Serving Elected Head of Government in India

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi became the longest-serving head of an elected government in India ,surpassing former Sikkim Chief Minister Pawan Kumar Chamling.
- PM Modi completed 8,931 days in office being the head of the government, combining his days as the Chief Minister of Gujarat and then becoming the Prime Minister.
- Assuming the office as the Chief Minister of Gujarat on October 7, 2001, he remained in his post until May 21, 2014, serving for more than ten years. He was later sworn in as the Prime Minister on May 26, 2014.

Forbes World's Billionaires List 2026

- India now ranks third globally behind China and the United States in the Forbes World's Billionaires List 2026
- Indian educator and Edtech entrepreneur Alakh Pandey has made it to the Forbes World's Billionaaire's List 2026.
- Alakh is among the 229 billionaires that India produced this year
- Alakh Pandey and Prateek Boob co-founded the edtech firm Physicswallah in 2020,
- Among the 229 Indian citizens on the Forbes' World's Billionaires list, richest and second richest Indians are business tycoons Mukesh Ambani and Gautam Adani.

India 6th most polluted country in the world: World Air Quality Report

- World Air Quality Report, a yearly global compilation of air quality by IQAir, a Swiss company.
- In the 2025 report, India stands at 6th, now also behind Tajikistan.
- New Delhi remains the top most-polluted capital city in the world.
- Loni, in Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad district was the most polluted region in India in 2025
- Pakistan grabbed the top spot for the most polluted country
- Following right behind Pakistan were Bangladesh and Tajikistan, ranking second and third in the list, respectively.
- Globally, only thirteen countries/territories met the WHO annual average PM2.5 guideline: French Polynesia, Puerto Rico, U.S. Virgin Islands, Barbados, New Caledonia, Iceland, Bermuda, Réunion, Andorra, Australia, Grenada, Panama and Estonia.

The Global Climate report 2025c

- The State of the Global Climate report 2025 released on World Meteorological Day , is based on scientific contributions from National Meteorological and Hydrological Services, WMO Regional Climate Centres, United Nations partners and dozens of experts.
- According to the report, every key climate indicator is raising alarms and the years from 2015 to 2025 have been the hottest 11 years.
- It also mentioned that 2025 was the second or third hottest year on record, at about 1.43 °C above the 1850-1900 average.
- The 2025 report for the first time included the earth's energy imbalance as one of the key climate indicators.
- However, rising concentrations of atmospheric greenhouse gases — carbon dioxide, methane and nitrous oxide — to their maximum level
- Annual sea ice extent in the Arctic was at or near a record low, Antarctic sea ice extent was the third lowest on record, and glacier melt continued
- one-third of the global workforce (1.2 billion people) face workplace heat risk at some point each year, especially those in agriculture and construction

The India Justice Report's (IJR), the 'Consumer Justice Report 2026

- The India Justice Report (IJR) released its Consumer Justice Report 2026 in March 2026, the first comprehensive, data- driven assessment of India's three-tiered consumer dispute redressal system covering District, State, and National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commissions under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019.
- The Consumer Justice Report 2026 is published by the India Justice Report (IJR), a collaboration of DAKSH, Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative, Common Cause, Centre for Social Justice, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, and TISS-Prayas.
- It assessed 11 indicators across five themes – Human Resources, Gender Diversity, Workload, Infrastructure, and Budgets, scoring each on a scale of 1-10 using the geometric mean to reduce distortion from outliers.

State-wise Performance

- Among large states, Andhra Pradesh recorded the highest case disposal, with only 4.8% of cases pending beyond three years.
- In contrast, Telangana ranked lowest among large states despite a high disposal rate, due to gaps in leadership and insufficient coverage.
- Meghalaya emerged as the top-performing small state, while Tamil Nadu achieved the highest clearance rate of 114.6%.
- Budget allocations: Jharkhand reduced its budget by 47% despite rising caseloads.
- Uttarakhand overutilised its budget by 512% due to under- allocation.
- Karnataka received the highest allocation (₹53.71 crore) and Bihar the lowest (₹3.18 crore), showing misalignment with caseload.

Gender Representation:

- The Consumer Protection (Appointment) Rules, 2020 mandate a minimum of one woman in every commission.
- Women's share in SCDRC presidents and members declined from 35% (2021) to 29% (2025), touching a five-year low of 23.2% in 2024.
- Jharkhand maintained an all-male SCDRC staff throughout the period.
- Women constitute just 26% of total SCDRC staff.

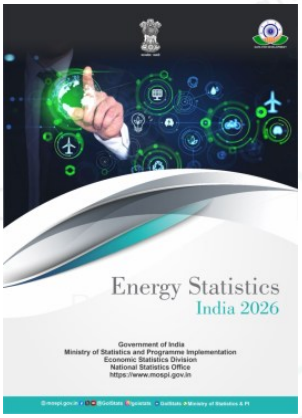
Delayed Disposal:

- Section 38(7) of CPA 2019 mandates disposal within 3 to 5 months of notice. In reality, 35% of all pending SCDRC cases have remained unresolved for more than three years.
- Among the states, the highest proportion of cases pending for over three years was observed in Kerala at 79.2%, followed by Jharkhand and Jammu & Kashmir at 70.8% each, and Uttar Pradesh at 61.8%.

Institutional Vacancies:

- About half of the State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commissions (SCDRCs) and one-third of district commissions were functioning without a president.
- Nearly 40% of sanctioned member posts were vacant.
- In several States, including Tamil Nadu, Arunachal Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh, SCDRCs had no members at all

Energy Statistics India 2026



- The National Statistics Office (NSO) has released the 33rd edition of its annual publication, Energy Statistics India 2026.
- Energy Statistics India 2026 is the annual publication of the National Statistics Office (NSO), under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
- It serves as a centralized repository of diverse information regarding the reserve, capacity, production, consumption, and trade of all energy commodities, including fossil fuels and renewables.

Key Highlights of the Report:

- Primary Energy Supply: The Total Primary Energy Supply (TPES) stood at 9,32,816 KTOE in FY 2024-25, marking a growth of 2.95% over the previous year.
- Renewable Energy Potential: India's total RE potential reached 47,04,043 MW as of March 2025, with Solar Energy holding the highest share at approximately 71%.
- State-wise Concentration: Over 70% of RE potential is concentrated in six states: Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Madhya Pradesh.
- Capacity & Generation: Installed RE capacity grew at a CAGR of 10.93% (2016–2025), while gross electricity generation from renewables reached 4,16,823 GWh in FY 2024-25.
- Consumption Trends: Per-capita energy consumption rose from 15,296 MJ in 2015-16 to 18,096 MJ in 2024-25.
- Efficiency Gains: Transmission and Distribution (T&D) losses were reduced from 22% in FY 2015-16 to 17% in FY 2024-25.
- Fossil Fuel Dominance: Coal remains the primary energy source, with its supply increasing to 5,52,315 KTOE in FY 2024-25.

International

US, Israel launch Operation Epic Fury against Iran

- 'Operation Epic Fury' targeted key government and military establishments, including the office of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and the Iranian President.
- A coordinated missile strike on Iran, with massive explosions across Tehran and multiple other cities
- The Islamic Republic launched counterattacks on Washington's regional allies – UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, and Qatar – all of which house US military bases.

'Operation Lion's Roar vs Epic Fury': Why US-Israel are running two different missions to strike Iran?

- The primary reason for two separate operations is that Washington and Tel Aviv have different definitions of "victory."
- Israel's Objective ('Lion's Roar'): Israel views a nuclear-armed Iran as an imminent, existential threat.
- Operation Shield of Judah: The original biblical name given to the operation before Prime Minister Netanyahu reportedly renamed it to signify a more offensive stance. Later, Prime Minister renamed the operation "Roar of the Lion,"
- The US Objective ('Epic Fury'): The United States has a much broader regional agenda. Beyond neutralizing the nuclear threat, Washington is focused on re-establishing global deterrence, crippling the IRGC's ability to fund proxy militias, protecting the flow of oil through the Strait of Hormuz

Strait of Hormuz is shut:

- It is a narrow waterway between Iran and the Arabian Peninsula, specifically the United Arab Emirates, and Musandam (Oman).
- The Gulf of Oman is on the strait's east, while the Persian Gulf is on the west.
- It is the only sea channel linking the oil-rich Persian Gulf (west) with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea (southeast).
- Iran is located on the north coast, while the UAE is on the south coast.
- At its narrowest point, the Strait of Hormuz is only 29 nautical miles wide (54 km)

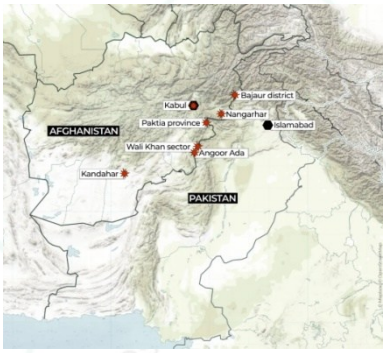
Significance

- The Strait of Hormuz is considered one of the world's most economically important choke points.
- About 30% of the world's liquefied gas and 25% of oil pass through the Strait of Hormuz.
- It serves as a key passage for supertankers transporting oil and gas from Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Iraq, Qatar, Bahrain, the UAE, and Iran.
- Most of this energy flows to Asian markets, including China, which remains Iran's sole significant oil customer.

Iran

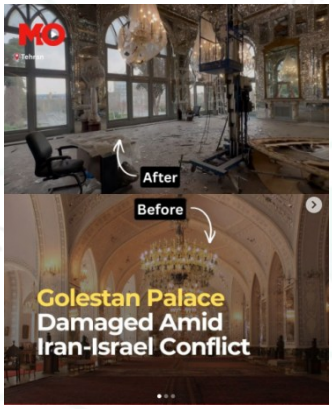
- Location: It is a prominent country located in West Asia.
- Bordering Countries: It shares land boundaries with Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Turkmenistan to the north, Afghanistan and Pakistan to the east, Iraq to the west, and Turkey to the northwest.
- Maritime Boundaries: It is bordered by major water bodies, namely the Caspian Sea to the north, and the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman to the south.
- Capital City: Tehran
- It is a member country of SCO, OPEC and BRICS.

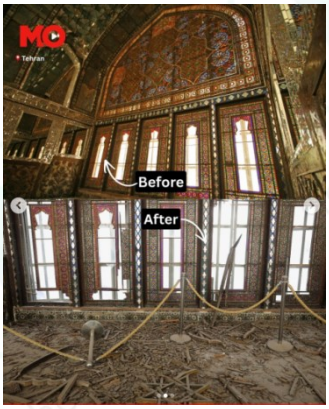
Pakistan Declares Open War After Kabul Airstrikes



- Tensions between Pakistan and Afghanistan have escalated into an open war following Pakistan's launch of Operation Ghazab lil-Haq in response to alleged unprovoked border aggression.
- The current conflict is a sharp military escalation between the Pakistan Armed Forces and the Afghan Taliban Region of Tension:
- The Durand Line: The 2,640 km porous border between the two nations, which Afghanistan has historically refused to recognize as an international boundary.
- The Torkham border crossing (East Afghanistan), Kandahar (Taliban stronghold), and the Paktia province.
- Pakistan accuses the Afghan Taliban of providing safe havens and training to the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP)which carries out attacks on Pakistani soil.

Golestan Palace





- The Golestan Palace, a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Tehran, reportedly suffered damage due to shockwaves and debris from nearby airstrikes amid escalating US–Israel–Iran tensions in 2026.
- Golestan Palace is a historic royal complex that served as the official residence of the Qajar dynasty
- Status: UNESCO World Heritage Site (inscribed in 2013)
- The complex gained prominence when the Qajar dynasty (1794– 1925) made Tehran the capital and adopted Golestan Palace as the royal residence.
- Combines traditional Persian architectural design with European decorative elements, reflecting Iran's interaction with the West in the 19th century.

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)

- An Iranian warship IRIS Dena was sunk by a US submarine off the coast of Sri Lanka while returning from the International Fleet Review 2026 at Visakhapatnam.
- UNCLOS is the comprehensive international treaty that establishes the legal framework governing the use of the world's oceans and seas.
- It is often called the Constitution of the Oceans because it defines rights and responsibilities of states in maritime zones

Came into force:

- Adopted in 1982 at Montego Bay, Jamaica.
- Entered into force in 1994 after sufficient ratifications.

Members:

- 168 parties including the European Union.
- Major maritime powers like India are parties, while the United States has signed but not ratified the convention.
- Establishes legal zones such as Territorial Sea, Contiguous Zone, Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), and High Seas.
- Guarantees freedom of navigation and innocent passage for ships through territorial waters.
- Regulates exploration and exploitation of marine resources such as fisheries, oil, and minerals.
- Establishes mechanisms like the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea (ITLOS) for resolving maritime disputes.
- Creates the International Seabed Authority (ISA) to regulate mineral resources in areas beyond national jurisdiction.

The Kurds

- The Kurds have returned to the global spotlight following reports that the CIA is considering engaging Kurdish armed groups to pressure the Iranian regime.
- This comes as a new Coalition of Political Forces of Iranian Kurdistan was formed in February 2026.
- The Kurds are an Indo-European ethnic group indigenous to the Mesopotamian plains and the highlands of West Asia.
- Widely recognized as the world's largest stateless ethnic group.
- They speak Kurdish, which belongs to the Northwestern Iranian branch of Indo-European languages.
- The majority are Sunni Muslims, but the community is religiously diverse, including Shia Muslims, Christians, Alevis, and Yazidis.
- The Kurds trace their ancestry back thousands of years to the ancient tribes of the Zagros Mountains.
- Post-WWI Betrayal: Their modern stateless status stems from the aftermath of World War I.
- The traditional Kurdish homeland, Kurdistan, is spread across four main countries of West Asia: Turkey, Iran, Iraq, and Syria.

The Gulf Nations

- The Gulf nations are at the center of a major regional crisis following a joint U.S.-Israeli military operation on February 28 that escalated into a full-scale war with Iran.
- Gulf nations primarily refers to the six sovereign states that form the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).
- Established in 1981, this political and economic union was created to foster regional integration and collective security among the Arab states bordering the Persian Gulf.

Member States:

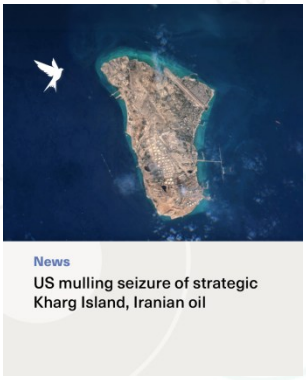
The GCC consists of six monarchies:

- United Arab Emirates (UAE)
- Kingdom of Bahrain
- Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
- Sultanate of Oman
- State of Qatar
- State of Kuwait

Key Geographical and Geological Features:

- The Arabian Shield: A vast Precambrian complex of igneous and metamorphic rocks in the west, which provides a stable foundation for the sedimentary layers in the east where oil is found.
- Rub' al Khali (The Empty Quarter): The largest continuous sand desert in the world, covering much of southern Saudi Arabia and parts of Oman and the UAE.

Kharg Island



- The United States is considering seizing Iran's Kharg Island to choke off the regime's oil revenues, a US official has suggested.
- It is a small coral island in Iran in the northern Persian Gulf.
- It lies about 30 Km from the Iranian mainland.
- This rocky limestone island is unique because it is one of the few islands in the Persian Gulf with freshwater, which has collected within the porous limestone.
- The discovery of an offshore oil field in the waters around Kharg in the early 1960s stimulated the development of the island as a site for major petroleum and petrochemical installations.
- Connection by pipelines to the underwater oil fields.
- It facilitates as much as 90 percent of the country's oil exports and is vital for Iran's economy.
- Its strategic significance lies in its proximity to the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial global oil passage

'Shenlong' Crude Tanker

- The Liberia-flagged crude oil tanker 'Shenlong' carrying Saudi crude oil reached Mumbai Port after transiting the Strait of Hormuz amid escalating tensions in the Middle East.
- Shenlong is a Suezmax-class crude oil tanker transporting crude oil from Ras Tanura Oil Terminal to India.
- It is Liberia-flagged, meaning the ship is registered under the maritime registry of Liberia, a common practice known as flag of convenience.
- Suezmax Category: Designed to carry around 1 million barrels of crude oil and sized to pass through the Suez Canal.
- Large capacity tanker: Typically 120,000– 200,000 deadweight tonnes (DWT).
- Global energy transport role: Used for long- distance transport of crude oil between major oil-exporting and importing regions.
- Strategic maritime route usage: Transited through the Strait of Hormuz, a vital global oil transit chokepoint.

Port of Fujairah

- Recent missile/drone attacks on Fujairah port and the Shah gas field in the UAE have disrupted oil loading and gas operations.
- A major deep-water, multipurpose port and global oil storage/bunkering hub serving as a critical export outlet for UAE's hydrocarbons.
- Located in: Fujairah Emirate, United Arab Emirates (UAE) on the eastern coast.
- Sea Open to: Directly opens into the Gulf of Oman / Arabian Sea, bypassing the Strait of Hormuz.

Qeshm Island

- Iran's Foreign Minister recently accused the United States of attacking a desalination plant on Qeshm Island, saying it had set a precedent.
- Qeshm Island is the largest island in the Persian Gulf near the Straits of Hormoz.
- It belongs to Iran.
- The Arabic name means "long island."
- It lies parallel to the Iranian coast, from which it is separated by the Clarence Strait.
- It lies close to the mainland cities of Bandar Abbas and Hormozgan Province.
- It covers an area of 1491 sq.km., which is 2.5 times the second largest island in the Persian Gulf, Bahrain.
- It has a hot and arid climate, typical of the Persian Gulf region.

Upemba National Park

- The International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) and its World Commission on Protected Areas (WCPA) condemned an armed attack on Upemba National Park headquarters in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC).
- Upemba National Park is one of Africa's oldest national parks and an important biodiversity hotspot in the Congo Basin ecosystem.
- It was established by royal decree in May 1939 and plays a key role in protecting wildlife and freshwater ecosystems in Central Africa.
- Located in: Southeastern Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC).
- Neighbouring Protected Areas: The park lies close to Kundelungu National Park, with the Lubudi–Sampwe hunting reserve acting as an ecological corridor between them.

Force Majeure

- Major Gulf energy producers like Qatar, Kuwait, and Bahrain have invoked force majeure on oil and gas exports due to shipping disruptions and infrastructure attacks linked to the 2026 Iran vs. US- Israel conflict.
- Force majeure is a legal clause included in contracts that allows a party to suspend or terminate its obligations without penalty when an extraordinary, unforeseeable event makes fulfillment impossible.
- It essentially pauses the contract because the circumstances are beyond the control of the parties involved.
- The term is French, literally translating to superior force. It is rooted in civil law but is now a standard feature in international commercial contracts and maritime law worldwide.
- Aim: The primary goal is to provide legal protection to businesses or governments.
- It ensures they aren't sued for breach of contract or forced to pay massive late fees when Acts of God (like earthquakes) or Acts of Man (like war) prevent them from delivering goods or services.

Malawi

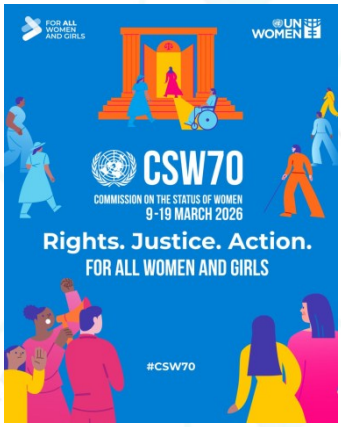
- Recently, India has dispatched a consignment of one thousand metric tonnes of rice to Malawi to support Malawi's efforts towards food security following the drought caused by the El Niño effect.

About Malawi

- It is a landlocked nation in southeastern Africa.
- Bordering Countries: It is bordered by three countries namely Mozambique on the east, south, and southwest. Tanzania to the north and northeast and Zambia is located to the west.

- Capital City: Lilongwe
- It occupies a narrow, curving strip of land along the East African Rift Valley.
- Major Lakes: Lake Nyasa, known in Malawi as Lake Malawi, accounts for more than one-fifth of the country's total area.
- Major Rivers: Shire, Rukuru, Dwangwa, Lilongwe, Bua etc.
- Highest Peak: Sapitwa Peak in Mt. Mulanje near the Mozambique border.
- Waterfalls: Likhubula Falls is a stunning waterfall located in Malawi.

Commission on the Status of Women



- The Minister of State for Women and Child Development to participate in the 70th Session of the Commission on the Status of Women (CSW-70) at the United Nations Headquarters. Commission on the Status of Women
- It is a functional commission of the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC).
- It was established by ECOSOC resolution of 21 June 1946.
- It is the principal global intergovernmental body dedicated to the promotion of gender equality and the empowerment of women.
- It is part of the United Nations, and works to promote women's political, economic, civil, social, and educational rights.
- In 1996, ECOSOC expanded the Commission's mandate
- Member States: Forty-five Member States of the United Nations serve as members of the Commission at any one time.
- Members are elected for a period of four years.

Chile Eliminate Leprosy

- The World Health Organization (WHO) and the Pan American Health Organization (PAHO) officially verified Chile as the first country in the Americas— and the second globally—to have eliminated leprosy.
- Leprosy is a chronic infectious disease caused by the slow-growing bacterium Mycobacterium leprae.
- It primarily affects the skin, the peripheral nerves, mucosal surfaces of the upper respiratory tract, and the eyes.
- If left untreated, it can cause progressive and permanent damage to the skin, nerves, limbs, and eyes.
- Leprosy is one of the oldest recorded diseases in human history, mentioned in ancient civilizations' texts from China, Egypt, and India.
- Chilean Context: It was historically recorded in Chile at the end of the 19th century, specifically on Rapa Nui (Easter Island). It remained localized there through strict isolation and treatment until the late 1990s.

Key Features

- Transmission: It is transmitted via droplets from the nose and mouth during close and frequent contact with untreated cases. It is not highly infectious.
- Incubation Period: The disease has a very long incubation period, averaging 5 years, though symptoms can take up to 20 years to appear.
- Symptoms: Pale or reddish skin patches with loss of sensation, painless ulcers on the soles of feet, and muscle weakness or tingling in the hands and feet.

Treatment

- Multi-Drug Therapy (MDT): Since the 1980s, WHO has provided MDT (a combination of rifampicin, dapsone, and clofazimine) for free globally.
- Curability: Leprosy is 100% curable. Early treatment prevents most disabilities associated with the disease.
- Stigma: Historically, patients were shunned or leper colonies were created. Modern public health focuses on stigma-free, integrated care.

India and Indonesia have partnered for the restoration of the Prambanan Temple complex

- It is the largest Hindu temple complex in Indonesia, located in Sleman, Yogyakarta, Southern Java.
- It is known locally as the Temple of the Slender Virgin (Roro Jonggrang).
- It was built in the 9th century by the Sanjaya dynasty, a Hindu kingdom that ruled over central Java.
- It is dedicated to the Hindu Trimurti, the three main gods of Hinduism: Shiva, Vishnu, and Brahma.
- In 1991, UNESCO designated Prambanan Temple as a World Heritage Site.
- The architectural style of Prambanan reflects the influence of both indigenous Javanese traditions and elements borrowed from South India, specifically the Pallava style.

Oxford Museum Returning 16th-Century Tirumankai Alvar Bronze to India

- The Ashmolean Museum (Oxford) is set to return a 16th-century bronze idol of Saint Tirumankai Alvar, after research indicated it was photographed in 1957 at the Soundarrajaperumal temple, Thadikombu (Tamil Nadu) and later replaced by a replica.
- Bronze art refers to sculptural and ritual objects made from copper-based alloys (bronze/brass; in South India often panchaloha tradition), used for worship icons, processional deities, lamps, utensils, and decorative forms.

Technique:

- Lost-wax casting (Cire perdue / Madhuchista Vidhan) is the core technique:
- Wax model: The figure is first sculpted in wax with all details.
- Clay mould: Wax model is coated with layers of fine clay to make a mould.
- Dewaxing: The mould is heated so wax melts out, leaving a cavity.
- Metal pouring: Molten metal/alloy is poured into the cavity.
- Finishing: Mould is broken, the casting is filed, polished, detailed, and ritually consecrated (for deity icons, often via opening of the eyes).

Important bronze artefacts in Indian history:

- Dancing Girl (Mohenjodaro, c. 2500 BCE): earliest iconic evidence of sophisticated metal casting in the Indus Valley.
- Daimabad bronzes (c. 1500 BCE): notable large bronzes showing advanced casting and likely ritual/ceremonial usage.
- Chola bronzes (c. 9th–13th century CE): the classical peak—especially Nataraja and other temple/processional icons with fluid movement and refined anatomy.

Sulawesi Hand Stencil Becomes Oldest Known Rock Art

- A hand stencil discovered in a limestone cave in Indonesia has been dated to at least 67,800 years ago, making it the oldest known example of rock art identified so far.
- Type: Red hand stencil
- The artwork was found in Liang Metanduno cave on Muna Island, off the coast of Sulawesi..

Villages of Excellence Initiative

- Prime Minister of India announced the Villages of Excellence initiative during his state visit to Israel in February 2026 to scale up agricultural cooperation.
- The Villages of Excellence is a grassroots-level extension of the Indo-Israel Agriculture Project (IIAP).
- While previous cooperation focused on centralized high- tech hubs, this initiative aims to transform entire farming clusters into modern, technology-driven agricultural zones by integrating Israeli expertise directly into local village ecosystems.
- Nations Involved: India and Israel

Key Features:

- A target has been set to increase the number of Centres of Excellence (CoEs) across India to 100.
- Developing villages located around existing CoEs to act as models for surrounding regions.
- Implementation of precision farming, satellite-based irrigation, advanced nursery management, and integrated pest management.
- Supported by the newly established India-Israel Innovation Centre for Agriculture (IINCA), which provides the research base for these villages.

Amondawa Tribe Lives Without Concept of Time

- The Amondawa tribe in Brazil's Amazon lives without clocks, calendars, or numerical age, organising life by natural cycles and identity changes, as revealed by researchers.
- They are an indigenous community living deep inside Brazil's Amazon rainforest.
- They were first contacted by the outside world in 1986.
- They are about 150 strong, continuing their traditional way of life, hunting, fishing, and farming.
- They live without any concept of time as understood by modern civilisation.
- They have no linguistic or cultural equivalent for words such as "time", "week", "month" or "year".
- One of the most striking aspects of Amondawa society is the absence of numerical age.
- Members of the tribe do not track birthdays or calculate how old they are.
- Instead, personal growth is marked through identity changes.
- As children mature, they receive new names, and a person may change names several times over the course of a lifetime.

Scotland Becomes First Nation To Approve Water Cremation in UK

- Scotland has become the first country in the UK where water cremations are now legal.
- The process - called alkaline hydrolysis - will offer families a third option instead of burial or traditional cremation.
- Bodies are wrapped in a shroud of biodegradable material such as silk or wool before being placed in a pressurised chamber with hot water and chemicals, speeding up decomposition.
- Water cremations already happen in countries including the Republic of Ireland and the United States.
- They are considered to be "green cremations".
- The process involves weighing the body, then heating it to 150C (300F) in a mixture of potassium hydroxide and water for up to 90 minutes.
- This dissolves the body tissue, leaving only the bones - which are then rinsed at 120C, dried, and pulverised into a coarse powder using a machine called a cremulator.
- Remains can be returned to next of kin, as ashes are following cremation

WTO's 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14)

- India has officially submitted a robust set of proposals for the WTO' s 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14), focusing on a permanent solution for food security and protecting the livelihoods of traditional fishermen.

Host for MC14:

- Location: Yaoundé, Cameroon.
- Dates: 26 to 29 March 2026.
- Chair: Luc Magloire Mbarga Atangana, Cameroon's Minister of Trade.
- The Ministerial Conference is the highest decision-making body of the World Trade Organization (WTO).
- Comprising trade ministers from all 166 member nations, it is the forum where major multilateral agreements are negotiated, trade disputes are addressed, and the future roadmap of global trade is legalized.
- Established: Under the Marrakesh Agreement (1994) which created the WTO.
- Frequency: The WTO Agreement mandates that the Ministerial Conference must meet at least once every two years.
- Successor to GATT: It replaced the informal Ministerial Meetings held under the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT).
- MC1: Singapore (1996)

International Malaria Conference 2026

- The International Malaria Conference (IMC) 2026, organised by the ICMR–National Institute of Malaria Research (ICMR–NIMR) under the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), concluded successfully in New Delhi .
- Held from 7th to 9th March 2026
- The conference was organised under the theme "Discovery, Development and Delivery: Driving Malaria Elimination and Beyond."

About Malaria

- Malaria is a life-threatening febrile disease caused by Plasmodium parasites and transmitted by infected female Anopheles mosquitoes.
- It is not contagious, but can spread through infected blood or contaminated needles.

Treatment:

- ACTs (Artemisinin-based Combination Therapies) – for P. falciparum
- Chloroquine – for P. vivax where effective
- Primaquine – prevents relapses in P. vivax and P. ovale
- Severe malaria – requires injectable treatment in hospitals.

What is the World Trade Organization e-commerce moratorium?

- The e-commerce moratorium is a global agreement among World Trade Organization members which bans customs duties being applied to electronic transmissions such as digital downloads and streaming.
- The policy was first adopted in 1998 at the WTO's Second Ministerial Conference in Geneva as part of a declaration to encourage early digital trade growth.
- It covers cross-border transmissions such as software downloads, e-books, music and movie streaming and video games.
- Originally intended to be temporary, the tariff moratorium has been renewed roughly every two years at each WTO ministerial conference, and was most recently extended for two years at the 13th conference in 2024.
- It is set to expire this month at the 14th WTO ministerial conference in Yaounde, Cameroon.

Bab el-Mandab Strait

- The Bab el-Mandab is a strategic maritime chokepoint and one of the world's most vital shipping lanes.
- It serves as the southern gateway to the Red Sea, acting as the primary link between the Indian Ocean and the Mediterranean Sea (via the Suez Canal).
- Situated between the Horn of Africa (Djibouti and Eritrea) to the southwest and the Arabian Peninsula (Yemen) to the northeast.
- Connectivity: It connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea.
- Key Point: The strait is split into two channels by Perim Island; the western channel is the primary lane for large commercial vessels.
- In Arabic, Bab el-Mandab translates to Gate of Tears.
- At its narrowest point, the strait is only about 29 kilometers (18 miles) wide, making it highly vulnerable to land-based missile attacks and naval blockades.

Kariba Dam

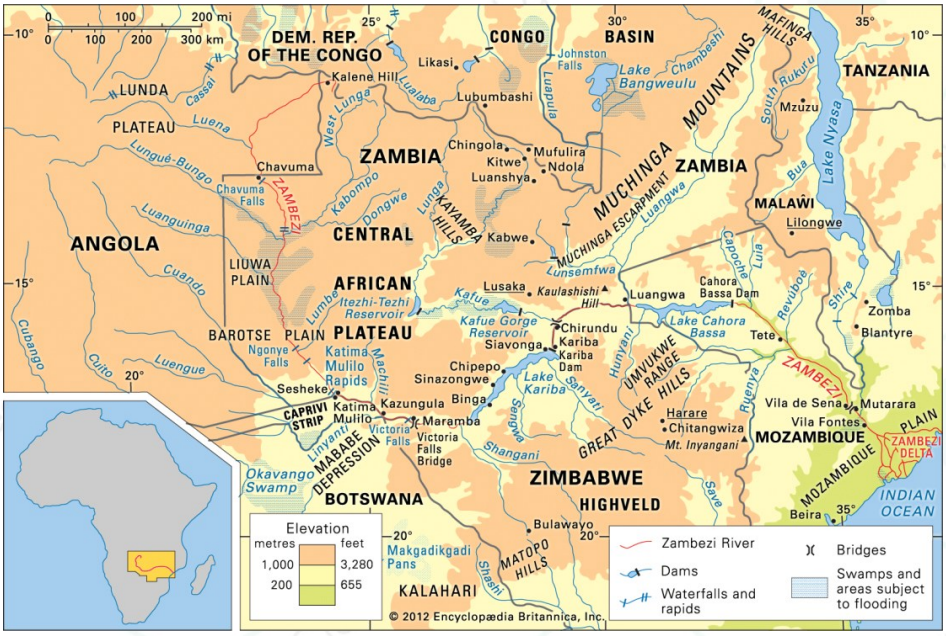
- A 500MW Floating Solar Plant being designed by Green Hybrid Power in partnership with the Intensive Energy User Group is to be installed at Kariba Dam in Zimbabwe.

Kariba Dam

- Location: It is a concrete arch dam across the Zambezi River at Kariba Gorge,
- It is on the border between Zambia and Zimbabwe.
- The construction of the dam was completed in 1959.
- The 128-metre-high double-curvature concrete arch dam provides critical electricity to both countries.
- It had created the world's largest human-made lake by volume, Lake Kariba.

About Zambezi River

- It is Africa's 4th longest river and the continent's longest east-flowing stream.
- Course
- It starts off in Angola's southern highlands, at the source of a river called the Lungwebungu.
- It flows for about 3,421 kilometers through Angola, Zambia, Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, and Mozambique before emptying into the Indian Ocean.
- Waterfalls: Victoria Falls and Chavuma Falls are on this river.
- Dams: The Cohara Bassa and Kariba Dams, two of Africa's major hydroelectric power sources, are located along the Zambezi's course



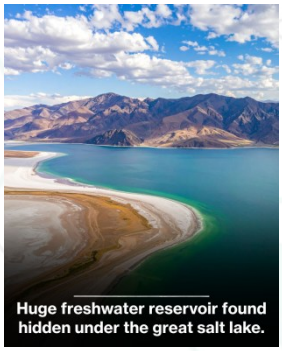
Trump signature to appear on US bills in first for sitting president, ending 165-year tradition

- US paper currency will soon bear Donald Trump's signature, the Treasury Department announced in a move that would be a first for a sitting American president and coincide with the country's 250th anniversary
- Historically, the signatures on dollar bills belong to those of the Treasurer of the United States and the secretary of the Treasury.
- To make this change, the treasurer's signature will be removed — the first time this has happened since US paper money was introduced in 1861.

The 250th Anniversary of the American Revolution

- The U.S. government has launched Task Force 250 and the Story of America video series to commemorate the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence on July 4, 2026.
- The American Revolution (1775–1783) was a transformative political and military struggle where thirteen of Great Britain's North American colonies rejected imperial rule to form the independent United States of America.
- Declaration of Independence (July 4, 1776): Drafted primarily by Thomas Jefferson, this landmark document formally announced the thirteen colonies' separation from Great Britain and grounded the new nation in Enlightenment principles.
- Treaty of Paris (1783): This formal agreement officially ended the Revolutionary War, with Great Britain finally recognizing the United States as a sovereign and independent nation.

Great Salt Lake



- Researchers at the University of Utah have found that freshwater saturates the rock and sediment beneath the Great Salt Lake to depths of up to 13,000 feet.
- Location: It is a saline lake located in northern Utah, United States.
- It is the largest inland body of salt water in the Western Hemisphere and one of the most saline inland bodies of water in the world.
- Water Source: The lake is fed by the Bear, Weber, and Jordan rivers and has no outlet.
- Like the Dead Sea, the Great Salt Lake exists within an arid environment and has chemical characteristics similar to that of the oceans.

Brazil's Proálcool Programme

- A national biofuel programme launched by Brazil in 1975 to promote ethanol as an alternative to petrol, especially after global oil shocks.
- To reduce dependence on imported crude oil and enhance energy security through large-scale adoption of ethanol-based fuels.
- Mandatory Ethanol Blending: Petrol (Gasoline C) mandated to contain ethanol (initially ~11%, later increased to ~30%), ensuring steady demand for biofuels.
- Introduction of vehicles capable of running on both petrol-ethanol blends and 100% ethanol (E100) using sensor-based technology.
- Fuel stations equipped with separate pumps for blended petrol and pure ethanol, allowing consumer choice based on price.

The Panama Canal is operating at top capacity, as the Iran war triggers more LNG vessel traffic.

- It is a manmade waterway that connects the Atlantic and Pacific oceans across the Isthmus of Panama.
- It is one of the strategic artificial waterways in the world.
- It is owned and administered by Panama, and it is 40 miles long from shoreline to shoreline.
- It was built by the United States and completed in August 1914.

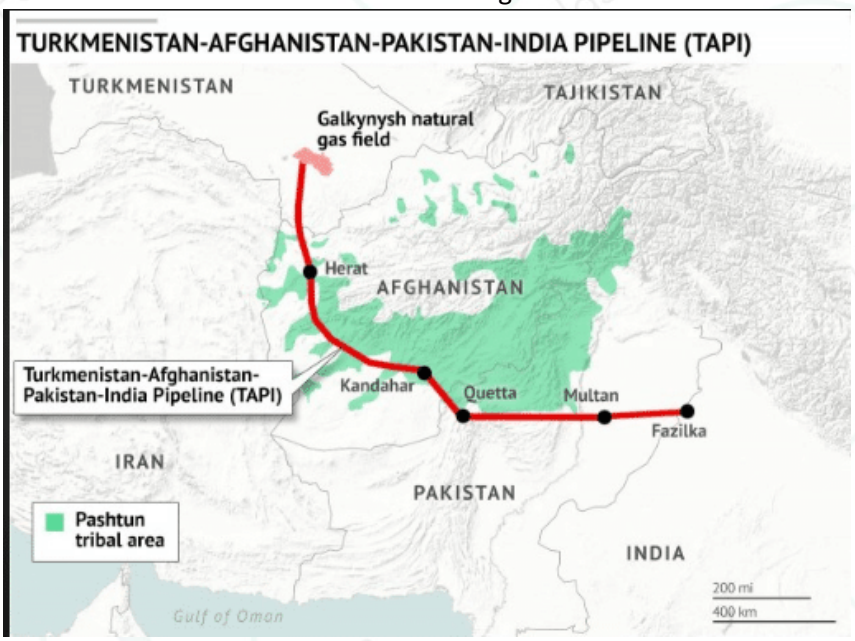
- From its opening in 1914 until 1979, the Panama Canal was controlled solely by the United States.
- In 1979, control of the canal passed to the Panama Canal Commission, a joint agency of the United States and the Republic of Panama, and complete control passed to Panama at noon on December 31, 1999.
- It uses a system of locks and elevators to take ships from one end to the other.

The Iran-Pakistan-India (IPI) Pipeline

- The ongoing West Asia crisis has disrupted energy supplies, exposing India's heavy dependence on imported gas.
- This has revived discussion on past pipeline projects like the Iran–Pakistan–India (IPI) and Turkmenistan–Afghanistan–Pakistan–India (TAPI)
- A proposed 2,775 km natural gas pipeline designed to transport gas from Iran's South Pars field to Pakistan and India.
- Often referred to as the Peace Pipeline, this project was intended to link the energy-rich Persian Gulf with the energy-starved South Asian economies.
- Conceptually originated in the 1990s; gained significant diplomatic momentum between 2004 and 2005.
- Current Status: Dormant/Recast. India effectively exited negotiations in 2007 due to U.S. sanctions (CAATSA pressure), pricing disagreements, and security fears regarding the pipeline passing through Balochistan.

Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India (TAPI) Pipeline:

- An 1,814 km trans-regional pipeline project supported by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) to bring gas from Central Asia to South Asia. Following the stalling of IPI, India shifted its focus to this Central Asian alternative, which enjoyed broader international and institutional backing.



- India officially signed the intergovernmental agreement in 2010, though the idea dates back to the mid-90s.
- Currently : Partially Active

Iran recently fired two ballistic missiles toward the joint U.S.-U.K. military base at Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean.

Diego Garcia

- Location: It is a coral atoll located in the central Indian Ocean.
- It is the largest and southernmost member of the Chagos Archipelago.
- It is part of the British Indian Ocean Territory (BIOT) and accounts for more than half the land area.
- It was discovered by the Portuguese in the early 16th century, it was for most of its history a dependency of Mauritius.
- In 1965 it was separated from Mauritius.
- In 1966, the UK leased Diego Garcia to the US to create an air and naval base. For constructing the defence installation, the inhabitants of the island were forcibly removed.

51 min ago

Iran Targeted Diego Garcia Base With Ballistic Missiles

By Shelby Holliday and Andrew Dowell

Diego Garcia, the largest island in the Chagos archipelago. U.S. Navy/Reuters HANDOUT/REUTERS

- Diego Garcia is the United States' major geostrategic and logistics support base in the Indian Ocean.
- A non-binding 2019 UN General Assembly vote demanded that Britain end its "colonial administration" of the Chagos Archipelago and that it be returned to Mauritius.

Caspian Sea

- Recently, the Israeli military confirmed that its fighter jets carried out strikes on several Iranian naval vessels in the Caspian Sea.
- It is the world's largest water body that is enclosed or bordered by land on all sides.
- It is located between Asia and Europe.
- The sea's name derives from the ancient Kaspi peoples, who once lived in Transcaucasia to the west.

- It is an endorheic basin (drainage basin without an outflow).
- Bordering countries: It is bordered by Russia and Azerbaijan on the west, Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan on the north and east, and Iran on the south.
- The composition of the water of the Caspian Sea also varies from almost fresh in the northern parts of the lake to saltier southwards.
- Three major rivers—the Volga, the Ural, and the Terek— empty into the Caspian from the north.
- Cities on Caspian: Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan, is the largest city on the Caspian. Another important city along the Caspian is Iran's Nowshahr.
- Islands: The largest are Chechen, Tyuleny, Morskoy, Kulaly, Zhiloy, and Ogurchin.

The Liberties Clause or Deviation Clause

- Amid the West Asia conflict (U.S.–Israel–Iran), major global shipping firms are invoking a 19th-century rule in maritime contracts to reroute cargo.
- This has led to containers being discharged at alternate ports, increasing costs and disrupting global supply chains.
- The Liberties Clause (often referred to as the deviation clause) is a standard provision in a Bill of Lading—the legal contract between a shipper and a carrier—that grants the shipmaster the authority to alter a planned voyage under specific circumstances.

Origin:

- These provisions trace back to 19th-century maritime law. During this era, voyages were highly exposed to unpredictable risks like piracy, wooden-ship weather damage, and regional wars, requiring shipmasters to have the legal authority to act without breaching their contracts.
- Aim: To protect the carrier from legal liability for breach of contract when external dangers prevent the ship from reaching the named port.

Sports

Khelo India Games

Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG)

- Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports announced that the first- ever Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG) will be held in Chhattisgarh from 25 March to 6 April 2026.
- The Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG) is a national-level multi-sport event dedicated exclusively to tribal athletes across India.
- It is organised under the Khelo India Scheme, a flagship programme of the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports to promote sports culture and excellence.
- Host State: Chhattisgarh
- Host Cities: Raipur, Jagdalpur and Sarguja

Sports Involved

- Medal Sports (7): Athletics, Football, Hockey, Weightlifting, Archery, Swimming, and Wrestling
- Demonstration Sports (2): Mallakhamb and Kabaddi

Key Features:

- First-ever national sporting event exclusively for tribal athletes in India.
- The official mascot Morveer symbolizes courage, pride and identity of tribal communities.

Khelo India Scheme

- It is a flagship Central Sector Scheme of the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India.
- Khelo India Games have been declared an 'Event of National Importance' in 2020 under the Sports Broadcasting Signals Act, 2007.

	GOLD	SILVER	BRONZE	TOTAL
ARMY	9	6	8	23
HIMACHAL PRADESH	6	7	1	14
HARYANA	4	1	2	7
MAHARASHTRA	3	5	4	12
LADAKH	2	5	6	13
CRPF	2	4	0	6
KARNATAKA	2	2	6	10
TELANGANA	2	2	2	6
UTTARAKHAND	2	0	1	3
JAMMU AND KASHMIR	1	1	2	4
TAMIL NADU	1	1	1	3
ITBP	1	0	1	2
KERALA	1	0	0	1
MADHYA PRADESH	1	0	0	1
ANDHRA PRADESH	0	2	0	2
CHANDIGARH	0	1	1	2
DELHI	0	0	1	1

Khelo India Winter Games 2026 medal tally

- Indian Army won the 6th edition of Khelo India Winter Games 2026 team championship title with a total of 23 medals - nine gold, six silver and eight bronze.
- The Indian Army had also won the team championships in 2024 and 2025.
- The first three editions of KIWG were hosted and won by Jammu and Kashmir in 2020, 2021 and 2023.
- Host Locations 2026 : Gulmarg (Jammu & Kashmir) and Leh (Ladakh)
- The first phase of KIWG 2026 concluded on January 26.
  The second phase was held from February 23 to 26.
- Format: The 2026 edition is designed as a two-leg competition- Ice sports in Leh
- Snow events in Gulmarg (Jammu & Kashmir).
- Sports Disciplines: The Games include ice sports such as ice hockey and ice skating.
- Figure skating has been added to the programme for the first time.
- The Mascot: "Sheen-E-She (Shan), the Snow Leopard Shan
- The Logo : Features the Indian Tricolor with a Dharmachakra (Wheel of Dharma) atop a hilltop, inspired by the Shanti Stupa in Leh

Rank	State/UT/Team	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1	Indian Army	9	6	8	23
2	Himachal Pradesh	6	7	1	14
3	Haryana	4	1	2	7
4	Maharashtra	3	5	4	12
5	Ladakh	2	5	6	13
6	CRPF	2	4	0	6
7	Karnataka	2	2	6	10
8	Telangana	2	2	2	6
9	Uttarakhand	2	0	1	3
10	Jammu and Kashmir	1	1	2	4
11	Tamil Nadu	1	1	1	3
12	ITBP	1	0	1	2
13	Kerala	1	0	0	1
13	Madhya Pradesh	1	0	0	1
15	Andhra Pradesh	0	2	0	2
16	Chandigarh	0	1	1	2
17	Delhi	0	0	1	1

National / International Championship

Kalinga Stadium Hosts National Para Athletics Championship

- Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar is set to host the National Para Athletics Championship from 19 to 21 March 2026
- The event, organised by the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI) in collaboration with the Odisha government,
- Asian Para Games 2026 will be held in Aichi– Nagoya, Japan.

MoS Raksha Khadse Announces Special Edition of ASMITA Women's Sports League

- Minister of State for Youth Affairs and Sports Raksha Nikhil Khadse has announced a special edition of the Achieving Sports Milestone by Inspiring Women Through Action (ASMITA) League in New Delhi.
- The League marks the International Women's Day on the 8th of this month.
- ASMITA is part of Khelo India's gender-neutral mission to promote sports among women through leagues and competitions.
- Started in 2021

The competitions under the ASMITA Women's Sports League 2026 will be conducted in three age categories,

- Under 13 years
- 13 to 18 years
- 18 years and above

The 24th National Para-Athletics Championships 2006 concluded at Kalinga Stadium, Bhubaneswar.

- The 24th National Para- Athletics Championships 2026 concluded at the iconic Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar.
- Haryana emerged as the overall champion, dominating the medal tally with 95 medals, including 39 gold.
- Tamil Nadu finished as runner-ups with 51 medals, whereas Gujarat came third with 30 medals.
- Host Odisha finished a respectable 5th overall

S. NO.	ATHLETE	EVENT	MEDALS
1	UDAY KAMBOJ	COMPOUND MEN'S INDIVIDUAL	GOLD
2	CHIKITHA TANIPARTHI & RAJAT CHAUHAN	COMPOUND MIXED TEAM	GOLD
3	PRATHMESH SAMADHAN JAWKAR	COMPOUND MEN INDIVIDUAL	SILVER
4	RAJ KAUR, TEJAL RAJENDRA SALVE & CHIKITHA TANIPARTHI	COMPOUND WOMEN TEAM	SILVER
5	DEVANG GUPTA, JUYEL SARKAR & SUKCHAIN SINGH	RECURVE MEN TEAM	SILVER
6	RAJAT CHAUHAN	COMPOUND MEN INDIVIDUAL	BRONZE
7	TEJAL RAJENDRA SALVE	COMPOUND WOMEN INDIVIDUAL	BRONZE
8	RIDHI	RECURVE WOMEN INDIVIDUAL	BRONZE
9	UDAY KAMBOJ, PRATHMESH S. JAWKAR & RAJAT CHAUHAN	COMPOUND MEN TEAM	BRONZE
10	RUMA BISWAS, KIRTI & RIDHI	RECURVE WOMEN TEAM	BRONZE

India wins 10 medals in archery at Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1 in Bangkok

- In archery, India won 10 medals as compound archers dominated with a mixed team gold and a clean sweep of the men's individual podium at the Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1 in Bangkok.
- The Asia Cup 2026 Bangkok archery tournament conclude on March 27.
- India finished with two gold, four silver and four bronze medals, bettering their overall tally .

1. Uday Kamboj (men's compound) - gold medal
2. Chikitha Taniparthi, Rajat Chauhan (mixed team compound) - gold medal
3. Prathamesh Jawkar (men's compound) - silver medal
4. Ridhi (women's recurve) - silver medal
5. Devaang Gupta, Sukhchain Singh, Juyel Singh (men's recurve team) - silver medal
6. Chikitha Taniparthi, Raj Kaur, Tejal Salve (women's team compound) - silver medal
7. Rajat Chauhan (men's compound) - bronze medal
8. Tejal Salve (women's compound) - bronze medal
9. Rajat Chauhan, Uday Kamboj, Rishabh Yadav (men's team compound) - bronze medal
10. Ruma Biswas, Kirti, Ridhi (women's team recurve) - bronze medal

Cricket

Jammu & Kashmir Win Ranji Trophy in Maiden Final After 67 Years

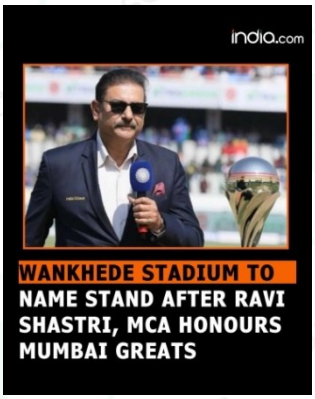
- Jammu and Kashmir created history by clinching their first- ever Ranji Trophy crown with a commanding triumph over Karnataka in Hubballi.

What is Ranji Trophy?

- The Ranji Trophy founded by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), was named after one of India's first test cricketer, Ranjitsinhji, who played for England and Sussex.
- Ranjitsinghji known as 'Father of Indian cricket', never actually played for India.
- The Ranji Trophy can be summed up as a domestic first- class cricket series played by various regional teams against one another.
- The series was announced in 1934, and the initial fixtures took place in 1934-35. Maharaja Bhupinder Singh of Patiala donated the trophy.

Other Domestic Cricket Tournaments

- Duleep Trophy
- Vijay Hazare Trophy
- Deodhar Trophy
- Irani Cup
- On completion of 25 years of the Ranji Trophy Championship, The BCCI inaugurated the Irani Trophy in 1960.
- Irani Cup sees a match annually between the Ranji Trophy champions of the preceding year and rest of Indian team.
- Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy:
- Introduced in the year 2008-09 - is a Twenty20 cricket domestic championship, among the teams from Ranji Trophy.



Wankhede Honours Ravi Shastri Names Stand After Former India Captain

- The Mumbai Cricket Association (MCA) has decided to name one of its iconic stands at the Wankhede stadium on former India player-turned-coach and commentator, Ravi Shastri.

Apart from Shastri, the MCA Apex Council has decided to honour other notable figures

- Naming the entryway gates after India player, the late Dilip Sardesai, former India women's captain Diana Edulji and former Mumbai spinner late Eknath Solkar.
- While entrance No. 3 will be called the Dilip Sardesai Gate, Gate No. 6 will be named after Eknath Solkar and No. 5 – the Diana Edulji Gate.

Indian women's cricket squad nominated for prestigious 2026 Laureus World Team of Year Award

- The Indian women's cricket squad has been nominated for the prestigious 2026 Laureus World Team of the Year Award following their maiden World Cup title triumph.
- They are the first women's cricket team to receive this nomination, a recognition for their exceptional performance in the ICC Women's World Cup 2025, including the highest successful run chase in women's ODI history in a semi-final win against Australia.
- The Harmanpreet Kaur-led women's team is nominated alongside major teams like the England Women's football team, the French football league's Paris Saint-Germain, and McLaren Formula One.
- The women's team joins a select group of Indian athletes nominated for the main Laureus categories, including Vinesh Phogat, Neeraj Chopra, and Rishabh Pant.

India Wins Third ICC Men's T20 World Cup Title

- India defeated New Zealand by 96 runs in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2026 final at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad on 8th March, thus becoming the first team to successfully defend their World T20 crown.
- India also became the first team in history to win a T20 World Cup at home.
- This is India's record-extending third T20 World Cup title.
- Jasprit Bumrah became the Player of the Match
- Sanju Samson won the Player of the tournament.

Full list of T20 World Cup winners and runners-up

EDITION	HOST NATION	WINNERS	RUNNER-UPS
2007	South Africa	India	Pakistan
2009	England	Pakistan	Sri Lanka
2010	West Indies	England	Australia
2012	Sri Lanka	West Indies	Sri Lanka
2014	Bangladesh	Sri Lanka	India
2016	India	West Indies	England
2021	UAE & Oman	Australia	New Zealand
2022	Australia	England	Pakistan
2024	USA & West Indies	India	South Africa
2026	India	India	New Zealand
EDITION	HOST NATION	WINNERS	RUNNER-UPS
2007	South Africa	India	Pakistan

Indian sportsperson Smriti Mandhana has been honoured with a Barbie doll of her own, making history as the first woman cricketer to receive this tribute.

Virat Kohli becomes first batter in IPL history to cross 4000 runs in run chases

- Indian stalwart Virat Kohli etched his name into the record books by becoming the first batter in the history of the Indian Premier League to cross 4000 runs in run chases.
- The right-handed batter achieved this historic feat during the IPL 2026 opener between the defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) and the Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru
- Kohli also surpassed former Pakistan batter Shoaib Malik to become the sixth-highest run-getter in T20 cricket.

Sahibzada Farhan Wins ICC Award

- Pakistan opener Sahibzada Farhan has been named the ICC Player of the Month for February 2026
- Indian cricket team pacer Arundhati Reddy was named the women's ICC Player of the Month for February 2026

Football

Sabrina Wittmann Becomes Germany's First Female Men's Team Coach

- Sabrina Wittmann has made history in German football as the first woman to manage a professional men's football team in the country.
- Initially appointed as an interim coach in 2024

Football for Schools (F4S) Programme

- Union Minister of State for Education & Development of North Eastern Region distributed football at PM SHRI Kendriya Vidyalaya, Dakshin Dinajpur, West Bengal, as part of the Football for Schools (F4S) initiative.
- It is run by Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) in collaboration with UNESCO.
- Aim: It aims to contribute to the education, development and empowerment of around 700 million children.
- Objective: It seeks to make football more accessible to both boys and girls around the world by incorporating football activities into the education system, in partnership with relevant authorities and stakeholders.

Argentina's Lionel Messi became the second men's football player in history to score 900 career goals in official matches, joining Cristiano Ronaldo in elite company.

Tennis

Jannik Sinner beats Daniil Medvedev to win BNP Paribas Open in Indian Wells

- Jannik Sinner claimed his first Indian Wells Open title in the men's singles final
- Aryna Sabalenka won the 2026 Indian Wells women's singles title by defeating Elena Rybakina
- Kateřina Siniaková and Taylor Townsend won the 2026 Indian Wells women's doubles title.
- Guido Andreozzi and Manuel Guinard won the 2026 Indian Wells men's doubles final.
- Belinda Bencic and Flavio Cobolli won the 2026 Indian Wells Mixed Doubles

Sabalenka sinks Gauff to win second straight Miami Open title

- Aryna Sabalenka successfully defended her women's singles title at the 2026 Miami Open , dispatching U.S. tennis star Coco Gauff .
- She became only the fifth woman to achieve the Sunshine Double.
- She became the first player since Australia's Ashleigh Barty to win the tournament back-to-back, and the first since Poland's Iga Swiatek to achieve the elusive "Sunshine Double" – a superlative awarded to players who win Indian Wells and the Miami Open in the same year.
- Jannik Sinner won the 2026 Miami Open men'ssingles title, defeating Jiří Lehečka .
- Jannik Sinner (2026) became the 8th man to complete the Sunshine Double and the first to do so since Roger Federer in 2017.

Badminton

Sikkim to Host Junior National Badminton Championship 2026

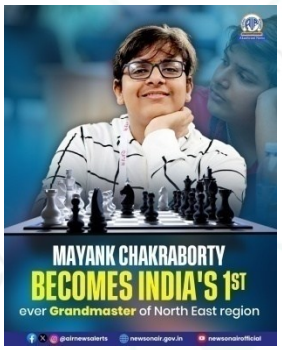
- Sikkim has been selected as the host venue for the 49th Yonex Sunrise Junior National Badminton Championship (Individual & Team – U-19) 2026.
- The tournament is scheduled to be held from 14th to 21st November.

Table tennis

Table tennis: Manav, Yashaswini win maiden National titles

- Manav Thakkar and Yashaswini Ghorpade, both representing the Petroleum Sports Promotion Board (PSPB), clinched their maiden men's and women's singles titles
- At the 87th Senior National Table Tennis Championship.
- Mixed Doubles: Ankur Bhattacharjee (WB) & Suhana Saini (Har)

Chess



Mayank Chakraborty becomes India's 94th and first ever Grandmaster from North East region

- Mayank Chakraborty became India's 94th chess Grandmaster and the first ever to hail from the country's North East region.
- In 2023, he became just the second person from the North East to become an International Master.
- Shahil Dey, also from Assam, became the region's first International Master in 2021 and a couple of years later, Chakraborty too reached there

Grand Prix

Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) won the 2026 Chinese Grand Prix

George Russell wins Australian Grand Prix 2026

Marco Bezzecchi won the 2026 United States Grand Prix

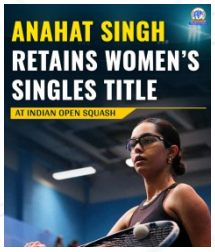
Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes won the Japanese Grand Prix

- The 19-year-old Italian became the youngest driver in Formula One history to lead the world championship standings.

Squash

Squash: Defending champion Anahat Singh wins Women's Singles title at Indian Open in Mumbai

- In Squash, top seed and defending champion Anahat Singh won the Women's Singles title.
- While Abhay Singh clinched the Men's Singles at the Indian Open 2026 in Mumbai



Basketball

LeBron James breaks record for most NBA games played

- LeBron James has played more games than any player in National Basketball Association history.
- He played his 1,612th game, which broke the old record.
- The previous record (1,611 games) was held by Robert Parish since 1997.

Athletics

Asian weightlifting championships postponed

- The Asian weightlifting championships, scheduled to be held in Gandhinagar from April 1 to 10, was postponed due to the ongoing conflict in the Middle East and Gulf region.
- The competition will now take place from May 12 to 17.

India to host a top international archery competition for the first time in 22 years

- India is set to host a Asian Archery Championships for the first time in 22 years with Delhi being awarded the second leg of the Asia Cup in 2027,
- First Leg: Bangkok, Thailand
- The country last staged a major international archery tournament when the Asian Archery Championships were held in Delhi in 2005.
- Ahmedabad will host the Asian Para Archery Championships in September this year.
- Kolkata will also get to stage an international competition after several years as it has been awarded the South Asian Archery Championships 2026.
- The city last hosted an international archery event in 2009 when it staged the Asian Archery Grand Prix 2009.

India Tops Medal Table at World Para Athletics Grand Prix 2026 New Delhi with 208 Medals

- India finished on top of the medal standings at the World Para Athletics Grand Prix 2026 New Delhi leg, securing 208 medals as the three-day competition concluded at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium
- The host nation (India) won 75 gold, 69 silver and 64 bronze medals.
- Russia finished second with 35 medals, while Bosnia and Herzegovina placed third with three.
- Around 257 athletes from eight nations - India, Russia, Nepal, Bhutan, Hong Kong China, Serbia, Bosnia and Egypt - took part in the World Para Athletics Grand Prix 2026 New Delhi.
- The New Delhi leg was the second stop of the 13th Grand Prix season, offering key international classification opportunities ahead of the 2026 World Para Athletics Championships and the 2028 Los Angeles Paralympics.

Chandrika Pujari Wins Gold at World Boxing Futures Cup 2026 as India Bags Five Medals

- Indian boxers concluded their World Boxing Futures Cup 2026 campaign in Bangkok, Thailand, with five medals - one gold, three silver and one bronze.
- Held in Bangkok from March 8 to 15
- Gold medal: Chandrika Pujari (women's 51kg)
- Silver medal: Gunjan (women's 48kg)
- Silver medal: Joyshree Devi (women's 54kg)
- Silver medal: Ambekar Meetei (men's 50kg)
- Bronze medal: Radhamani Longjam (women's 57kg)

Miscellaneous

Shrishti Sharma Sets Fastest 50m Limbo Skating World Record

- Indian roller skater Shrishti Dharmendra Sharma has created history by setting a new Guinness World Record in limbo skating.
- She achieved the fastest time to skate under descending poles over a distance of 50 metres in just 7.46 seconds.
- Limbo skating is a roller skating discipline where athletes glide under very low horizontal bars.

IISc professor becomes second Indian woman to summit world's highest volcanic peak

- Arpita Patra, professor at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) has summited the Nevado Ojos del Salado, which is the highest volcanic peak in the world and the highest mountain in Chile.
- By summitting the Nevado Ojos del Salado, which is 6,893 meters,
- Became the second Indian woman to achieve this feat.
- Ojos del Salado, located deep in the Atacama Desert
- Prior to this, she had climbed the highest volcanic peaks of four continents, which are Mt. Kilimanjaro (5,895 meters) in Africa, Mt. Elbrus (5,642 meters) in Europe, Mt. Giluwe (4,367 meters) in Oceania, and Pico de Orizaba (5,636 meters) in North America.

Anant Rana Makes History Completing Full Ironman New Zealand in 11h 50m

- Athlete Anant Rana created history by completing the 'Full Ironman New Zealand' triathlon held in Taupo, New Zealand in 11 hours and 50 minutes, finishing swimming, cycling and the marathon run.
- The Thirty-three-year-old resident of Sonari in Jamshedpur, Jharkhand, associated with the Tata Steel Adventure Foundation, completed 3.8 kilometres of swimming, 180 kilometres of cycling and a 42-kilometre run well within the stipulated 17-hour time limit.

News in short

- Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports, Dr Mansukh Mandaviya unveiled the logo of India's pioneering sporting initiative, the world's first franchise-based Road Cycling League, named Cycling League of India.

Olympic champion Cameron McEvoy sets new 50 metre freestyle world record

- Olympic and world champion swimmer Cameron McEvoy has broken the men's 50-meter freestyle world record which had stood for 17 years.
- The 31-year-old Australian posted a time of 20.88 seconds at the China Open in Shenzhen, taking 0.03 second off Brazilian César Cielo's previous mark.
- Cielo set his world record of 20.91 during swimming's so-called "super suit" era in 2009.

Bhubaneswar to host World Indoors in 2028

- India will be hosting the 2028 World Indoor Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar, Odisha at the Kalinga Indoor Athletics Stadium, Athletics Federation of India confirmed
- Completed in 2024, Kalinga Indoor Athletics Stadium, is the largest indoor athletics stadium in South Asia.

SRY Gene Screening

- The International Olympic Committee (IOC) announced a seismic policy change mandating SRY gene screening for all female athletes in international elite sports.
- This decision effectively bans transgender women and many DSD (Differences in Sex Development) athletes from female categories.
- SRY stands for 'Sex-determining Region Y'. It is a specific segment of DNA usually found on the Y chromosome.
- This gene acts as a biological master switch that triggers the development of testes and the production of male levels of testosterone, leading to male physical development.
- Developed By: The SRY gene was first discovered in 1990 by Professor Andrew Sinclair.
- The primary objective is to protect the female category in elite sports.
- The IOC aims to ensure that athletes competing in the female category do not have the physiological advantages associated with male puberty and male chromosomal development, such as increased bone density and explosive muscle power.
- Voluntary but Mandatory for Entry: Athletes can refuse the test, but refusal results in immediate disqualification from IOC-sanctioned events.

How it Works?

- Sample Collection: The athlete provides a simple saliva sample or a cheek swab at a certified diagnostic lab.
- DNA Analysis: The lab analyzes the sample to detect the presence or absence of the SRY gene.
- Verification: The results are submitted to the relevant international sports body. If negative, the athlete is permanently cleared for the female category.

Banking

Sixteenth Finance Commission — misses and concerns

C. Rangarajan

is a former Governor of the Reserve Bank of India and Chairman of the Twelfth Finance Commission

D.K. Srivastava

is Chief Policy Adviser, EY India, a former Director of the Madras School of Economics and Member, Twelfth Finance Commission

Evaluating the federal implications of the Sixteenth Finance Commission recommend-ations

The Sixteenth Finance Commission had significant flexibility in determining its approach and methodology, as its terms of reference followed directly from constitutional provisions, unlike earlier commissions that operated under detailed central directives. This Commission, as before, addressed the two key dimensions of fiscal transfers – namely the vertical and the horizontal.

The vertical dimension

The Commission took note of the increase in the share of States in the divisible pool of central taxes from 32% to 42% by the Fourteenth Finance Commission. The Fourteenth Finance Commission had justified it on account of a discontinuation of State plan grants, amounting to only 3% of the divisible pool of central taxes at the time of transition. The subsequent reduction to 41% was due to the change in the status of Jammu and Kashmir. The Sixteenth Finance Commission noted the Centre's concern about the reduction in its fiscal space. The Centre had responded to this substantial increase in the share of states by the Fourteenth Finance Commission by, first, increasing the non-shareable cesses and surcharges, second, reducing its share in the financing of centrally sponsored schemes and third, not accepting sector-specific/State-specific grants recommended by the Fifteenth Finance Commission. In the end, however, the Sixteenth Finance Commission retained the States' share at 41%, imparting to it a kind of semi-permanence.

The Sixteenth Finance Commission makes no recommendations regarding the non-shareable cesses and surcharges which, by their very nature, should be limited and levied for finite periods. These should be earmarked for specific purposes and not merged with the Centre's general funds. Instead, Sixteenth Finance Commission recommended a 'grand bargain' (paragraph 7.67) between the Centre and States saying that 'States would agree to a smaller share in the resulting larger divisible pool, with no loss of revenues to either side' provided the Centre agreed to merge a large part of the cesses and surcharges in the regular taxes.

The Commission did not take into account its constitutional duty as enumerated in Articles 270 and 280 for objectively determining the share of States in the shareable pool of central taxes while making its observations on the cesses and surcharges. It would have been better had the Commission at least pointed out to the Centre that the steep increase in cesses and surcharges was not warranted and not in the spirit of the Constitution. Further, the Commission chose to discontinue the revenue deficit grants and did not recommend any State and sector specific grants. This became a route to lower the share of States in the Centre's revenue receipts as compared to the Fifteenth Finance Commission.

The average effective transfers covering tax devolution and Finance Commission grants to the States as a percentage of the Centre's pre-transfer gross revenue receipts were 27.0%, 27.2% and 28.3%, respectively during the Finance Commission periods (11, 12, 13). This share increased sharply to 35.6% during the Fourteenth Finance Commission period. In the Fifteenth Finance Commission period, covering the years 2020-21 to 2024-25, this share came down marginally to 34.4%, still considerably higher than those of the Eleventh and Thirteenth Finance Commission periods. This steep increase in resources transferred as a proportion of gross revenue receipts of the Centre should not be overlooked.

Looking at the first year of the Sixteenth Finance Commission's award period, 2026-27, this ratio is 32.7% as per the Centre's budget estimates. The Sixteenth Finance Commission's projections for later years may prove to be overestimates since the 2026-27 nominal GDP growth, assumed at 11%, is higher than the Budget estimate of 10%. The Commission also did not factor in the revenue reducing effect of the major Goods and Services Tax (GST) reforms undertaken in September 2025, while the Commission was still in session.

Horizontal dimension

The Sixteenth Finance Commission introduced a new criterion of contribution to reflect an efficiency consideration. But it measured it through the share of a State's Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) in an all-State GSDP.

There is a need, however, to differentiate the efficiency of the production system from that of the fiscal system. In the production system, the inter-State distribution of GSDP depends on many factors which includes the inter-State movement of financial and human resources. It largely depends on market forces which tend to lead to a concentration of productive capital stock in a limited number of States. Human resources also move from less developed to the more developed States.

This change involved using GSDP in two opposite ways. In the income distance formula, the lower the per-capita GSDP of a State, the higher the per-capita share of that State. In the contribution criterion, the higher the per-capita GSDP of a State, the higher is its share. However, the Commission did not finally use the GSDP. Instead, it used its square root. This was meant to reduce the excessive effects of using GSDP to reflect contribution on some States.

In the devolution formula, the weights of some of the other criteria have also been changed. These are purely judgemental. Dropping the tax effort/fiscal discipline criterion, which was a fiscal efficiency criterion is not consistent with the Commission's own narrative.

Losses and gains

Consequently, the main States that have lost on account of the Sixteenth Finance Commission devolution scheme as compared to the Fifteenth Finance Commission are Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. The other group of losing States are Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Manipur, Nagaland, Tripura, Sikkim, and Goa (the north-east or extremely small States). The gain by other richer States has not been uniform.

Ideally, the losses of some States could have been mitigated through normatively determined revenue gap grants. Devolution is not enough to capture the finer details of cost and need differentials of India's highly differentiated States. Further, if a Finance Commission changes the tax devolution formulae, then the consequential loss of some of the States could be neutralised by the revenue gap grants.

In fact, Article 275 provides an important mode of fiscal transfers for the consideration of State-specific 'needs'. It should not be confused with revenue deficits. Needs can be estimated in order to equalise standards of critical services such as health and education.

This would have facilitated accommodating the performance argument of the richer States while still promoting the equalisation objective. Even if there are difficulties in estimating revenue gap grants since it involves normative assessment of States' needs and resources, the Sixteenth Finance Commission need not have taken the shortcut of dropping these altogether. While ad hoc State-specific grants are not appropriate, equalisation grants still have a place.

The views expressed are personal

Sixteenth Finance Commission — Misses and Concerns

- The Sixteenth Finance Commission (16th FC), chaired by Dr. Arvind Panagariya, submitted its final report for the period 2026–31.
- The Finance Commission is a constitutional body established under Article 280 to define the financial relations between the Union and the States.
- The 16th FC's mandate was to recommend the vertical share of taxes for states and the horizontal formula to distribute those funds among them for the five-year award period starting April 1, 2026.

Recommendations of the 16th FC:

- Vertical Devolution (41%): The Commission recommended retaining the states' share in the divisible pool of central taxes at 41%, maintaining the status quo from the 15th FC.
- Horizontal Devolution Formula: A new formula was introduced with a 10% weightage for Contribution to GDP (measured by the square root of GSDP), replacing the previous Tax Effort criterion.
- Local Body Grants (₹7.9 Lakh Crore): Substantial funds were allocated for rural and urban local bodies, with 80% as basic grants and 20% as performance-linked grants.
- Disaster Management: A corpus of ₹2.04 Lakh Crore was recommended for State Disaster Relief and Mitigation Funds, with a 75:25 cost-sharing ratio (90:10 for Himalayan/NE states).
- Urbanisation Premium: A unique ₹10,000 Crore grant was proposed to incentivise the merger of peri-urban villages into larger urban local bodies.

- Fiscal Deficit Targets: The Commission recommended that the Centre reduce its deficit to 3.5% of GDP by 2030-31, while States must strictly adhere to a 3% GSDP cap.
- Cesses and Surcharges: The Commission failed to cap non-shareable cesses and surcharges, which now account for nearly 20% of the Centre's gross tax revenue, effectively reducing the actual money available for states.
- End of Revenue Deficit Grants: For the first time, the FC discontinued Article 275 revenue deficit grants, leaving states with high debt (like Himachal Pradesh and Punjab) in a precarious fiscal debt spiral.
- Overestimation of Growth: Critics argue the projected 32.7% effective transfer ratio for 2026-27 is based on an optimistic 11% nominal GDP growth, which may not materialize.
- GST Reform Impact: The 16th FC did not factor in the revenue-reducing effects of the September 2025 GST rate cuts (which moved most 12% and 28% items into 5% and 18% slabs).
- Horizontal Inequity: The use of GSDP Contribution (10%) favors industrially advanced richer states, while the reduction in weight for Income Distance may hurt poorer states like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh.

The new Income Tax rules

- The new Income-tax Act, 2025 set to be enforced from April 1, the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has come out with a new set of rules, Income-tax Rules, 2026, to align with it.
- A series of changes have been introduced in the forms, disclosures, and deductions for salaried employees, with some experts pointing out that the old tax regime could carry more incentives for middle-income salary earners vis-à-vis the new regime under Section 202 under I-T Act, 2025.

PAN is now needed for:

- **Cash Transactions:**
  Cash deposits/withdrawals ≥ ₹10 lakh/year (aggregate) in one or more accounts
  (Earlier: only deposits > ₹50,000/day required PAN)
- **Motor Vehicles:**
  Purchase of vehicles ≥ ₹5 lakh (including two-wheelers) (Earlier: PAN not required for two-wheelers)
- **Hotels/Events:**
  Payments > ₹1 lakh (hotel, restaurant, banquet, event management)
  (Earlier: threshold was ₹50,000)
- **Immovable Property:**
  Transactions (purchase/sale/gift/JDA) > ₹20 lakh (Earlier: ₹10 lakh)

For individuals, senior citizens:

- A single unified challan-cum-statement to replace separate forms for Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) on property, rent, contractors and crypto assets, with filing to be done using PAN (Permanent Account Number) of the deductor than TAN (Tax Deduction and Collection Account Number).
- TDS needs to be deducted on rent payment of Rs 50,000 for a month, on transfer of immovable property of Rs 50 lakh or more, on professional or contract or commission brokerage payments of Rs 50 lakh and transfer of virtual digital assets (no monetary limit).
- Provisions for Minimum Alternate Tax (MAT) and Alternate Minimum Tax (AMT) have now been separated into two distinct sub-sections, improving clarity.
- Taxpayers now have the option to update their returns up to four years from the end of the relevant assessment year, allowing mistakes to be corrected without penalty or extra tax liability.
- Additionally, the period for which assessments can be reopened has been reduced to five years, ensuring greater certainty for taxpayers and preventing long-drawn scrutiny

Introduction of "Tax Year"

- A new concept of "tax year", defined as April 1 to March 31, has been introduced.

The law has been significantly streamlined:

- Sections reduced from 819 (1961 Act) to 536.
- Chapters reduced from 47 to 23.
- Word count halved from 5.12 lakh to 2.6 lakh.

- Tables and formulae increased to provide clarity (57 tables, 46 formulae)
- Table showing how you can the new tax rules, 2026 help you save income tax due to meal card/voucher/ coupon
- Salary Income (CTC) Level: Rs 15 lakh, Rs 20 lakh, Rs 25 lakh and Rs 30 lakh

Particulars	Rs 15 lakh	Rs 20 lakh	Rs 25 lakh	Rs 30 lakh
Basic	7,50,000	10,00,000	12,50,000	15,00,000
HRA (assumed to be fully exempt under Old Tax Regime)	3,75,000	5,00,000	6,25,000	7,50,000
Children Education Allowance (assumed to be fully exempt under Old Tax Regime)	72,000	72,000	72,000	72,000
Food Coupon (assumed to be fully exempt under both the Tax Regimes)	1,05,600	1,05,600	1,05,600	1,05,600
Special Allowance	1,97,400	3,22,400	4,47,400	5,72,400
Taxable Income as per Old Tax Regime (assuming no deduction other than Standard deduction)	8,97,400	12,72,400	1,647,400	20,22,400
Tax along with Education Cess as per Old Tax Regime after considering Rebate u/s 87A	**95,659**	**2,01,989**	**318,989**	**4,35,989**
Taxable Income as per New Tax Regime (assuming no deduction other than Standard deduction)	13,19,400	18,19,400	23,19,400	28,19,400
Tax along with Education Cess as per New Tax Regime after considering Rebate u/s 87A	**81,026**	**1,70,435**	**2,91,044**	**4,42,853**

Gruh Sugam Portal

- The National Housing Bank (NHB) has launched the Gruh Sugam portal, a specialized digital lending platform designed for Defense, Paramilitary, and Government personnel.
- It is a dedicated digital bridge between government employees and lending institutions.
- The portal functions as an aggregator where employees can register their home loan requirements, receive multiple competitive offers from banks, and complete the application process digitally through their respective administrative units.

Organisation Involved:

- The project is spearheaded by the National Housing Bank (NHB), which is the apex regulatory body for housing finance in India under the Government of India.

About National Housing Bank

- It is an apex agency established to promote housing finance companies (HFCs) in India.
- It is an All-India Financial Institution (AIFI) wholly owned by the Government of India (GoI).
- NHB supervises HFCs, while regulation of HFCs is with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).
- NHB is wholly owned by the GoI post the 24 April 2019 notification of RBI

HPSC HCS PRELIMS 2026 CRASH COURSE
RECORDED + LIVE BATCH
70 Days
200+ Classes
With Notes, PYQs & Tests
Starts : 2 Feb
Ends : 14 April
Subjects
CSAT PAPER
Complete Haryana GK
General & Haryana Current Affairs
Geography, Polity
History, Economics
Science, Static GK

72nd BPSC PRELIMS 2026 CRASH COURSE
RECORDED + LIVE BATCH
70 Days
200+ Classes
With Notes, PYQs & Tests
Starts : 23 March
Ends: 01 June
Subjects
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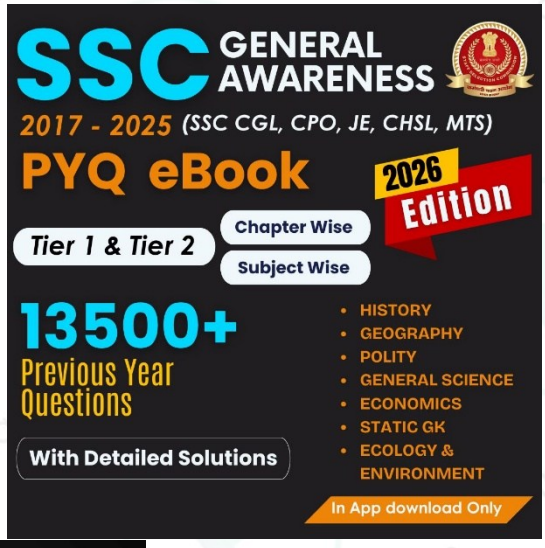
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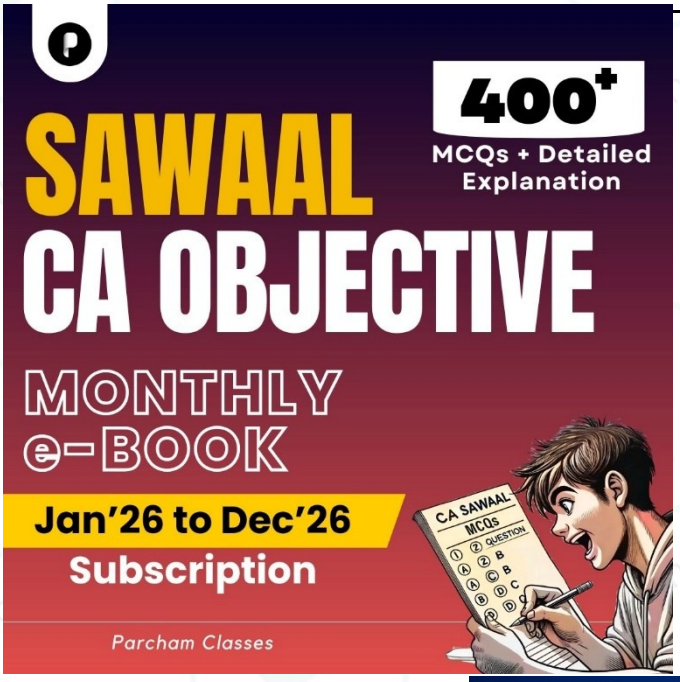
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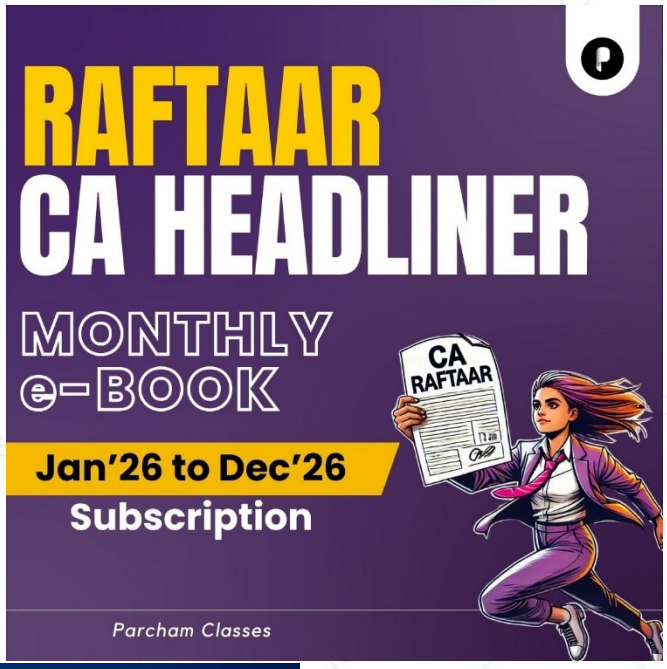
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